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EXPRESS investigation

Delhi's Killer Dust

Dust is one villain in Delhi's pollution story, its levels don't depend on weather and it makes up over a third of the fine particles that clog lungs, inflame blood vessels. The good news is it can be controlled. The bad news, as an investigation by *The Indian Express* of a year's civic records reveals, the city's fleet of sweeping machines is 80% short — and what exists barely scrapes the surface



A Mechanical Road Sweeping Machine in Govindpuri. Just five of the 52 designated MRS routes account for nearly 18% of their total running and sweeping distance. TASHI TOBGYAL

Sophiya Mathew, Drishti Jain & Kaunain Sheriff M
New Delhi, May 24

AS POLLUTION starts tightening its grip around the national capital again, triggering Stage I of the city's Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), the only thing more predictable than Delhi's toxic air is the discourse around it. Every talking head points to the weather, the geography, the cars. What few talk about is where all the agencies have dropped the ball. It's that four-letter word in the pollution story: dust.

Dust is what accounts for PM 10 and PM 2.5 — the fine, lethal particulate matter that clogs lungs and sneaks into the bloodstream. Dust is what remains in the air, irrespective of weather. And unlike the weather, it is the one villain most easy to fix.

On the ground, however, the reality is different.

The *Indian Express* investigated one year's records, March 2025 to March 2026, of daily movement logs of Delhi's key weapon against dust, the Mechanical Road Sweeping Machine (MRS). Using geospatial mapping and route-level analysis, a dashboard was created to track

EXPLAINED

THE 4-LETTER WORD THAT EVERYONE IN DELHI NEEDS TO KNOW

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52 geo-tagged MRSs managed by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) — the largest fleet in the capital — across 12 months. The investigation, based on coverage, frequency and concentration of mechanised sweeping across seasons and municipal zones, found that the capital's clean-up infrastructure barely scrubbed the city's surface.

Indeed, the investigation found, these machines cover a fraction of the city, with a fleet that is vastly underpowered: just 76 in all, including 52 run by the MCD, during a majority of the period examined by *The Indian Express*. This is a shortfall of 429 machines from the 505 recommended by the Centre to the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM).

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Was your neighbourhood dusted? Track cleaner on this dashboard

Sophiya Mathew, Drishti Jain & Shijith P Kunhittu
New Delhi, May 24

HOW MUCH of Delhi is covered by Mechanical Road Sweeping Machines (MRS)? Which roads are covered, which are missed? Most importantly, is your ward covered?

The answers are now at your fingertips — on a new, interactive dashboard available ex-

clusively at www.indianexpress.com. The dashboard covers all 12 zones of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) across 250 wards.

Here's how the dashboard was made:

- MRS routes across 52 weeks, available on the MCD's live portal, were plotted on the official map of Delhi using Google Earth.



SCAN THE QR CODE TO ACCESS THE DASHBOARD

This was a process involving many layers: geo-coordinates, time-stamps, vehicle IDs, route IDs and GPS points.

- In the next step, route-level data points — distance travelled, duration, and vehicle speed — were analysed and integrated to build a measurable dataset.

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Inside a night shift that sweeps the capital: 'It feels like I have fainted'

Sophiya Mathew & Drishti Jain
New Delhi, May 24

SHORTLY AFTER nightfall, under dim yellow streetlights, a convoy of mechanical road-sweeping machines rolls out of a small parking dock next to Delhi's iconic Jawaharlal

MORE INSIDE PAGE 5
NEW FLEET, ROUTES, APP: MCD'S PLAN TO CLEAN UP ITS ACT

Nehru Stadium. Seven of them line up, engines idling, before heading out to clear road dust

across key roads in the capital's Central Zone for the night.

This is the largest such fleet under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) in any single zone. These machines form the capital's last line of defence in its desperate fight against dust, one of the biggest

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Bengal to set up 'holding centres' for illegal Bangla immigrants, Rohingya

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, May 24

THE WEST Bengal government has ordered the setting up of "holding centres" across all 23 districts in the state for Bangladesh nationals and Rohingya people found to be illegally staying in the country, ahead of their deportation.

The state's Home and Hill Affairs Department issued the

order, dated May 23, to all District Magistrates and copied it to superintendents of police, all police commissionerates, the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), as well as the West Bengal DG and IGPs.

The order included the "procedure to be followed for deportation of Bangladeshi/Rohingya apprehended for staying illegally in this country".

"In this connection, it is re-

quested to take initiative/appropriate action for setting up of Holding Centres in the district for apprehended foreigners as well as for the released foreign prisoners awaiting deportation/repatriation in accordance with MHA (Union Ministry of Home Affairs) guidelines...", the order said.

All districts, especially in border areas, have been put on

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BJP wins Falta by over 1 lakh votes; CPM second, TMC forfeits deposit

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, May 24

THE BJP on Sunday swept the repoll in West Bengal's Falta Assembly seat with a victory margin of 1.09 lakh votes. The Trinamool Congress (TMC) slipped to fourth place in its former stronghold and forfeited its deposit after its candidate did not put up a fight and announced his "withdrawal"



BJP supporters celebrate the repoll win in Falta. EXPRESS

from the contest on the last day of campaign. The CPI(M) finished second.

Falta is part of TMC second-in-command Abhishek Banerjee's Diamond Harbour Lok Sabha constituency and had provided him a lead of 1.68 lakh votes in the 2024 parliamentary elections. The party's vote-share in Falta was 89%, which has come down to 3.7% this time.

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'I don't see India-Pakistan players shaking hands, as of now... our tradition is namaste'
MITHUN MANHAS
BCCI PRESIDENT
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SOME BUMPS AS U.S. MODERNISING MIGRATION SYSTEM, TRADE AGREEMENT TO BE SIGNED SOON, SAYS RUBIO

US-India strategic alliance, global influence: Rubio

Asked about ties with Pakistan, US Secy of State says: We work at tactical level

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 24

SEEKING TO repair ties between India and the United States — which he described as a "strategic alliance between two countries that have global influence and the ability to influence global events" — visiting US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Sunday addressed New Delhi's concerns on challenges over the past year — from trade tariffs to visa restrictions and changes in immigration policies to Washington's close ties with Pakistan's military leadership.

Rubio underlined that the changes "whether trade tariffs or visa curbs" were not targeted at India, but were being applied globally. Saying that the US was in the process of "modernising" its "migration system", he said there may be "bumps" during this period of transition, but the "destination" would be a more efficient system. He also said the two sides were "on the verge" of winding up a trade agreement that would be "beneficial to both" and "sustainable".

Addressing a press conference with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Rubio

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US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with Minister of External Affairs S Jaishankar in New Delhi, Sunday. AP

India can count on me 100%... anything India wants, they get: Trump

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 24

JOINING AN event hosted by the US Embassy here to celebrate the 250th anniversary of America's Independence Day, US President Donald Trump, in a live phone call on Sunday, assured his "100 per cent" support to India.

"I love India... I love the Prime Minister. (Narendra) Modi is great. He's my friend, and I just want to say a very, very good evening to everybody this

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



*Mother Teresa's Nobel Peace Medal

India finalises request letter for 114 Rafales, to send it to France soon

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 24

INDIA HAS finalised the Letter of Request (LoR) for the procurement of 114 Rafale fighter jets for the IAF and is expected to send it to France "very soon", within the "next few weeks", *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Around 90 jets from this set of 114 are to be manufactured in India through a collaboration between the French manufacturer Dassault Aviation and an Indian company, while the rest will arrive in fly-away condition.

Senior officials said that soon after France responds to the LoR, India will formalise the Request for Proposal (RFP) for acquisition.

An LoR is a formal government-to-government document used to initiate such procurement, under the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) or Intergovernmental Agreement (IGA) route, outlining the capabilities, quantities and technical

requirements needed.

In such procurements, the Defence Acquisition Council (DAC) first grants its approval, following which the LoR is issued. Once the foreign government responds, mentioning the price, availability and logistical support, negotiations take place between the two sides. The Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) has to grant approval before the final contract is signed.

In this case, the LoR came three months after the DAC cleared the long-awaited proposal to buy the Rafales under an inter-governmental deal. IAF Chief Air Chief Marshal AP Singh is scheduled to visit France early next month before Prime Minister Narendra Modi visits later in June.

The IAF already operates 36 Rafales, and the Navy is set to induct 26 Rafale M aircraft for carrier operations over the next few years. The procurement of additional Rafales will help

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NATION

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UCC WON'T APPLY TO TRIBALS: SHAH

Happening today

- UNION MINISTER Piyush Goyal will visit Canada to advance talks on the India-Canada Comprehensive Economic & Partnership Agreement.

Alok Singh
New Delhi, May 24

FOR THE last few years, Arvind Gupta would spend hours on stock trading sites, using the income to help support his young family. A salesman at a rexine manufacturing and import company, Gupta was no novice: having started investing in financial markets five years ago, he thought he knew how to spot an investment fraud.

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anchor

Yet, 28-year-old Gupta counts himself lucky, since he was able to escape "relatively lightly". He also helped bust an elaborate fake trading racket.

In May, the Delhi Police arrested three people — software engineer Ravi Rathore, cricket coach Sudama, and call centre

operator Vikas Rathore — for allegedly swindling over 600 people, including Gupta, into investing more than Rs 90 crore through their fraudulent trading platform.

The arrests came a month after Gupta filed a police complaint at the Central District Cyber police station in Delhi for investment fraud.

For law-enforcement agencies already grappling with pervasive "digital arrest" scams, cyber investment frauds such as this — in which

● LURED WITH LUCRATIVE OFFERS



TRADEMAKER LISTED the app, on Google Play Store

LURED PEOPLE with lucrative offers, claiming to be an automated platform where users would have to pay lower fees and no service tax

636 VICTIM ACCOUNTS and nearly 14,232 transactions amounting to Rs 99.77 crore linked to the app, say police

fraudsters lure unsuspecting investors with promises of higher returns — are now emerging as a major challenge.

"In digital arrest scams, the fraudsters generally manipulate their targets emotionally and even threaten them. But in this case, they exploited greed, cheating multiple people on the same platform. Of the total financial frauds in the country, around 65-70% are related to investment schemes," one officer tells *The Indian Express*.

Belonging to a family of

farmers in Uttar Pradesh's Gonda, Gupta, a Class 12 graduate, began working as a rexine salesman in Central Delhi in 2022. He lives with his family — wife and two sons aged 5 and 2. His job earned him Rs 18,000 a month, and with rent and household expenses mounting, Gupta began looking for other avenues of income.

It was then that a friend introduced him to stock trading, and soon Gupta began trading — cautiously at first, and then

» CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



The Aspirants

UPSC aspirants during last-minute checks outside an exam centre in Delhi on Sunday. Around 5.49 lakh candidates appeared for the Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination across the country. At 70,885, Delhi had the highest number of candidates, followed by Hyderabad (44,209) and Patna (39,147). VIVEK PRAKASH KRISHNA

ATS: Maharashtra ‘lone wolf’ attacker self-radicalised

Mohamed Thaver

Mumbai, May 24

THE MAHARASHTRA Anti Terrorism Squad (ATS) investigating the “lone wolf” attack in Mumbai, where Zaib Ansari (31), a US-returned Indian national, allegedly attacked two security guards last month, has concluded that the accused had been “self radicalised” from the internet and was not in touch with anyone else with regard to the crime.

The agency has found that Ansari saw videos of some controversial preachers like Anwar Al-Awlaki, a radical American Muslim cleric of Yemeni descent linked to a series of terror cases globally. The agency has also found that while in the US, Ansari made money through tennis coaching. He did not have a regular source of income in India. Besides, he had gone through a divorce and was staying alone, it was found. His landlord had asked him to leave as she did not want to rent out her house to bachelors, an officer said. It was these factors coupled with the attacks in Palestine that drove him to some extreme content on the internet, which radicalised him over the past six to eight months, the officer added.

The agency has found that apart from Al-Awlaki, Ansari would go through videos of a London-based popular You-Tuber, a Saudi-based Salafist preacher and a Malaysia-based

preacher in addition to literature from a Salafist website that they believe drove him to attack the two security guards.

“We were investigating if Zaib was in talks with any handlers from foreign countries. We have not found any evidence of that. Based on our probe, it appears he was self-radicalised after going through the online content,” the officer said.

“In the US, he had seen lone wolf attacks being carried out at the behest of Islamic State (IS) and planned to do the same here. Hence, following in their steps, he left behind a note assuming he would be killed. When he survived, he came home and got dressed in black, waiting for the police to nab him,” the officersaid. He further told investigators that he did not die by suicide as it was considered asin. “Initially, when he got the house on rent, his mother had accompanied him from the US. Later, his wife was staying with him, but ever since they parted ways, he had been staying alone for the past few months. He was facing difficulty getting a new house on rent as he was a bachelor,” the officersaid. Ansari is currently lodged in Thane prison.

Ansari had allegedly stabbed two guards at an under-construction site on Mira Road on April 27 after asking them their religion. The two guards sustained injuries and were eventually discharged by the hospital.

Will ensure safety of investors: Bihar CM at business conclave

Yuvraj Singh

Patna, May 24

A TWO-DAY state-level business conclave organised here by the Bihar Chamber of Commerce and Industries (BCCI) brought together investors, entrepreneurs, business associations and government representatives to discuss the potential of investment, industrial expansion and employment generation in the state.

Organised as part of the BCCI’s centenary celebrations under the theme ‘Vyavasay, Rajneeti, Vikas’, the conclave, which concluded Sunday, witnessed participation from over 300 delegates representing around 73 chambers of commerce, business associations and private stakeholders from across Bihar.

Speaking at the opening session of the event on Saturday, Bihar Governor Lt Gen (Retd) Syed Ata Hasnain stressed upon tapping into the youth’s potential to generate employment opportunities across tourism, agriculture and entrepreneurial sectors.

Referring to Bihar’s increasing national visibility, the Governor also spoke about his broader symbolic visions for the state, including INS Patna, the possibility of an Army Day Parade being conducted in Bihar capital, and the possible establishment of an IPL team named ‘Patna Patriots’.

Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary, who attended the closing session of the event on Sunday, said: “There is no dearth of investment proposals in Bihar. We want to encourage public-private partnership. We assure investors of complete safety and good law and order conditions. We have asked the DMs

— The writer is an intern at The Indian Express

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Strategic alliance

assured that the bilateral relationship between India and the US continues to be strong and has not lost any momentum. The two ministers held their bilateral meeting on Sunday, a day after Rubio met Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

“There are only a handful of countries in the world that have both the economic and diplomatic power to be influential on strategic issues from a global perspective, and India is one of them, which is what adds the finishing touches on the importance of the strategic alliance... we have a strategic alliance between the US and India, it’s a strategic alliance between two countries that have global influence and the ability to influence global events, and that distinguishes it from other relationships,” Rubio said.

Stating that the Indian government follows a “India First policy” just like the Trump administration’s “America First policy”, Jaishankar, who was calibrated in his comments, stuck to the “strategic partnership” line. “We have a strategic partnership which emanates from a convergence of national interests in many areas,” he said. He outlined issues of defence, energy, nuclear energy, critical minerals and the trade negotiations as part of the bilateral talks, apart from geopolitical issues in West Asia and the Indo-Pacific.

“We discussed the importance of taking into account the Make in India approach and lessons drawn from recent conflicts, while going forward in the defence domain. On the economic front, we spoke about the value of concluding at an early date the final text of the interim agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade,” Jaishankar said.

The two sides discussed strengthening their strategic

partnership, with the focus on defence, security and economic cooperation. Key points from the bilateral talks include the renewal of the 10-year major defence partnership framework and the signing of a comprehensive underwater domain awareness roadmap.

Rubio, who is also the National Security Advisor in the Trump administration, also met NSA Ajit Doval.

Visa curbs

Raising the issue of visa curbs faced by Indians, Jaishankar said: “People-to-people ties are at the heart of our relationship. I apprised Secretary Rubio of challenges that legitimate travellers face in respect of visa issuance, while we cooperate to deal with illegal and irregular mobility. Our expectation is that legal mobility would not be adversely impacted as a consequence. After all, this is very relevant to our business, technology, and research cooperation.”

Asked about the impact of the recent curbs on Indians travelling to the US, Rubio acknowledged the contribution that Indians have made to the US economy. “Over \$20 billion has been invested in the US economy by Indian companies. We want that number to continue to increase, and obviously the expertise as well that they’ve provided into our economy has been very, very valuable,” he said.

“...The changes that are happening now, or the modernisation of our migration system into the US, is not India-focused. It’s not India-specific. It is global. It’s being applied across the world. We are in a period of modernisation,” he said. “We’ve had a migratory crisis in the US. This is not because of India, but broadly, we had over 20 million

people illegally enter the US over the last few years, and we’ve had to address that challenge,” he said.

“We are modernising the US immigration system for the 21st century, so that it is an immigration system that’s not just good for America, but is also good for the people that are coming... I want to be clear that the changes, while they may be having a disproportionate impact on a place like India that provides so many high-skilled workers to the US economy, it is not a system that is targeted at India, it is one that’s being applied globally. But we’re in a period of transition, and like any period of transition, there’s going to be some bumps on that road, but we think ultimately our destination is going to be a better, more efficient system and more sustainable”.

Responding to questions on racist comments against Indians and Indian-Americans, Rubio said: “Look, I’m sure that there are people that have made comments online and in other places, because every country in the world has stupid people. I’m sure there’s stupid people here. There’s stupid people in the US that make dumb comments all the time. I don’t know what else to tell you, other than the US is a very welcoming country.”

Trade talks

“The US-India relationship has not lost any momentum. I understand why some people might say that... The reality of it is, this is not about India, this is about the US, in terms of trade. The President did not say, ‘Let’s figure out a way to create friction with India over trade’. The President came in and said, ‘We have a trade situation involving the US economy that doesn’t work moving forward. There’s a huge imbalance that’s built up, and it needs to be addressed’. And he pursued it from a global perspective,” Rubio said.

“As Secretary of State, there

E. EXPLAINED

Bid to repair ties

New Delhi and Washington have had a challenging year where strategic trust has been a major casualty. Marco Rubio’s remarks are an important outreach towards the Indian government, and part of Washington’s diplomacy towards its partner in the region and a member of Quad.

is virtually no country in the world that I could travel to that isn’t going to raise the issue of trade, because we did this from a global perspective. The President approached it and said we have to rebalance US trade, and one of the reasons why is, again, this is not about India... The US was being de-industrialised, we pursued trade policies that left us in a place where all the means of production had been outsourced in such a way that left us vulnerable. That had to change, and it cost us jobs to create a huge displacement in our country, and that needed to be corrected. There needs to be a rebalancing of how we approach global trade,” he said.

“The good news is that through this rebalancing, we are ultimately seeking, and believe we will arrive at, trade arrangements around the world that are good for the US, and also for our trade partners, and one of those we hope will be India. In fact, we are on the verge of making that happen. We are hopeful that our trade representative can visit here very soon. We had an Indian delegation in the US, I believe, last week or the week before. We’ve made tremendous progress, and I think we’re going to wind up with a trade agreement between the US and India that’s going to be enduring, and it’s going to be beneficial to both sides and sustainable in a way that addresses this national in-

‘Holding centres’

alert and tasked with identifying those staying “illegally”. According to sources, after such people are identified, they will be put in the holding centres. Later, they will be handed over to the BSF for a “push back” into Bangladesh.

Speaking to reporters in Kolkata on the issue, Union Minister of State Sukanta Majumdar said, “Union Home Minister (Amit Shah) on multiple occasions said that illegal infiltration will not be tolerated. Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari also made it clear that if there is any Bangladeshi infiltrator here, police will catch them and then hand them over to the BSF... Why should we pay

and feed people who have come from another country? We will send them back. I had a talk with the Chief Minister yesterday. The government will prepare a list of such persons.”

The BJP, which came to power for the first time in West Bengal earlier this month, has made it clear that tackling illegal immigration is one of its major priorities. In the first Cabinet meeting, it was decided that land would be given to the BSF to undertake fencing along the Bangladesh border, and the work for this has been underway on a war footing.

In a press conference on May 20, Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari said his gov-

terest that we have,” he said.

Rubio listed areas of cooperation, including on Pax Silica, an initiative on critical minerals. “This is an area of strategic concern for both sides... In just the last few months, as I said, there’s \$20 billion of Indian investment in the US economy, and that number continues to grow, so I think the relationship continues to be strong. In fact, I believe by the end of this administration it will be stronger than it’s ever been. That’s certainly our goal, and that’s certainly what we’re building towards,” he said.

US-Pakistan ties

On the Trump administration’s close ties with Pakistan’s military leadership, Rubio said: “As far as our relations with other countries... we have relations, and we work at the tactical level, for example, and in many other ways, with countries all over the world; so does India. That’s what responsible nation states do. But I don’t view our relation with any country in the world as coming at the expense of our strategic alliance with India.”

He underlined that “India is an important strategic partner... one of our most important strategic partners in the world”.

Hormuz closure

On Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Rubio said: “This is an international waterway... they don’t own it. It’s an international waterway, and what they are doing now is basically threatening to destroy commercial vessels using an international waterway. That is illegal under any concept of international law that governs us... if we allowed that to become normal, we would be normalising an unacceptable status quo and setting a dangerous precedent that could be replicated here in this region and in multiple places around the world. So, the President has his preference... to find a diplomatic way that these problems can be solved.”

ernment would follow the “detect, delete and deport” system for illegal Bangladeshis in Bengal. This involves finding “illegal immigrants”, deleting their names from the voter list and welfare schemes, and then sending them back to their country of origin.

He also mentioned the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), under which Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis, and Christians from Afghanistan, Bangladesh, and Pakistan can apply for citizenship. “Those who are covered under CAA are safe here. Those who are not covered under CAA and illegal infiltrators will be arrested by the state police and handed over to the BSF for deportation. Our policy is detect, delete and deport,” said the Chief Minister.

Rafales

minimise logistical and training costs.

The indigenous content of the jets would be nearly 50 per cent. While having complete access to the source code is unlikely, India has been negotiat-

ing to obtain the Interface Control Documents (ICD) for the jets, to be able to integrate indigenous weapons such as Astra and BrahMos-NG. An ICD is a technical blueprint on how an aircraft’s onboard systems communicate with external weapons, sensors and equipment.

The Government is aiming

to sign the contract by the end of this year, once commercial negotiations conclude and the CCS approves the acquisition.

The process for the acquisition of modern fighter jets for IAF has picked up over the past year after a long wait of nearly 18 years. The Rafales will be critical in filling the gap in the

Trump

morning here, and this evening there. And I just want to say, you’re great. We’ve never been closer to India, and India can count on me 100 per cent and our country,” Trump said.

“We have a record economy, a record stock market. And anything India wants, they get. And I’m a big, big fan of Prime Minister Modi,” he said.

Trump was on speakerphone with US Ambassador Sergio Gor, who called him up at around 9 pm IST (11.30 am in Washington DC), as about 1,500 guests, including US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, attended the event.

Addressing the event at Bharat Mandapam, Rubio said: “... We know that so much of what we achieved in our history has been built in partnership with other countries around the world, with which we share so much. And one of those relationships that I am so excited about going into... given the challenges and the opportunities of this new era, is India. It’s one of those countries that I know that we have this very valuable strategic partnership with, and we share so many values and so many common interests.”

“I will try to go through other celebrations of our 250th birthday in different parts of the world, although I doubt any will have a production like this one, but I want you to know that part of my visit here is also to reinforce how important this relationship is, how exciting it is, and how many opportunities we have to do things together. If I think about all of the key issues and all of the key opportunities of the modern economy, India and the US together are... perfectly positioned to work together on these issues to achieve a better life for the people of the United States, for the people of India, and frankly, for the people of other countries working together as well,” he said.

“Today, our two countries approach the world with certain common attributes. We are both political democracies, we are market economies, and we are open societies. These shared traits have, in recent times, been strengthened by a convergence of national interests, and that is precisely what has enabled us to overcome the hesitations of history. Our strategic partnership is expressed now in a very wide range of activities. They span trade and investment, defence and security, critical and emerging technologies,” Jaishankar said.

Music composer A R Rahman was among those who performed at the event.

IAF’s fighter squadron strength, which stands at 29 against the sanctioned strength of 42. They are expected to bridge this capability gap until the maturity of India’s indigenous fighter programmes, LCA Mk1A, LCA Mk2 and the fifth-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA).

victims across the country. Two victims have already come forward. While one has allegedly invested Rs 1.3 lakh, the other victim has put in Rs 70,000.

Of the 636 investors, police have so far identified 109: 48 from Maharashtra, 27 from Bihar, 14 from Delhi, 9 from Haryana, 4 each from Kerala and Assam, 2 from Jammu, and 1 from Tamil Nadu. Investigators have also not found any links to overseas cybercrime syndicates, although the probe is still underway.

The police, meanwhile, advise caution while using investment apps. “An investor must check whether an app is registered with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI),” the officer explains.

“Carefully examine the app’s logo, photos, written notes, instructions, website, and pages for errors or suspicious details. If the app offers unrealistic returns, stay vigilant. If, after your first investment, someone insists that you put in more money, be cautious — it could be a red flag. If you realise that you have been trapped in a fraud, immediately report it by calling 1930, the toll-free National Cyber Crime Helpline, or approaching the local police.”

Back in Central Delhi, Gupta continues to trade online but the episode has shaken him. “*Sabak mil gaya, sir* (I’ve learned my lesson),” he says.

WEEKS AFTER BIOMETRIC ATTENDANCE MADE MANDATORY

Mark biometric attendance or face action, Chief Secy warns govt staff

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, May 24

DELHI CHIEF Secretary Rajeev Kumar has warned employees across government departments to mark their biometric attendance or face disciplinary action after finding that guidelines issued earlier were not being heeded despite reminders, said sources. The warning comes over a month after Chief Minister Rekha Gupta held a surprise inspection at the office of Department of Trade and Taxes and found senior officers and staff missing. Following the inspection, biometric attendance was made mandatory for staff members and officers across government departments.

The Chief Secretary, said officials, held a meeting with all the Heads of the Departments

Show cause notices have been sent to some officers over non-compliance

(HoDs) last week and directed them to ensure that the staff members take the directions seriously.

"It was observed that several officers across different departments were still not marking their attendance through the Biometric Attendance System. The CS warned the departments to take the directions seriously, or, he said strict disciplinary action will be taken," said a senior official who was in attendance at the meeting.

Sources said that show-cause notices have also been issued to some officers and staff members in different departments for not adhering to the guidelines.

After the CM's surprise inspection last month, all the employees, including additional Chief Secretary, Principal Secretary and Secretary-level officers, were asked to punch in at 9.30 am and punch out at 6 pm. However, the Delhi government has recently implemented staggered timings for the employees after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to save fuel in the wake of the Iran-US war.

During her review, the CM sought a monthly attendance report indicating the average time of arrival of each official. She also directed the General Administration Department (GAD) to compile a daily attendance report and submit it to the

Chief Secretary by 12 pm every day.

After fresh directions from the Chief Secretary, the Public Works Department (PWD) has also issued a fresh order to its staff, saying, "... It has been observed that some officers/officials are either not marking their attendance regularly or are not doing so within the prescribed office timings... Therefore, all officers/officials are once again directed to register themselves in the Biometric Attendance System, if they have not already done so, and to mark their attendance regularly on a daily basis within the prescribed office timings. All officers/officials shall ensure strict compliance with these instructions and adhere to them without any lapse."

An official said, "Order for work from home on Wednesday has also come. For the rest of the

days, we have directed officials to mark their attendance to ensure everyone comes to office on time."

Moreover, the PWD has also asked its officials to consider carpooling for inspections, field visits and travel to office, wherever feasible, as part of efforts to reduce fuel consumption and emissions.

"During inspections, inaugurations and official events, officers have also been advised to travel together using electric vehicles, pooled vehicles or public transport," the official said. Further, officials have also been asked to maximise the use of electric pumps and permanent pumping stations instead of diesel-operated or tractor-mounted pumps.

In addition, virtual meetings will be encouraged to minimise avoidable travel.

12 DAYS AFTER SHE DIED

'How will we live without her...': Family's tearful adieu to Twisha after 2nd autopsy

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, May 24

AFTER NEARLY two weeks of courtroom battles, protests against the police, and duelling allegations on forensic and digital evidence, Twisha Sharma's last rites were carried out on Sunday evening at the Bhadbhada cremation ground, where grief-stricken relatives carried the 33-year-old model and actor's remains to her funeral pyre, covered in marigolds and silence.

When Twisha's body was finally released after the second postmortem conducted by experts from AIIMS Delhi at AIIMS Bhopal, her family gathered for one final glimpse before the cremation.

Carrying her body, wrapped in white and bright red cloth and placed on a bamboo bier, toward the cremation ground triggered a fresh eruption of grief for the family. Her mother, Rekha Sharma, broke down as relatives tried to steady her while the body was prepared for the final rites. At several moments, family members had to physically support her as she sobbed uncontrollably beside her daughter's remains.

By the time the body reached the cremation ground, it had been completely covered in thick marigold garlands. Relatives leaned over the bier, burying their faces into the flowers and weeping quietly as prayers continued around them. The mother had to be helped into the cremation ground by relatives who repeatedly handed her bottles of water as she struggled through exhaustion, heat and grief to remain standing beside her daughter's funeral pyre.

Family members embraced each other and cried silently as Twisha's body was lifted onto the funeral pyre by relatives, some of them retired and serving Army officers wearing military jackets and caps. Event-



Family members of model-turned-actor Twisha Sharma, during her last rites, at Bhadbhada Vishram Ghat in Bhopal, Sunday, PTI

ually, it was Twisha's brother, Harshit Sharma, who lit the funeral pyre.

For nearly two weeks, Harshit had become the public face of the family's fight, protesting outside police stations, attending court hearings, briefing the media and pursuing legal petitions from the Madhya Pradesh High Court to the Supreme Court while refusing to allow the cremation until a second post-mortem was conducted.

That battle transformed Twisha's death from a dowry death investigation into one of Madhya Pradesh's most explosive and emotionally charged criminal cases.

At a prayer meet organised for Twisha, her father Navnidhi Sharma said, "We don't know how we will live without her. As kids grow up, they take care of their parents. They become like parents and parents become like children. She used to take care of like a mother does for her children."

"This case will set an example for everyone and people's faith in the judicial process will be restored. I thank the Supreme Court for taking suo motu cognisance of the matter," he said.

Twisha was found dead at her matrimonial home in Bhopal less than six months after her wedding to Samarth Singh, son of retired judge Giribala Singh. What followed was an

extraordinary chain of events with allegations of murder and evidence tampering by Twisha's family, claims of investigative lapses by senior police officers, leaked CCTV footage, disputed WhatsApp chats, accusations of influence over forensic procedures, a dramatic surrender attempt by Samarth in Jabalpur after 10 days on the run, and ultimately the transfer of the investigation to the CBI.

The family repeatedly refused to cremate Twisha's body while demanding a second post-mortem and alleging that the first forensic examination had been compromised. The body remained in the mortuary for days as legal petitions moved rapidly between courts.

After the body was recovered from the mortuary on Sunday, her brother Harshit Sharma said the identification turned out to be difficult. "It was slightly difficult, considering it was being done after 10 days. Also, since a first postmortem had already been conducted on the body, it became a little more difficult. However, it was identified by matching the birthmarks and other features," he said.

The Madhya Pradesh High Court eventually ordered a second postmortem, observing that because the death had occurred within six months of marriage, "all doubts from any quarter" should be removed.

Gymkhana prepares to move court, staff worry about uncertain future

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 24

MEMBERS OF Delhi Gymkhana Club have started a signature campaign to authorise the club to move court against the Centre's decision to take back the land that the elite institution occupies in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi.

On Friday, the Land and Development Office under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs wrote to the Secretary of the club initiating the "re-entry and resumption of [the] premises" at 2 Safdarjung Road. Clause 4 of the lease deed allows the government to take back the leased property, if it or any part of it is required for a public purpose.

Major Atul Dev (Retd), a senior member of the club who has been handling its legal matters, had told The Indian Express on Saturday that the club would file a petition seeking a stay on the order.

The government's notice had come without warning, and had given no reasons or cited any violation of the conditions of the lease, Maj Dev had said.

PTI adds: Anxiety and uncertainty have gripped employees of the iconic Delhi Gymkhana Club after the Centre instructed the club to vacate its premises by June 5.

Nandan Singh Negi, President of the Gymkhana Employees' Welfare Association, stated that the staff was informed on Saturday about the Centre's plan to take over the



Outside Gymkhana Club in New Delhi on Sunday. GAJENDRA YADAV

club premises.

"We were told about the development yesterday. Staff members have been calling me throughout the night, asking what will happen to them and where they will go," Negi said.

Rameshwar, a staff member who has worked at the club for over 35 years, said that the unexpected order had left employees worried about how they would support their families.

"Many of us have spent over three decades here, while others have worked for 10 to 15 years. We do not know how we will sustain our families now," he said, adding that finding another job at this stage of life would be difficult for many workers.

Several staff members gathered at the Gymkhana Club on Sunday, demanding clarity on the situation.

MURDER CASE REGISTERED, POLICE LOOK FOR MOTIVE

Security guard dies after man beats, drives SUV over him

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 24

AROUND 4 AM on Sunday, a PCR call was received about a man getting injured in a road accident at a tempo stand in West Delhi's Paschim Vihar West, said officers. Identified as Bijendra, the 60-year-old who worked as a security guard at the tempo stand was rushed to a nearby hospital by a team of officers where he was declared dead. As officers investigated the circumstances that led to his death, they found that he did not die in an accident. An SUV driver allegedly thrashed him and ran the vehicle over him twice, grievously injuring him, according to police.

A murder case has been registered after CCTV footage police recovered contradicted initial findings, said officers. Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outer District) Vikram Singh said the motive behind the alleged attack would become clear after the suspects are arrested. Investigations and efforts to identify and apprehend the SUV occupants are ongoing, officers added.

"Initial on-site observations included tyre marks, which led us to suspect a vehicular collision. However, subsequent review of CCTV footage showed the attack was deliberate," another police officer said.

The CCTV footage, according to the officer, shows the incident took place on Sunday around 2.50 am.

Bijendra was seated on a



A CCTV grab of the incident.

chair at the tempo stand when an SUV pulled up. A man got off the vehicle carrying a stick and struck the security guard. The 60-year-old then picked up the stick in self-defence and tried to resist the attacker, officers said.

During the scuffle, the SUV driver allegedly drove the vehicle toward Bijendra and attempted to hit him. The 60-year-old moved behind a parked tempo to escape. The driver sped up the vehicle towards him.

After Bijendra fell, the driver, accompanied by another man, ran over him once and drove on. The footage then shows the SUV turning back, returning to the scene and running over Bijendra a second time before fleeing. Crime and forensic teams collected evidence at the scene. Police said the SUV involved had no number plate.

Bijendra lived in Peeragarhi with his son Bunty, daughter-in-law and grandson. His wife died six years ago, said police.

Mahaveer Prasad, a local,

Online timestamps, refreshments: How cops traced Govindpuri double murder suspect

Alok Singh
New Delhi, May 24

REFRESHMENTS IN the living room and no signs of forceful entry in the house had initially led the police to suspect that someone familiar to the family was involved in the murders of 38-year-old Sharda Sahu and her 13-year-old son in South East Delhi's Govindpuri on the intervening night of May 20 and 21.

The victims' last-seen WhatsApp timestamps helped investigators establish the probable time of the murders and subsequently narrow their scanning of CCTV footage to a specific time frame, officers said. As part of the preliminary investigation, police said they began examining CCTV footage. They had to establish the exact timeline in order to narrow down the footage they needed to scan, officers said.

The examination of CCTV footage eventually led to the arrest of the key accused identified as Saurabh Sahu (28). Saurabh, Sharda's cousin, allegedly killed her and her son because he was angry over Sharda's repeated attempts to stop him from engaging in criminal activities and drug abuse, police said.

According to the police, the CCTV footage from the night of May 20 through the early hours of May 21 was unclear and did not provide good visuals of

people moving in the area. Officers were informed of the murders at around 1 am on May 21, when the woman's husband returned home from work.

The woman had suffered around 20 stab wounds, while her son had seven injuries on different parts of his body, police said. Signs of struggle were visible throughout the house, and the bodies were found in the kitchen, with blood splattered all around, police said.

Upon reaching the spot, the police team found a glass of litchi juice along with some biscuits and muffins in the drawing room, indicating that refreshments had been served to a visitor, a detail that hinted that someone known to the family might have killed the two, officers said, adding that the main door of the house was open, and the locker inside an almirah had been broken.

To identify the accused, Deputy Commissioner of Police (South-east) Hemant Tiwari formed multiple teams and assigned officers separate tasks, including examining CCTV footage, questioning relatives and friends, and identifying local criminals.

The Anti-Narcotics and Anti-Auto Theft Squad (AATS) teams, led by Inspectors Vishnu Dutt, Ajay Dalal, and Rajender Singh Dagar under the supervision of ACP Kalkaji VKPS Yadav, scanned CCTV

footage from the area. Although many visuals were blurred, investigators noticed several people moving through the lane late into the night.

"On checking the mobile phones of the deceased, investigators found that the woman was last seen online at 7:30 pm and her son at 7:49 pm. A neighbour also informed police that he had called the woman at 8:26

pm regarding some work, but the call went unanswered and she never called back," an officer said. This information helped police narrow down the probable time of the murders. Investigators subsequently focused on CCTV footage recorded between 7:49 pm and 1 am. Saurabh was arrested Saturday near a park in Tughlakabad Extension.

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CAPITAL IN CLASSROOMS

Private equity is reshaping K-12 education, with Gurgaon emerging as a hotspot. **DEVANSH MITTAL** reports on why schools are turning to investors, what draws private equity to the sector, and the changes — and concerns — that follow its entry into classrooms.

IN 2024, two private equity (PE) and venture capital veterans — Piyush Gupta and Norbert Fernandes — set out to build a new investment firm, Kenro Capital, at a time when artificial intelligence (AI) had become the industry's most overused buzzword.

They started with a quieter, almost philosophical question that has been echoing through boardrooms and venture circles as AI accelerates its reach: In a rapidly changing AI-driven world, what are the things that will not change?

The premise was not that AI would reshape everything — but that it would come close. The real challenge was identifying the rare corners of life that would remain stubbornly human.

“One answer that stood out was high-touch businesses like schools. People will always send their children to schools,” Fernandes says.

With this conviction, Kenro Capital invested roughly Rs 340 crore in K12 Techno Services Private Limited at the end of 2024, best known for its flagship chain, Orchids: The International School.

And Kenro Capital is not alone in making that bet. Across India, private equity firms are increasingly circling the K-12 (Kindergarten to Class 12) education space. Nowhere is this more visible than in Gurgaon, where at least nine K-12 schools are already backed by private equity capital.

Why schools are turning to private equity

Even as most schools in India operate as nonprofit trusts or societies, private equity firms generate returns by investing in the commercial entities around them rather than the trusts themselves. According to industry insiders, PE funds that pool money from wealthy individuals and institutions, acquire companies that own school real estate, manage operations, license brands, provide technology platforms, or run services such as transport and curriculum support. “The school trust pays lease rentals, management fees and service charges to these for-profit entities, allowing investors to earn recurring revenue indirectly from school cash flows,” an industry insider said.

The PE firms, the industry insider points out, also benefit from the scalability of branded school chains and higher valuations driven by consolidation in the education sector. “This improves profitability. Some exit at higher valuations through sales or public listings,” the industry insider says.

Increasingly, India's private school sector is emerging as a target.

Industry insiders say PE's growing presence in K-12 education reflects a structural shift years in the making. For decades, many private schools in India operated like family-run businesses, where key decisions — from hiring teachers to expanding infrastructure — were made within the founder's close circle.

Now, many of these schools are at an inflection point. The next generation of founders is often unwilling to take over day-to-day operations, preferring instead to bring in professional management.

“Their next generation is no longer interested in running it on a daily basis and is instead open to handing over the management to professionally run players,” Fernandes says.

This opens the door for private equity firms, which see not just a school, but a scalable institution with predictable demand and long-term cash flows.

At the same time, demand-side pressures are also reshaping the sector.

For India's growing middle class, education is no longer just about securing admission to a nearby good school. “They want high-quality infrastructure, holistic exposure, and best-in-class outcomes,” says Amitabh Jhingan, partner at EY Parthenon and EY's Global Education Sector Leader.

This shift in expectations is transforming private K-12 schools.

“The new normal is a more global, aspirational and future-ready school format across both national (CBSE and ICSE) and international curricula (IGCSE and IB),” Jhingan says. For parents, these international programmes also promise smoother pathways to foreign universities and stronger global credentials.

However, the transition comes at a cost. “IB and Cambridge systems require

schools to send teachers for expensive training programmes. They also have larger staff structures. Overall costs are high,” says Ameeta Watal, Chairperson of DLF Foundational Schools.

On the supply side, expansion is capital-intensive. Setting up a school requires large land parcels, regulatory approvals, and significant upfront investment. Regulations often mandate long-term control over land — either ownership or leases of up to 30 years, according to an industry insider who did not wish to be named.

Many schools also operate under not-for-profit structures, limiting access to traditional financing. “Thus, it becomes difficult to expand on their own, necessitating institutional capital. This is where private equity comes in,” the insider says.

Interest in schools

Private equity firms are not solely focused on high-risk and high-return sectors, a senior PE investor emphasises. “A lot of their capital ends up in lower-risk, stable, cash-generating sectors like healthcare or essential consumer goods,” he says.

He explains the rationale lies in how PE funds are structured and how they generate returns. “Typically, they buy companies using a significant amount of borrowed money. To safely service that debt, they need businesses that generate steady and predictable cash flows.”

“Also, PE firms usually need to exit investments within 10 years through a sale. Buyers prefer companies with low operational risk, so low-risk industries make exits more certain,” he says.

Fernandes says PE firms view education as relatively lower risk because demand is stable. “Parents won't stop sending their children to school. One of the most important budget allocations at a household level tends to be their education. Other factors are that these are cash-flow positive businesses in which fees are collected in advance of the school year.”

Investors are also drawn to fragmented, unorganised markets that can be consolidated, similar to platforms like Uber and Oyo, according to an industry executive.

“K-12 schooling in India, until now, is a largely unorganised market. Once you consolidate the market and have a large number of schools on your platform, efficiencies created by the economies of scale will help you increase your margins while providing value,” he says.

Driven by these shifts, major private equity firms are investing in K-12 schools. Blackstone reportedly considered a majority stake in Jaipur-based Globetrotters Educational Innovations, which runs Jayshree Periwai International School (JPS), last November. KKR, the second-largest global PE firm, holds a majority stake in Lighthouse Learning and increased its investment in November. In India, ChrysCapital, Peak XV, and Kedaara Capital hold stakes in K-12 Techno Services.

Changes that PE brings

When PE firms invest in schools, the focus shifts toward expansion and higher student enrollment, according to industry insiders. For instance, in 2023, Lighthouse Learning partnered with a top IB school in Gurgaon, Heritage Xperiential Schools, to open 10 new schools over five years. Manit Jain, co-founder of the Heritage group, had said that Lighthouse would provide infrastructure and operational support to enable faster expansion.

Growth in occupancy, insiders say, becomes a key metric. Schools carry heavy fixed costs — teacher salaries, classrooms, and infrastructure — regardless of student strength. “As a result, even with half the number of students, the school continues to incur nearly the same overall costs,” Fernandes says. The goal, therefore, is to reach 90–95% occupancy within one to two years, spreading fixed costs over a larger base.

Fernandes also highlights that PEs prefer to invest in a network of schools instead of a single standalone school because of economic advantage. He cites examples like senior-school coaching classes as an example.

He says students in higher classes often need extra subject-specific coaching for competitive exams — say for physics or chemistry. For one independent school, hiring a dedicated specialist teacher for each subject may be too expensive. “But if the school is part of a larger network, like K12 Techno Ser-

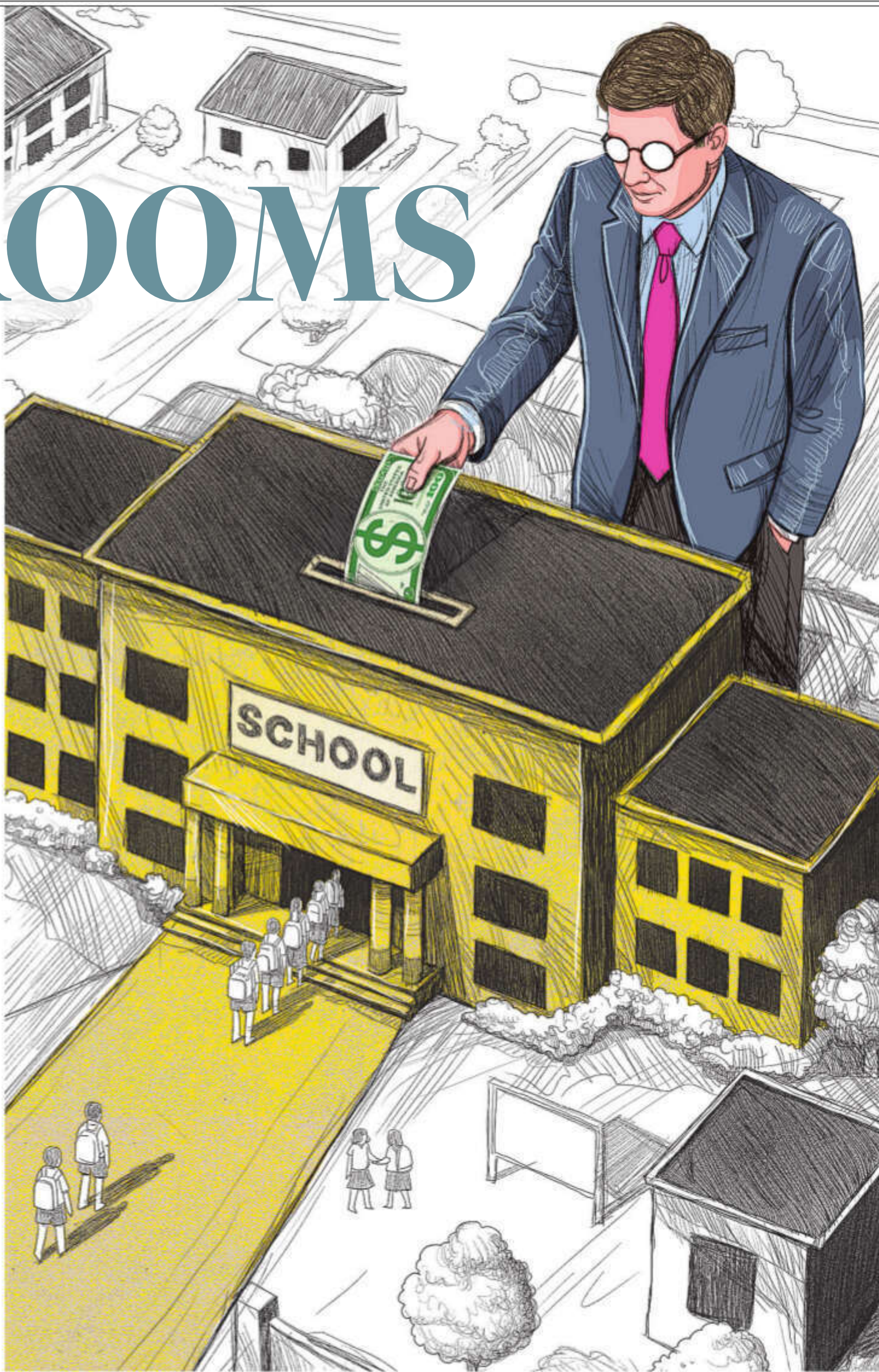
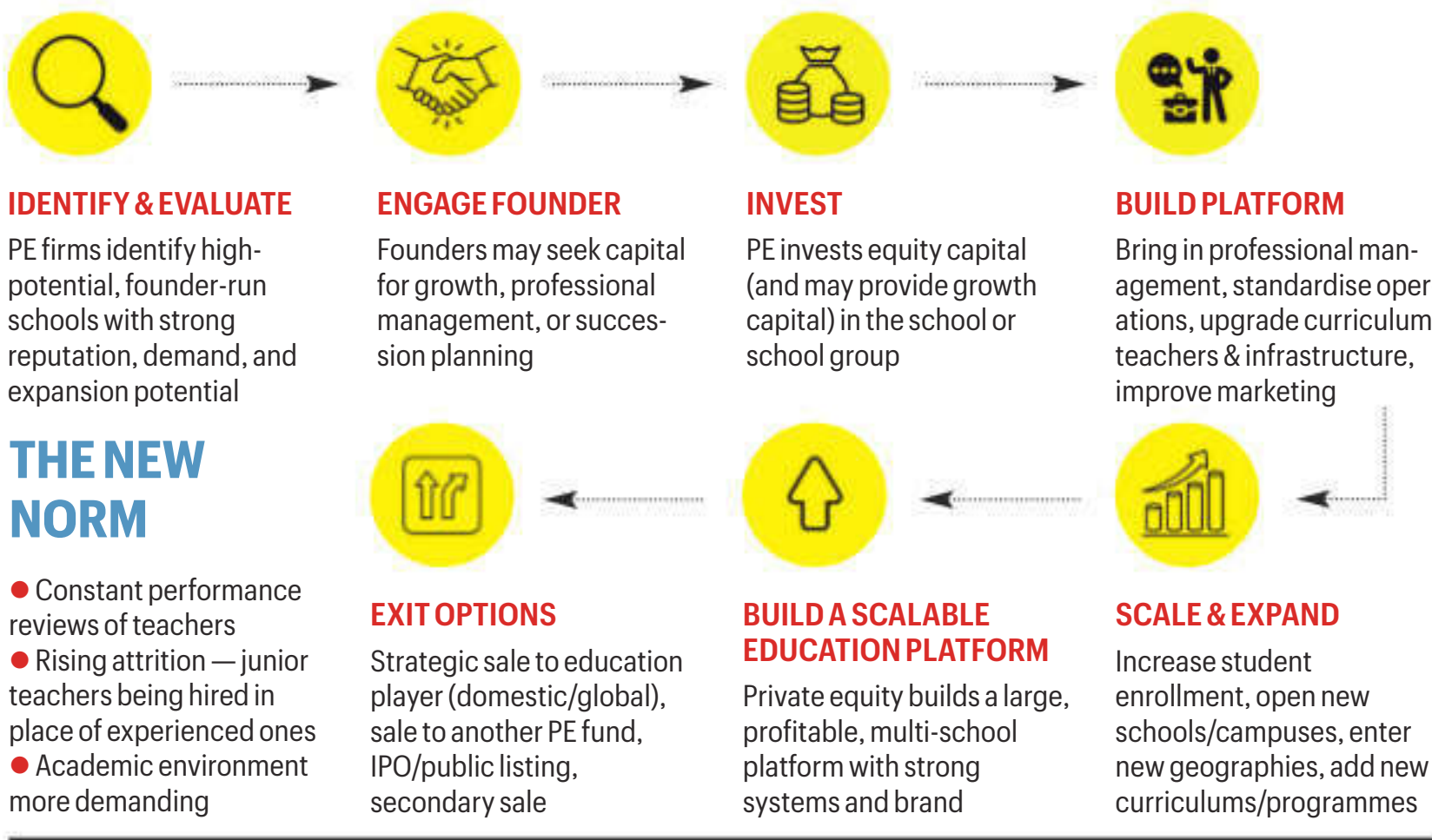


ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

• How private equity invests in founder-run schools and makes money



vices' schools, that same specialist teacher can be shared across multiple campuses. Instead of one school bearing the full cost, the teacher can rotate between schools and teach students at each one,” he adds.

Within individual schools, the changes are most visible in everyday classroom practices, where insiders say standardisation has emerged as the most visible shift.

Take for instance, Dwarka's Shantigyan School. A teacher said that after the founder's death, the institution was divided between his three children. While two continue to run separate schools, one brought in what the teacher described as the professional “cavalry” — K12 Techno Services. The company arrived with its management team, as well as physical, academic and technological infrastructure, and its brand name ‘Orchids: The International School’.

“When the new management came in, they brought everything new with them, even the furniture. The new furniture, which we were told is the same in every K12 school, was brought in from Bengaluru,” the teacher says.

Teachers receive lesson plans from the K12 team in Bangalore that include videos, presentations and instructional material for every period. “This is great mostly since we can teach according to a plan, but many times it also leads to micromanaging, as there are directions for every five minutes which are not feasible to implement and become tedious,” the teacher adds.

The model has also drawn support. Speaking about the difficulty of building schools such as DPS and Columbus, which take years to develop, former Reserve Bank of India governor Raghuram Rajan had

pointed to the Orchids system two years ago on a podcast as a case study.

“What he (founder of K12 Techno) does is that he has 37,000-plus lesson plans put together for each lesson that a teacher will give. Every lesson plan is written down for every subject, and then teachers are recruited to deliver this. You get pretty close to top-level public school education,” Rajan said.

Insiders also point to improvements in infrastructure and extracurricular activities. The Orchids network, for instance, the students point out has invested in facilities for music, dance, textiles, and pottery. At Heritage Xperiential International School (HIXS), a teacher says Lighthouse Learning is investing a lot in exploring the use of AI in teaching. “They want teachers to learn how to use AI in classrooms,” she says.

The concerns

For many teachers in Gurgaon's elite private schools, the arrival of PE investors has brought with it a quiet but noticeable shift in everyday life — one marked by surveillance, scoring systems, and constant performance reviews.

“Every morning, five teachers have to install microphones before classes begin. These devices record us throughout the day, and later we are given scores based on how we taught and managed students. Principals and coordinators also observe classes and assign ratings, which are used in appraisals,” the teacher says.

Concerns are emerging among teachers and students over what they describe as a gradual erosion of the school's original culture — one shaped by long-term teacher loyalty. They say the shift is contributing to

higher teacher attrition.

As per one teacher, the institution was never defined by the highest pay scales, but by continuity and personal connection. “People stayed — for the brand name, yes, but also because the founders created a personal connection. There was warmth, a sense of belonging,” she said, adding that this environment was now fading.

At two Gurgaon-based PE-backed schools, teachers point to a growing preference for hiring junior faculty over more experienced educators.

Students say the attrition has had a direct impact on them. A senior student at one of the schools said at least nine senior faculty members left in 2025 alone.

“Letters of recommendation for foreign university applications are extremely important for those of us seeking undergraduate admission to top global universities,” the student says. But newer teachers often do not know students well enough to write references. “If the senior teachers had stayed, we would not be facing this issue,” the student adds.

Even prospective parents are concerned. At a parent tour organised by the school two weeks earlier, one parent asked: “We hear that a large number of teachers are now being hired from outside.” The response from the school representative was carefully worded — “We are providing all teachers with the right facilities and a good work environment. But some teachers leave for professional growth. At the same time, we also encourage fresh blood.”

Another visible shift has been the growing emphasis on academic rigour. Parents, however, remain divided over whether the change represents progress or a departure from what once distinguished these schools. “There is a shift away from the experiential learning model that prioritises holistic learning,” one parent says.

Others view the transition more favourably. Anisha Agarwal, a finance professional at Acuity Partners whose children attend a PE-backed school in Gurgaon, said the academic environment had become noticeably more demanding. “My eldest child hardly studied at all,” she says. “But now, my younger child has far more assignments. Academics have become more rigorous. This is a positive change.”

Sridhar Rajagopalan, an education entrepreneur, said that while PE firms often focus on funding new facilities, technology upgrades and professional management, the real measure of success lies in learning outcomes.

“The only metric to judge all these investments is whether the school is improving the learning outcomes of students, both academic and non-academic,” he said, adding that the sector will ultimately be judged by “what kind of impact these investments have on learning outcomes.”

• PE-BACKED INDIAN SCHOOL GROUPS K12 TECHNO SERVICES

Origin: A K-12 school management and education services company founded in 2010

Brands it owns: Orchids: The International School with around 100,000 students in its roughly 110 schools nationwide, and Eduvate that provides content and platform services to schools.

Investors: Kedaara Capital, Peak XV (formerly Sequoia Capital India), Vitruvian Partners and Kenro Capital.

Monthly fees: Rs 8,000 to Rs 16,000

Schools run in Gurgaon: 4

LIGHTHOUSE LEARNING GROUP

Origin: Formerly known as EuroKids International, it is one of India's largest Early Childhood & K-12 Education groups.

Brands it owns: EuroKids Preschool, Kangaroo Kids Preschool, EuroSchool, Billabong High International, Centre Point Group of Schools, Heritage International Xperiential School, Heritage Xperiential Learning School, Phoenix Greens School of Learning and Finland International School Maldives. It has around 1,850 preschools and 60 K-12 schools.

Investors: Majority stake owned by KKR, one of the largest PE firms in the world.

Monthly fees: Heritage International Xperiential School charges Rs 13,000-Rs 30,000, excluding admission, transport fees, & one-time security deposit.

Schools run in Gurgaon: 5

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Over the past year, the MRSRM fleet collectively covered a maximum of 2,891 km — about 70.38 per cent of Delhi's major roads. TASHI TOBGYAL

WHAT IS AN MRSRM?

A Mechanical Road Sweeping Machine (MRSRM) is a modified truck with rotating brushes, water jets, filter bags and storage space

COST**Rs 40-60 lakh**

PER UNIT

MAKERS

TPS Infrastructure, Roots Multiclean, Kam-Avida Enviro Engineers (India); Elgin Sweeper, Global Environmental Products (US).

INDIA USE

Mainly in Delhi, Chandigarh, Varanasi, Agra, Patna, Kolkata, Pune, Bengaluru, Hyderabad.

GLOBAL USE

China (Beijing) uses optical sensors to detect high-dust areas and deploys mechanical sweepers. European nations combine sweeping with high-pressure washing and dust-binding agents. US states like California use advanced mechanical sweepers.

Delhi's Killer Dust

The MCD acquired six additional MRSMs last month and eight more subsequently. The other key civic body, New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), added five more MRSMs this year to its fleet of four. Yet, the revised count of 95 MRSMs is still over 80 per cent short of what is needed.

The *Indian Express* investigation also zoomed in on the main sources of dust, prised open systemic gaps and tracked these MRSMs on the ground to find out how the dust is collected by teams of drivers and sanitation workers and the challenges they face.

The findings are telling.

Just five of the 52 designated routes of MRSMs account for nearly 18 per cent of their total running and sweeping distance. And, the clean-up is mainly focused on a small group of routes at a time: one-third of the entire active fleet was concentrated on the busiest MRSRM paths — 15 of 52 designated routes — where the machines travelled the most distance. On an average, each route covered 61 km of combined sweeping and running length — in line with the MCD's operational benchmark. As a result, half of the total operational distance recorded in the city was on these routes, indicating that large parts received little or no coverage. For context, imagine a vacuum cleaner covering only one tiny corner of one room in a house, leaving the rest of the floor caked in dust.

There's more: the fleet operates below capacity for much of the year, including peak dust months. Deployment is skewed towards winter, when air pollution peaks politically — a reactive rather than preventive posture. Coverage across municipal zones is sharply uneven, with better-funded zones faring considerably better.

The investigation also found gaps in planning, funding and execution that have allowed dust pollution to persist, despite the magnitude of the problem being clear for years. A landmark 2016 source-apportionment study by IIT Kanpur had identified road dust as the single largest contributor to Delhi's air pollution, accounting for 56 per cent of PM 10 emissions and 38 per cent of PM 2.5.

This echoed findings from this newspaper's 2015 investigative series, *Death By Breath*, which documented how previous air quality gains, including the conversion of Delhi's public transport fleet to CNG and the launch of its Metro, were reversed as officials repeatedly ignored rising dust levels and health hazard warnings.

New records investigated by *The Indian Express* show how the Centre arrived at its 505-machine figure: 246 small machines for 9,855 km of roads with a right of way (RoW) — road width open for traffic — of under 20 feet; 91 medium machines for 7,277 km of roads between 20 and 60 feet; and, 168 large machines for 13,409 km of major roads with RoW over 60 feet.

The final number was based on how often the roads need to be cleaned, records show. In this case, experts recommended cleaning on alternate days. When calculating how much road each MRSRM must cover, the experts considered the length and edges of the surface. The calculation: 1 km of road without a divider (two edges) requires 2 km of cleaning while 1 km of road with a divider (four edges) requires 4 km of cleaning.

Capacity concerns were flagged multiple times. Minutes of high-level official meetings from 2024 show that Delhi needed more than the 85 machines then in operation. In 2025, the Prime Minister's Office directed agencies to expedite procurement, primarily addressing the MCD and New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC), the capital's two main civic bodies. At a meeting in April last year involving the PMO, officials noted that at least 1,000 additional machines would be needed across the National Capital Region (NCR) for comprehensive coverage. According to Delhi Environment Department officials, the MCD alone still faces a shortfall of over 100 mechanised sweepers, based on the benchmark of one machine per 40 km of road.

Most sweeps in winter, least in summer

Even during last winter, when stricter pollution-control norms required peak deployment, the MCD did not operate all 52 of its machines available at the time simultaneously.

The gap was more pronounced in summer, when road dust is the single largest contributor to Delhi's air pollution, accounting for an estimated 38 per cent of PM 2.5 and 41 per cent of PM 10, according to a 2018 TERI study. During those months last year, only 25 sweeping routes were active city-wide on a typical day. By December, machines with traceable movement had risen to 43 — expanding coverage, but still short of full utilisation. In a sharp turn, March 2026 saw active routes fall to 15.

This unevenness shows up starkly in distances covered, or median distance covered by all machines in a day. In summer 2025, the fleet covered 1,629.1 km. This dipped to 1,284.15 km during monsoon, climbed to 2,231.7 km in the post-monsoon period, and peaked at 2,591.57 km in December — nearly 60 per cent higher than summer levels. This figure sustained through February, only to drop again by 60 per cent in March (1,043.55 km). In other words, the city sweeps hardest in winter, when the political pressure is greatest. In summer, when the dust is worst, it sweeps least.

Uneven coverage across zones

The MCD divides Delhi into 12 zones, each assigned a fixed number of machines. Central and South have the largest fleets (7 each), followed by West and Najafgarh (6

Is your ward, zone covered? Find out on the new dashboard

Finally, a month-wise data analysis was conducted to determine how much of Delhi was being covered by these MRSMs. The result: A sample day from a specific zone, which is representative of the median data, is generated showing the route covered and the time where the machine reached a specific area.

After the dashboard was created, The Indian Express reporters conducted on-ground verification, travelling on MRSMs along key road stretches to validate the findings across two of the 12 MCD zones.

Here is how you use the dashboard:

- Select your zone from the dropdown menu, or type your ward's name, to access the MRSRM route map with coverage routes and time stamps.

- Apart from the route map, a red chart on the left of the screen shows how many median daily kilometres were swept per day across all routes in that zone. And, an orange chart shows what share of the zone's major roads were covered.

DASHBOARD:
<https://data.indianexpress.com/projects/2026/delhi-sweeping-machines>

each), Shahdara South (5), Keshavpuram and Rohini (4 each), and Civil Lines, City SP, Karol Bagh, Shahdara North and Narela ranging from 2-3 each — the count excludes the six machines bought this month.

Shahdara South, Rohini and Keshavpuram consistently recorded the highest median daily distances — around 230-260 km across most seasons. Narela, Najafgarh, Shahdara North, Civil Lines and Karol Bagh consistently lagged, averaging only 120-150 km per day even in winter. The gap between high and low-performing zones remained largely unchanged across seasons. West Delhi was the lone exception — median daily coverage rose from just 39 km between June and August to 211 km by December.

The MCD did not officially respond to an emailed questionnaire from *The Indian Express* on its key findings. However, when asked why a few routes were more active than the rest, a senior MCD official said (*see adjacent story*), “The difference in median daily distances could be because of the network of PWD roads being more in a few zones rather than others. Each zone is a combination of bigger PWD roads and arterial MCD roads. Currently, the MRSMs cover only the PWD roads.”

replace current ones, which are nine years old. Their life will expire in another year. Hence, we need the new fleet,” he said.

The newer fleet will also cover more distance per shift. The official said when a sweeping vehicle is in operation, only part of the time and distance is spent cleaning roads, the rest is devoted to non-cleaning activities such as driving to the starting point, dumping collected waste, refuelling and filling water. “Only about 60-65% of total travel is actual cleaning work; the rest is non-productive movement,” the official said.

Earlier, when MRSMs were required to run 40 km in a day, only 30 km counted as “actual sweeping work”. Under the new contract, he said, 40 km of pure sweeping must be completed over an 8-hour shift. “So, under the new system, the total cleaning work output across all vehicles will be

Asked how MRSRM routes are decided, the official said: “They are determined by traffic congestion — like at Ring Road, where there is movement of heavy vehicles such as buses. Beyond the designated fleet, machines are often deployed in response to requests from senior officials for their respective zones. For example, since many VIP residences are located in the Central Zone, a larger share of the fleet is allocated there.”

Limited reach, repeated hotspots

Across this period, coverage of major roads remained just above the halfway mark. In summer, only 51.59 per cent of major roads were covered. Coverage improved in monsoon to about 60 per cent, rising marginally in the post-monsoon period. It stood at 60.5 per cent in November, when stricter pollution response measures were in place, before dropping to 41.24 per cent by March 2026.

Over the one year, the fleet collectively covered a maximum of 2,891 km — about 70.38 per cent of Delhi's major roads. When all motorable roads are taken into account, only around 23.31 per cent were covered at any point.

Spatial mapping of sweeping activity showed machines repeatedly logging high movement in the same clusters: Wazirpur Industrial Area, Model Town, Seelampur, Dilshad Garden and, from November onwards, Okhla Industrial Area — all locations identified by the Delhi Environment Department as dust pollution hotspots.

Why these machines matter

A 2020 audit by TERI found that MRSMs “are certified as PM10 efficient or capable of picking up greater than or equal to 80% of PM10 particles which is stirred up from vehicular traffic on paved roadways”. The report pointed to Indore, officially one of the country's cleanest cities, where the use of MRSMs brought respirable suspended particulate matter levels down considerably, from 145 mg/Nm³ to 75-80 mg/Nm³.

The last available official break-up of these MRSMs is from April 2025, according to the Delhi Environment Department: MCD (52), National Highways Authority of India (20), New Delhi Municipal Council (6), Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (3), Delhi Cantonment Board (3), National Capital Region Transport Corporation (1), and Central Public Works Department (1).

“The fleets under a few of these agencies have changed since last year. For instance, a total of six MRSMs, each costing Rs 58.69 lakh, were added to the MCD's fleet last month and eight more have been procured,” the MCD official said.

Night shift: 30 km, 1,200 kg dust

contributors to Delhi's air pollution.

The *Indian Express* spent two nights tracking two MRSMs on two routes, 30 km apart, till the Okhla landfill, to find how the system functions in practice and the constraints it operates under. The first track began at the MCD dock near the stadium. The second covered the longest route that night — around 70 km — along the Najafgarh zone.

‘Difficulties during peak pollution’

It's around 9 pm, and PM2.5 levels in the area have pushed air quality into the ‘poor’ category — a long way from the 60 microgrammes per cubic metre that signals clean air. Pollution peaks often complicate operations. “There are difficulties during pollution peak periods,” says a supervisor, adding that workers wear masks in such conditions.

At around 10 pm, the machine (route code HQEM_HQEM_4498) eases out of the dock onto Maa Anand Mai Marg. Beneath the vehicle, rotating brushes lower towards the road surface while suction pipes and water nozzles slide into position, part of a nightly routine repeated across Delhi.

A route supervisor shows how the large brush with bristles disturbs the settled dust while a suction pump pulls it into the vehicle's container. “Water is released after sweeping so that once the dust is removed, the road is washed to prevent its resuspension,” he says.

From a distance, the machine appears to glide quietly through empty roads. In reality, it is part of a tightly coordinated, labour-intensive operation involving multiple workers, repeated dumping trips, manual intervention, and constant adjustments to traffic and road conditions.

Once sweeping begins, the machine slows, crawling at about 8 kmph. Saravan (25), a sanitation worker, and the supervisor step down from the cabin, walking alongside the vehicle to guide the driver, monitor the rotating brushes, and assess road conditions. A shovel hangs from the front of the machine. If dust is not collected due to obstacles, Saravan pushes it manually. “We almost travel 30 km on foot and sit occasionally for about 8 km in the vehicle. Even during peak winters and summer pollution, we have to work only by covering our faces,” he says.

Despite mechanisation, each MRSRM still requires a driver, a sanitation worker, and a supervisor. On the road, the workers' faces are hidden behind cloth masks, with no specialised personal protective equipment in sight.

At some sections, trucks, buses and commercial carriers continue to ply the stretch, disturbing settled dust each time they pass. “The machine works better depending on the quality of the roads. The better the road, the better its efficiency,” the supervisor says. Uneven surfaces, broken stretches, and construction activity frequently disrupt sweeping and force route adjustments. Each vehicle typically covers between 50 km and 70 km in a night, of which 35 km should be actively swept, according to Delhi's Environment Department. The remaining time is spent navigating traffic, stopping for manual clearing, or travelling to dumping sites.

From Maa Anand Mai Marg and Kalkaji Mandir, the machine moves through Govindpuri, the Kalkaji bus depot, Indira Kalyan Vihar, the ESI Hospital stretch, and nearby industrial pockets. By around 2 am, it reaches the Okhla landfill, completing one full round. In this round, 1,200 kg of dust has been collected. “The collected dust is usually higher. Even now the container wasn't full,” says Saravan, as the driver empties the load amid multiple dust mounds deposited by other vehicles.

At the landfill, Chandrashekhar, a junior engineer with the MCD, explains what happens next. “The dust and loose soil brought here are deposited and then levelled using JCBs and other heavy machinery. Paths are created over the levelled material,” he says. Dust that mixes with municipal waste is sent for bio-remediation. After bio-remediation, the waste is segregated and reused. The biodegradable waste is used to prepare manure,” he says.

For the driver, however, the night is far from over. “When I reach home, my condition is such that it feels like I've fainted,” says Yasin (35), who has been driving MRSMs for three to four years. “Breaks rarely exceed ten minutes during the eight-hour night shift. The vehicles run every day. We manage cough and cold, and try to cover our faces,” he says. At home, his wife and seven-year-old daughter wait. “They worry a lot when pollution and winter are at their peak and I have to go out working,” he says.

‘This route is very dirty today’

Nearly 30 kilometres away, it's another night and a similar scene unfolds in Delhi's Najafgarh zone. Here, the difficulties are sharper. At 10 pm, a fleet of five MRSMs departs from Dwarka Sector 3. Earlier seven in number, two vehicles have been shifted to the Central Zone.

The *Indian Express* accompanied one of these MRSMs (route code MCD_MCD_3535_M) from Goyla Dairy through Deenpur village, Jhatikara More, Chhawla drain, Roshanpura, and Chhawla Stand. It's a bumpy ride. “This route is very dirty today,” says Amit, the driver, over a phone call to his supervisor. One side of the road is occupied by local vendors and parked vehicles. Along the central verge, cows feed from plastic bags.

The sanitation inspector, in a green reflector vest, steps down repeatedly, shooing away cattle and clearing cow dung with a rusty shovel. “We try to come after 10 pm so traffic reduces, but many times the road is blocked. This is the dirtiest area of the zone because of the dairy nearby,” says MCD supervisor Dharamveer. Large trucks carrying chaff pass through the night, dropping debris along the way. “Even if we clean it, after a few minutes the dust returns,” he says.

Inside the cabin, Amit repeatedly switches the brush on and off as garbage clogs the vacuum. When waste piles up, the sanitation worker removes it manually and dumps it on the roadside. The unpaved arterial roads nearby, Dharamveer adds, make dust mitigation almost impossible. “No matter how much we try to polish the road, its dust will return sooner or later,” he says. Throughout the route, all three men provide real-time updates on WhatsApp groups, sometimes with geo-tagged photographs taken in front of the MRSRM.

Two hours into the shift, the vehicle breaks down when a pipe snaps. “The machines are already eight years old. Their lifespan is 8-10 years,” says an official on site. At the dump site in Dwarka Sector 12, an open stretch beside an MCD dhalao, dust lies uncovered. “Our job is to dump the dust on land allotted by the MCD. From here, it is taken to the Okhla landfill,” an official says.

MCD to add 70 road sweepers by October, plans app for real-time tracking

Drishti Jain & Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, May 24

THE MUNICIPAL Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will add at least 70 mechanised road sweeping machines (MRSMs) to its fleet by October, ahead of the capital's high-pollution season — a move aimed at expanding coverage and replacing ageing equipment, according to senior corporation officials.

The officials were responding to a key finding of an investigation by *The Indian Express*, showing that the city's fleet of mechanised sweeping machines is far short of what has been recommended.

Officially, the MCD did not respond to a questionnaire sent by *The Indian Express* on the findings of its investigation that analysed GPS data of MRSRM operations in the capital.

The officials, meanwhile, said the new machines will be deployed on redesigned routes and operated under revised performance benchmarks that more precisely define “actual sweeping” work.

The expansion comes alongside efforts by the MCD to address inefficiencies in current operations, including gaps in GPS-based monitoring, the official said. The civic body also plans to introduce a “public-facing” app for real-time tracking of sweeping vehicles, as part of a broader push toward greater transparency.

A senior MCD official, with whom the findings of the investigation were first shared, said tenders were floated on April 2 for the purchase of 70 MRSMs. The new vehicles, he said, will operate on routes identified in a more “scientific” manner, alongside existing ones.

“Some of the new machines will also

Coming soon

- 70 new sweeping machines by October
- Routes redesigned more scientifically
- New IT push to fix GPS gaps
- Public app for real-time vehicle tracking

2,800 km per day,” he said.

Responding to another finding of the investigation, about lesser MRSRM coverage during summer, he said data uploaded in the public domain could, in some instances, be inaccurate.

According to the official, the current system uses SIM-based GPS tracking, which means vehicles send location data through mobile networks. This, he said, can result in delays or failures for four reasons. GPS data is not always sent instantly;

network issues delay data packets; routes may not be mapped perfectly; and the API (the software system that collects data) may not receive information properly. “This can make it look like there is a gap or inconsistency. The discrepancy is only in live monitoring, not in cumulative records,” he said.

The MCD has hired a new IT vendor to fix these discrepancies, the official said. “The new vendor is also working on enhancing the technology. Currently, data available to the public includes the date, time and route of the machines, but now we are planning that when these 70 are deployed, we will develop an app where people can see which vehicles are passing through their area, what the issues are, and what is not,” he said.

Under the new tender, operators will also be required to integrate IoT (Internet

of Things) systems. “They will use IoT, which means the vehicles will be equipped with sensors, GPS and software that automatically collect and transmit data about their movement and work, such as their exact location, the distance they have covered for cleaning, and the routes they have followed, without requiring any manual reporting from operators,” the official said.

The aim, he said, is to enable real-time tracking with live updates, ensure transparency by preventing false reporting, and reduce human interference to make the process more automated, accurate and data-driven. “We have asked them (the vendor) to research and tell us what technologies they will apply and where, for data transfers, so as to provide real-time and transparent data to the public,” he said.



Pat From Top

THE CONGRESS high command appears to be pleased with the way NSUI president Vinod Jakhar has led the protests against the NEET-UG paper leak in different cities. Party sources said Rahul Gandhi sees great potential in Jakhar as a leader ready to hit the streets “without being intimidated”. Gandhi has communicated to the Congress student wing chief to continue holding the protests for the next one week. Over the past few days, Jakhar has led the protests in several cities, including Guwahati, Hyderabad and Jaipur, demanding resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Unlikely ally

WITH ASSEMBLY polls less than a year away in Uttarakhand, Congress veteran and former CM Harish Rawat appears to have got an unlikely cheerleader — former BJP CM and former Governor Bhagat Singh Koshyari. At an event in Dehradun on Saturday for the release of a documentary on Rawat’s political and social life, Koshyari not only shared the stage with the Congress stalwart but also reached for A B Vajpayee’s trademark optimism. Quoting the late PM’s famous line, “*Haar nahi manunga, raar nahi thanunga*”, he advised Rawat to keep fighting on politically. The optics was hard to miss in a state where Rawat remains the Congress’s tallest face and his CM ambitions are an open secret.

FIRST ADDRESS SINCE TMC’S DEFEAT IN BENGAL POLLS

Mamata slams ‘bulldozer politics’, questions BJP win

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, May 24

IN HER first major address via Facebook Live since her party lost power in West Bengal, TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Sunday launched a scathing attack on the new BJP government, accusing it of unleashing “bulldozer politics” and altering the poll outcome through “massive institutional rigging”. “Was this truly an election, or merely a mockery in the name of democracy?” the former CM asked as she alleged widespread poll irregularities, claiming that nearly one crore voters were deleted from electoral roll through the Election Commission’s “logical discrepancy” model.

Alleging that Opposition agents were forcibly removed from counting halls, she said, “BJP workers entered counting centres wearing uniforms of the Central forces, and our agents’ ID cards were snatched away... We would have won over 200 seats, but the outcome was all-



TMC chief Mamata Banerjee speaks on Facebook Live

tered. If they had truly won, why is there no celebration among the people?” She said the TMC would pursue legal remedies in constituencies where questions remained over the conduct of polls.

Condemning the ongoing anti-encroachment and eviction drives targeting street vendors and hawkers in Kolkata and nearby areas, Mamata said the administration was operating through brute force. “Today, the protector has become the predator... Municipal councillors are being arrested every day. The (Kolkata) Mayor and the chairman are kept un-

aware, yet the corporation is making decisions without any hearings. Those shouting *chor, chor* (thief, thief) are all outsiders who do not understand the culture of Bengal. That is why bulldozer politics is being used,” she said, referring to demolition notices sent to party leaders. She called the demolition of a statue near Salt Lake Stadium that was conceptualised and designed by her, and the tearing down of party offices a “personal vendetta”.

Contrasting the BJP government’s coming to power with her own, after having ended Left Front’s over two-decade rule in 2011, Mamata said, “In my administration, 30 per cent of panchayats were under the control of the Opposition parties, but we never forced them to stop working. Now, even the Kolkata Municipal Corporation is not being allowed to function properly.”

“After coming to power in 2011, we ensured Rabindra Sangeet was played. But this time,

even Rabindra Jayanti was not observed properly,” she said.

Accusing the BJP of using political pressure and intimidation against opponents, she said, “The more the BJP tortures TMC in Bengal, the more problems it will face in New Delhi... Our party workers and elected representatives are being tortured and intimidated, but we are holding on.”

She also accused the BJP government of failing to deliver on key welfare schemes while repackaging old financial policies.

“We are ready to fight, and we will not give up till the end,” she said, adding that from now on she would be communicating through Facebook Live.

“Those who are watching me on Facebook Live today, I want to tell them that I will speak to you through Facebook Live only. Now, no media is of the people. It is Godi media... My weapon is my Facebook Live... Keep a watch on our party’s social media handles,” she said as she signed off.

AFTER BREAKTHROUGH IN LADAKH TALKS

Avoid excitement, undue pessimism, says panel member

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, May 24

DAYS AFTER talks between the Centre and representatives from Ladakh made significant progress, reaching an “in principle understanding” on key issues, the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) co-chairman has warned against “unnecessary excitement or undue pessimism”.

Sajjad Hussain Kargili, who is part of the high-powered committee (HPC) in which the talks are held, said “no final agreement or concrete outcome has been reached” yet.

“Negotiations are a continuous process, and discussions are still underway. As of now, no final agreement or concrete outcome has been reached,” said Kargili, who participated in the last round of talks as a KDA representative.

“We had shared our draft proposals demanding statehood and Sixth Schedule, and the government has now responded with certain sugges-

tions,” he said.

He said the Centre is expected to come up with a formal draft before the next meeting of the HPC.

“Once that is received, we will hold detailed consultations with constitutional and legal experts, along with the respected representatives of the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) and Leh Apex Body (LAB), to carefully examine whether the proposed framework truly safeguards the interests and future aspirations of Ladakh,” he said, adding, “We will also assess its implications on regional balance, sensitivities, and long-term safeguards and democratic structure.”

Kargili said it would be “prudent to avoid both unnecessary excitement and undue pessimism” until a comprehensive review is undertaken. On Friday, the Centre and the representatives of Ladakh had their latest round of talks, wherein “significant progress” was made.

BJP minority panel chief: Avoid sacrifice of large animals on Eid

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, May 24

ISSUING AN appeal to ensure the peaceful observance of Eid-al-Adha this week, the BJP’s minority morcha on Sunday urged Muslims to avoid community animal sacrifices and particularly that of large animals, keeping religious harmony in mind.

BJP national minority morcha president Jamal Siddiqui said that as per Islam, ‘qurbani’ or sacrifice of animals on Bakrid is considered ‘wajib’ (required) and not ‘fard’ (mandatory). He further appealed to the community to protect cows during the festival.

“Bakrid is the festival of renunciation and sacrifice, it should be observed with mutual love and harmony. I urge all Muslim brethren not to sacrifice any prohibited animal, and to especially protect the cow which a large section of the people of the country and especially our Hindu brothers consider as a mother,” said Siddiqui, who hails from Nagpur.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

TMC MP quits party post, slams I-PAC

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, May 24

DAYS AFTER senior TMC leader Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar was replaced by Kalyan Banerjee as the party’s chief whip in Lok Sabha, the Barasat MP on Sunday resigned from the post of organisational district president and slammed the party’s decision to hire political consultancy firm I-PAC, which, she said, created “havoc” and “ruined” the party. Hersson said that she may quit as MP soon.

In her resignation letter to TMC West Bengal president Subrata Bakshi, Dastidar took moral responsibility for the party’s poor performance in her Barasat constituency and appealed to party supremo Mamata Banerjee to rely on veteran party workers rather than



Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar

“external consultants”.

“If there is anyone at the root of the destruction, then it is that organisation (I-PAC). It has completely destroyed everything... I did not appoint them. Only those who appointed it can talk about it. But those little children harassed us, harassed our workers... I have been in politics for the past 40 to 45 years. Now, a

young girl of 22 to 23 years from the consultant firm, which finished the party, would come and threaten me. Would dictate what to do and how to do,” Dastidar told mediapersons.

In her letter to Bakshi, she wrote: “My appeal to leader Mamata Banerjee is that if you work with the dedicated, old workers, just like in the past. It will brighten the party’s image. I do not think difficult work can be accomplished through fly-by-night agencies.”

She also picked holes in the TMC government’s governance in the state. “Recent alarming incidents of crime and corruption in West Bengal have naturally raised questions and anxieties in the minds of the general public. To strengthen democracy further, greater importance must be given to trans-

parency, accountability, commitment, decorum, and responsibility toward the people, along with core values,” Dastidar, a close aide of Mamata wrote.

A day after she was removed as TMC chief whip in Lok Sabha, she wrote on a social media post, “Acquainted since ’76, the journey began in ’84. Today, I have been rewarded for four decades of loyalty.”

The post sparked widespread speculation about her future in the party.

Meanwhile, her son, Baidyanath Ghosh Dastidar, said that the MP has also resigned as president of TMC’s women’s wing and added that she was most likely to resign as MP.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Baidyanath said scandals of the TMC government took a toll on their family’s reputation.

Congress govt betrayed people of Karnataka, says BJP chief Nabin

ENS & PTI
Bengaluru, May 24

BJP NATIONAL president Nitin Nabin on Sunday targeted the Congress government in Karnataka, alleging that the administration had “betrayed” the people of the state and diverted its focus away from development and welfare activities over the past three years.

Speaking during his two-day visit to Karnataka, Nabin said the ruling Congress in the state was plagued by internal conflicts and accused its leaders of “using power for personal interests” rather than governance.

“The Karnataka government has deceived the people here over the past three years, betrayed the trust of the people, and because of their internal conflicts, public welfare works have taken a backseat,” he said.

He indirectly referred to the ‘power tussle’ between Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and his deputy D K Shivakumar. Claiming that the state government was disconnected from public concerns, Nabin said, “The government here has nothing to do with the interests of the people. The leaders running this government are using the government and power merely as instruments for themselves.” He alleged that

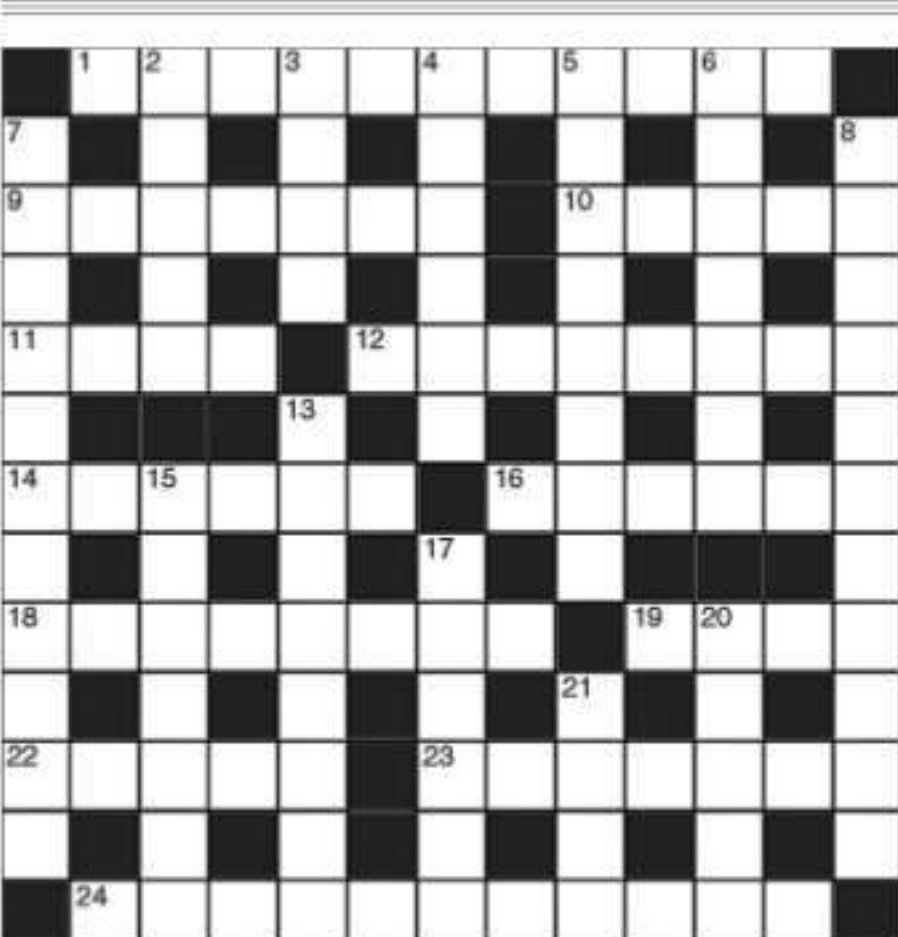
developmental and welfare programmes in Karnataka had suffered due to the Congress government’s priorities.

Nabin’s maiden Karnataka visit since taking over as the BJP president has triggered speculation that BY Vijayendra will continue to lead the party’s state unit for a second term.

Nabin had breakfast with BJP leaders at the residence of veteran leader BS Yediyurappa, who is Vijayendra’s father and a member of the party’s Parliamentary Board. The breakfast meeting, where Vijayendra played host, was quickly interpreted as a reflection of where the power centre resided in the state BJP.

CROSSWORD

5997



ACROSS
1 Only a priest but may show charisma (11)
9 Man devoured by a lion perhaps - a circus performer (7)
10 Tell lies about the bulk of the diet (5)
11 Long period return to a district (4)
12 It should make a Mexican less hot-headed (8)
14 Commercials about smart fashions (6)
16 Risks one gets at home with dogs (6)
18 Stays up when there are games about (8)
19 A drug addict perhaps makes sure (4)
22 So rot affected the trunk (5)
23 Something manufactured in multiple operation (7)
24 Washing depends on it (11)

DOWN
2 Strange how millrace ends in the lake (5)
3 Deep sorrow shown by bishop in plea for help (4)
4 This idea will get you into no trouble (6)
5 Pushed the boat out in Paris? (4,4)
6 Representation of notable authors (7)
7 An oasis should make a good one (7,4)
8 Show how devil and saint rank in estimation (11)
13 Jutted most noticeably (5,3)
15 Garments appear dishevelled on the First Lady (7)
17 Sound move plain to a Russian (6)
20 Reject a goad which has a point (5)
21 A record is made to spin (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 5996 **ACROSS:** 1 Spring, 4 Keepsake, 9 Resume, 10 Strained, 12 Nile, 13 Cobra, 14 Flea, 17 Disintegrate, 20 Demonstrates, 23 Amen, 24 Round, 25 Data, 28 Seaboard, 29 Maniac, 30 Landlady, 31 Enigma **DOWN:** 1 Serenade, 2 Restless, 3 Name, 5 Enterprising, 6 Peel, 7 Annals, 8 Endear, 11 Rose-coloured, 15 Anger, 16 Start, 18 Stealing, 19 Estancia, 21 Damsel, 22 Remain, 26 Foul, 27 Lawn.

JUMBLD WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

When men reach their sixties and retire, they go to pieces. ___ go right on ___. - Gail Sheehy (5,,7)

MSEOO

NOOCMM

NOINO

AINCKW

ANSWER: When men reach their sixties and retire, they go to pieces. **Women**

SOLUTIONS: Moose, Onion, Noncom, Waking

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6329

			1			4		9
	7		5					
				8	6			1
7							1	
4	6		9		8		2	
	8							3
9		2	7					
					1		3	
3	7			4				

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6328

8	6	4	3	9	2	5	1	7
5	1	7	6	8	4	2	3	9
9	3	2	5	7	1	8	4	6
7	4	3	1	6	5	9	8	2
2	8	5	7	4	9	1	6	3
6	9	1	8	2	3	4	7	5
1	2	8	9	3	6	7	5	4
4	7	6	2	5	8	3	9	1
3	5	9	4	1	7	6	2	8

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Oh happy day! Today your communication skills are tops. No one will be able to resist your requests. However, in some cases, you will have to go more than halfway because the Moon is opposite your sign. No biggie. Tonight: Listen to others.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You are the financial wizard of the zodiac, and today is an excellent day for financial negotiations. Discussions with a boss, supervisor, parent, teacher or the government might lead you to a new source of income. Keep your options open. Tonight: Work.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Accept invitations to party. Enjoy socialising. Fun activities with children will delight you. Romantic get-togethers will be full of promise. You have lots of energy. Tonight: Enjoy socialising.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today you'll enjoy yourself. People see you as charming and diplomatic. However, the Sun and Mercury are hiding in your chart, which means you might prefer to take a backseat. Take it easy and watch the parade go by. Tonight: Home and family.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a harmonious day. This will encourage powerful social bonding between people. Make an effort to get out and mingle; you'll enjoy talking to everyone. Groups and organizations are excellent choices. Tonight: Conversations.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): This is an excellent day. You are cast in a flattering spotlight. Furthermore, Mercury will promote conversations with everyone, especially authority figures. You might see ways to introduce improvements to your health and your job. Tonight: Check your money.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): It's a winning day. You have a slight edge over others. People want to socialise today and you are ready to respond. Travel and a chance to explore new adventures will be appealing. Tonight: You win.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Although the social vibes are excellent today, you might feel annoyed with someone. Consider this an opportunity to practice patience. Travel opportunities will appeal. Discussions about shared property will favour you. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Despite your need for rest, you're also pumped to work. Today is a pleasant day, bringing you many opportunities to socialise and explore romantic flirtations. Conversations with partners and friends will be lively and energetic. Tonight: Friendships.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is a 'choose your adventure' day. You can work hard and be productive if you want, or you can play, party and socialise. Accept invitations to socialise. Fun activities with children will delight you. Tonight: You're admired.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Of all the zodiac signs, today is the most promising for you in terms of having fun. Accept invitations to party. Enjoy the company of others. Celebrations will give you pleasure. Tonight: Explore!

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): This is a fun-loving day for you with a mixed bag of choices. You can choose to relax at home and possibly even entertain. Some of you might tackle home repairs. Family discussions will take place. However, it's also a promising, social, fun-loving day. It's your call. Tonight: Check your finances.

Eight of family swept away while collecting mussels in Karnataka river

Express News Service
Bengaluru, May 24

EIGHT PEOPLE of a family, including seven women, died on Sunday after being swept away by strong currents while collecting mussels from the Tatte Hakalu river in Karnataka's Uttara Kannada district. Three other persons, who were part of the same group, still remained missing.

The incident took place in Bhatkal taluk of Uttara Kannada district. According to the police, the victims have been identified as Lakshmi Mahadev Naik (42), Umesh Naik (30), Lakshmi Naik (30), Lakshmi Annappa Naik (60), Lakshmi Shivaram Naik (49), Jyothi Nagappa Naik (34), Malathi Naik (38), and Mas-thamma Naik.

A survivor told the police they were collecting mussels, known as "Kappe Chippu", from the riverbed while holding each other's hands. However, due to overnight rainfall, the water in-flow suddenly increased.

In a post on X, CM Siddaramaiah announced Rs 5 lakh compensation for the families of each of the deceased. PM Narendra Modi also announced a Rs 2 lakh ex gratia for the kin of the deceased.

Search operations remained underway to rescue the missing persons on Sunday.

UCC will not encroach upon rights, customs, traditions of tribals: Shah

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, May 24

SEEKING TO allay apprehensions among tribal communities over the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that no provision of the UCC would apply to tribals and asserted that the law would not encroach upon their rights, customs or traditions.

Addressing the "Janjati Suraksha Samagam" — a massive tribal mobilisation organised by the RSS-linked Janjati Suraksha Manch (JSM) and Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram — at the Red Fort grounds, Shah said: "A conspiracy has started where it is being said that the UCC will deprive tribals of their right to follow their culture and traditions. I want to make it clear today that no provision of UCC will be applicable to tribals. UCC will not encroach upon the rights of tribals."

The statement is significant because the UCC has long been one of the core ideological projects of the RSS and BJP, and tribal groups in several regions have expressed apprehension that a common civil code could dilute customary tribal practices and community laws.

Shah said BJP-ruled Gujarat and Uttarakhand had already made "special provisions" to keep tribals outside the ambit of the UCC. "I want you to go



Union Home Minister Amit Shah attends the Janjati Suraksha Samagam at Red Fort on Sunday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

across the country with this message. Tell people there is nothing to fear from the UCC," he said.

Shah's remarks came at an event that also carried strong undertones of the Sangh Parivar's long-running ideological campaign against religious con-

versions among tribals. Referring to conversion indirectly, Shah said the Constitution gave every citizen the right to follow their "indigenous faith" with dignity, but added that "nobody can convert anyone through allurements or by force".

"Tribals follow a range of be-

liefs and worship nature which connects us to Sanatan Dharma. Today we have to take the pledge that we will protect our faith. It is our faith that will keep us connected to our culture and even our country," he said. The remarks are likely to be read in the backdrop of the mobilisation carried out over the past several years by the JSM — an organisation formed around 2005-06 specifically to raise the demand for delisting converted Christians from the Scheduled Tribes category. The JSM has organised rallies across tribal-dominated regions of central India and the Northeast arguing that converted tribals continue to avail reservation benefits despite moving away from indigenous faith systems.

Its national convenor Ganesh Ram Bhagat has been among the most vocal proponents of the demand, while the organisation's co-convenor Dr Rajkishore Hansda is a long-time functionary of the RSS-affiliated Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram, which has worked among tribal communities since the 1950s and historically opposed Christian missionary activity in tribal belts.

At Sunday's event, Shah praised Bhagat and other organisers, saying the "movement of tribal identity, unity and protection of tribal culture" launched by them was "the first movement after Bhagwan Birsa

Munda's Ulgulan Andolan to bring the nation together".

The gathering, organised to mark the 150th birth anniversary year of tribal icon Birsa Munda, drew participants from hundreds of tribal communities across the country. Organisers had claimed ahead of the event that over 1.5 lakh people representing more than 500 tribal groups would attend.

In his address, Shah sought to weave tribal identity into the broader Hindutva narrative. Invoking episodes from the Ramayana, he said those trying to divide society forget that "during Treta Yug, Lord Ram, by eating berries tasted by Shabari, had taught us that we are all one," and that "by washing the feet of Nishad Raj, Lord Ram had paid respect to tribals".

He underlined what he described as the BJP's political and welfare commitment to tribal communities, a constituency the party has sought aggressively to expand among over the past decade but where it still faces uneven electoral success across regions.

"The BJP has always believed in the welfare of tribals. Until Atal Bihari Vajpayee became Prime Minister, there was no Tribal Welfare Ministry," Shah said, adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had increased the tribal welfare budget from Rs 28,000 crore to Rs 1.5 lakh crore.

Gen Z travellers, weddings: Goa sees opportunity in PM's austerity appeal

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, May 24

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's recent appeal for austerity, specifically his urging of citizens to avoid overseas travel and destination weddings abroad, has given optimism to the tourism sector in Goa, with stakeholders believing this could increase tourist footfall in the coastal state despite global challenges and geopolitical conflicts, at least in the short run.

On the sidelines of a tourism stakeholders' meeting ahead of the monsoons earlier this week, Goa Tourism Minister Rohan Khaunte told *The Indian Express*, "We are already getting many inquiries from the domestic market... All the weddings, for instance, which may have been planned or scheduled abroad... some will now look to change the destination within the country. People will look at Goa or Jaipur... We see an opportunity here. Every family still needs to go on a holiday."

The minister said that even though the global scenario and war in West Asia have impacted airlines and certain restrictions in terms of air travel connectivity, and visa issues persist, there has been a steady increase in domestic and foreign tourist arrivals in the state.

"There is no such thing as off-season in Goa. Many young travellers — Gen Z and Gen Alpha — ... they are not planning holidays months in advance. They often decide that they are



“We are already getting many inquiries from the domestic market... We see an opportunity here. Every family still needs to go on a holiday.”

ROHAN KHAUNTE,
GOA TOURISM MINISTER

heading to Goa next week. A holiday is synonymous with Goa. With this [austerity push], and our initiatives of promoting the state as a spiritual and cultural destination and 'Goa beyond the beaches', we expect the average stay of a domestic tourist will increase to five days, as compared to three-four days. It will be better for the state's economy. We are also discussing how we can promote Goa internationally and to newer markets," he said.

Jack Sukhija, president of the Travel and Tourism Association of Goa (TTAG), the apex body representing hotels and travel trade in the state, shares this op-

timism. "This is a definite opportunity. More people will travel to Goa. We feel the state is well-positioned to accept new demand from the domestic market like it was during the pandemic. Though the situation is different to Covid in the sense that air travel is open... the fact remains that people still want to travel and all the domestic destinations, including Goa, will do well if the austerity appeal finds resonance." Ernest Dias, chief operating officer of Travel Corporation India, said, "I feel that tourists, who otherwise would have travelled abroad, will come to Goa. Travel has now become a habit for a certain income class. If they do not go for a holiday abroad... and if the currency continues to weaken against the Dollar, I feel more domestic tourists will flock to Goa."

While data shows there has been a steady increase in domestic tourist arrivals over the past few years, foreign tourist arrivals are still far from the pre-Covid mark. Conflicts in the Russia-Ukraine region and West Asia, cumbersome visa processes, and "market forces" in the past few years have meant that the recovery to pre-Covid numbers of foreign tourist arrivals has been slow.

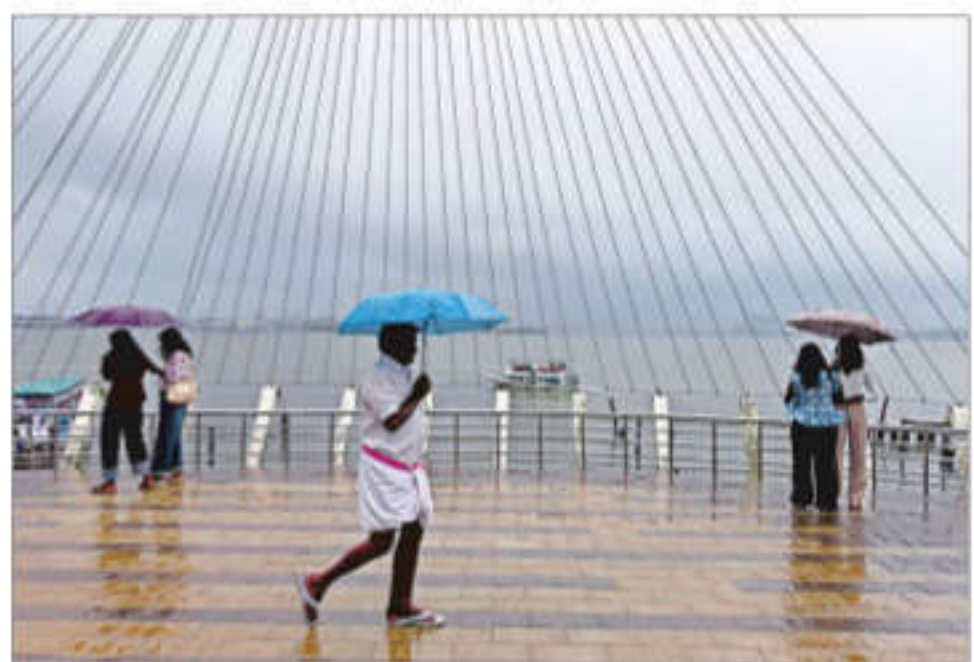
According to figures from the state tourism department, Goa recorded 71.27 lakh domestic and 9.37 lakh international tourists in 2019. In 2021, when international travel almost came to a halt due to the pandemic, 33.08 lakh domestic tourists and only

22,128 foreign tourists visited the state. The following year, 70.18 lakh domestic tourists and 1.69 lakh foreign tourists visited Goa. In 2024, 99.41 lakh domestic tourists and 4.67 lakh foreign tourists visited the state, while in 2023, 81.75 lakh domestic tourists and 4.52 lakh foreign tourists arrived. In 2025, a record 1.08 domestic tourists and 5.17 lakh foreign tourists visited Goa.

Some, however, remain more circumspect, arguing that if the conflict in West Asia continues to disrupt global supply chains and soaring prices, people simply may cut down on travel in the long run. The spill-over effects could mean that the prices of all essential commodities and airfare will shoot up, disincentivising travel for many domestic travellers.

Akash Madgaonkar, vice president of the North Goa chapter of TTAG, said, "There can be two possible scenarios. Goa remains a preferred destination and comparable as an alternate option to travelling abroad. We are hearing from stakeholders that this austerity push could translate to an increase in tourist footfall in Goa if people do not travel abroad. But it's too early to gauge." Madgaonkar said some flights of domestic airline carriers have been discontinued, which would impact connectivity. "If the war sustains in the long run and has a knock-on effect on prices of essential commodities and fuel, people may think twice before travelling domestically too," he added.

BRIEFLY



People hold umbrellas as it rains in Kochi on Sunday. AP

KERALA

Heavy rain, strong winds in Kerala; warnings sounded in 12 districts

As heavy rains and strong winds lashed parts of Kerala, the IMD on Sunday issued an orange alert in Ernakulam district of the state and a yellow alert in 11 others. An orange alert means very heavy rain of 11 cm to 20 cm, while a yellow alert means heavy rainfall between 6 cm and 11 cm. The strong winds and rains caused damage to property and vehicles in some parts of the state. In Thrissur, due to the winds, a heavy branch broke off from a tree on the roadside and fell on a car, piercing through its windshield, while it was moving. No one was injured in the incident. The IMD has predicted an early onset of the monsoon which is expected to land in the state on May 26. PTI

MP: Tiger kills woman, dies during rescue

A WOMAN was killed and four others injured in a tiger attack near the buffer zone of the Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve on Saturday, triggering protests by villagers who later assaulted forest officials. The deceased was identified as Phool Bai (34). The tiger, which was later rescued, was also reported dead, officials said. Forest officials said a tiger entered the courtyard of a house in the revenue area adjoining the reserve, where members of a family were sleeping in the open. ENS

Teen dies by suicide over 'NEET stress'

A FARMER from Maharashtra's Latur district has claimed that his 18-year-old daughter died by suicide due to mental stress caused after the cancellation of the NEET-UG examination over alleged paper leak. According to the police, Maithili Ashok Sonwane of Gondgaon village hanged herself from a tree on May 16. Her father submitted a statement to the police on Sunday, claiming that Maithili had been under severe mental stress after the exam was cancelled. PTI

Hit by tech glitches, CBSE to take IITs' help

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 24

WITH THE CBSE facing technical glitches on its portal for post-result services such as obtaining copies of answer books and applying for re-evaluation, experts from IIT Madras and IIT Kanpur are set to examine the system and help with improvements.

The involvement of the IITs comes on Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's directions. Besides, four public sector banks will now assist the CBSE in strengthening its payment gateway infrastructure.

Meanwhile, the Board has extended the deadline to apply for answer book copies by one more day, allowing applications till midnight on Monday.

The CBSE portal has been facing glitches over the past week. On Sunday, the Board said that last week's technical issues led to incorrect fee deductions in some cases when students were applying for scanned copies of answer books. "In some instances, excess payment was deducted, while in others, lesser amounts were charged," the Board said. Refunds will be pro-

E. EXPLAINED

Concerns over drop in pass percentage

With CBSE's on-screen marking system in place for Class 12, answer books were evaluated digitally this year. Results showed a drop not only in pass percentage but also in number of students scoring over 90%. With parents and students raising concerns about the marking, the Board has seen a surge in the number of students applying for copies of answer books

vided for excess payments, and candidates who were charged lower amounts will be informed about additional payments.

Pradhan also spoke to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Sunday, and four banks — Bank of India, Bank of Baroda, Canara Bank and Indian Bank — will now assist the CBSE in strengthening its payment gateway infrastructure.

2 govt teachers booked for 'attempt to convert' Class 10 student in UP

Express News Service
Lucknow, May 24

TWO FEMALE teachers at a government college in Kaushambi have been booked over allegations of brainwashing a minor student in an alleged attempt to influence her religious conversion.

Police said the complainant told investigators that he began noticing unusual changes in his daughter's behaviour over the past few months. When questioned, she allegedly said she was being "pressured by the teachers to change her religion and embrace Islam."

Based on a complaint by the minor's father, an FIR has been lodged against the two teachers and several unknown persons

under BNS section 351 (criminal intimidation) and Uttar Pradesh Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Act, 2021.

Circle Officer, Kaushambi, Satyendra Prasad Tewari said that investigation was underway and that none of the accused, including the two government college teachers, had been arrested so far.

According to the police, the complainant, who identifies himself as a Hindu activist, alleged that he began noticing changes in the behaviour of his daughter, a Class 10 student, around two months ago. When questioned, she allegedly claimed she was being pressured to read Urdu books related to Islam and "participate in Islamic prayers and practices".

Pir Panjal to Imphal: Manipur's new DGP shaped by insurgencies

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, May 24

WHEN MUKESH Singh, an IIT-Delhi graduate who later joined the police services, reported for his first posting in Poonch's Mendhar in the late 1990s, India and Pakistan were exchanging mortar fire across the LoC as the Kargil war unfolded in the mountains above. For a young IPS officer, it was an unforgiving initiation into policing in conflict zones.

The wars never really left him after that.

Over the next three decades, Singh's career would trace the geography of almost every major internal security crisis India confronted — militancy in Kashmir, counter-insurgency operations in Pir Panjal, 26/11 attack that led to the birth of the NIA, terror investigations stretching from Delhi to Hyderabad, and the renewed militant violence in

Jammu's mountains. Now, as Manipur battles a deepening ethnic conflict between Nagas and Kukis, the Centre has once again turned to an officer shaped by insurgencies.

A 1996-batch IPS officer of the AGMUT cadre, Mukesh Singh will take charge as Manipur's Director General of Police (DGP) on May 30 after the Centre approved his inter-cadre deputation as a "special case in public interest". This comes at a time when Manipur's security architecture remains deeply strained — by ethnic violence, armed militias, cross-border insurgent movements, narcotics trafficking and an enduring trust deficit in the police.

After his baptism by fire in Mendhar, Singh was posted as SP City Srinagar in 2002, when militancy in the Valley was at its peak. He would then move to Poonch during Operation Sarp Vinash, the Indian Army's mass-



Centre has approved Mukesh Singh's inter-cadre deputation as a "special case in public interest"

ive counter-insurgency offensive aimed at flushing out militants entrenched in the forests of the Pir Panjal range. It was one of the bloodiest periods of militancy in the region. During one year of his tenure there, more than 230 militants were killed.

Over the following years,

Singh served in some of J&K's most challenging districts.

But the defining turn in his career came after the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks. As the Union government created the NIA, Singh became part of the founding team. His first case at the NIA took him to the Northeast, where he investigated an insurgent group operating in the North Cachar Hills.

Over the next several years, he would go on to handle some of the country's most high-profile terror cases, including investigations into the 2011 Delhi High Court blast, besides the Mecca Masjid blast and the Samjhauta Express bombing (both in 2007).

Colleagues describe Singh as a low-profile but methodical investigator. Seniors call him a "balanced officer" who is "system-compatible".

Singh returned to J&K in 2014 before moving back to the

NIA in late 2015, just as India entered another phase of high-profile terror attacks. During his second stint with the agency, he was associated with investigations into the 2016 Pathankot, Uri and Nagrota attacks; the Sunjuwan military station attack (2018); and the 2019 Pulwama suicide bombing.

He was later posted as IG and, thereafter, Additional DGP, Jammu Zone.

Within a year of his posting, the Jammu region began witnessing a resurgence of militancy. Highly trained militants began targeting Army patrols in the dense mountain ranges of Rajouri, Poonch, Kathua, Kish-twar and Doda.

"That was a difficult time... But the Jammu police had generated considerably good intelligence. It had led security forces close to the terrorists on multiple occasions," a senior officer who served in Jammu during Singh's

tenure recalled.

Security officials say that by the time Singh exited the Jammu Zone, the security establishment had begun regaining operational control.

Unlike the insurgency in J&K, Manipur's present crisis is rooted in ethnic fragmentation, competing territorial claims, armed civilian militias, and collapsing social trust between communities. For supporters within the security establishment, he is precisely the kind of officer required to stabilise a fractured security grid — someone experienced in coordinating with the Army, intelligence agencies and central forces.

Critics, however, worry that importing a "Kashmir model" into Manipur could deepen militarisation there. Singh's challenge would be to strike the elusive balance between the two views. **FULL REPORT ON**
www.indianexpress.com



वंदे गंगा

जल संरक्षण - जन अभियान 2026



सोमवार, 25 मई 2026 से शुक्रवार, 5 जून 2026 तक
(गंगा दशमी) (विश्व पर्यावरण दिवस)



अभियान के प्रमुख उद्देश्य



जल संरचनाओं का जीर्णोद्धार

जल स्रोतों को प्रदूषण से मुक्त करना

पर्यावरण संरक्षण के प्रति जागरूकता

भूजल पुनर्भरण हेतु जागरूकता

व्यवहार परिवर्तन से बेहतर जल उपयोग

हरियालो राजस्थान की तैयारी

जल संचय जन भागीदारी बढ़ाना

जल संरक्षण जन-जन का अभियान

जल संरचनाओं की स्वच्छता हेतु जागरूकता

जल बचत हेतु जन जागृति

कर्मभूमि से मातृभूमि अभियान से हर बूंद का संचयन

PMKSY



मुख्यमंत्री
जल स्वावलम्बन
अभियान

जलग्रहण विकास एवं भू-संरक्षण विभाग, राजस्थान

The energy challenge is urgent, step up to it

THE US war on Iran has prompted a rethink on the challenges facing the Indian economy. While most of the focus at present has been on the sharp fall in the exchange rate of the rupee, the rupee's fall isn't, by itself, the problem. It is, rather, a reflection of the more substantive weaknesses in the economy. The biggest one is India's high and rising dependence on energy imports. The initial response of austerity — urging people to work from home and other ways to conserve energy — could at best be a short-term fix. It is not a surprise that on his return from the five-nation tour last week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi held a meeting with his council of ministers to review the state of the economy and asked them to urgently explore alternative energy sources.

An economy such as India's that hopes to quadruple average incomes over the next 20 years will need all the energy it can get. For instance, according to the government's own data, between 2013-14 and 2023-24, per capita electricity consumption rose by 46 per cent. But while demand is growing fast, and is expected to grow faster, the supply of energy is a different story. Take coal, for example. India has one of the largest reserves of coal in the world and coal has remained the backbone of its energy supply, accounting for nearly 79 per cent of the total energy supplied domestically in 2024-25. Yet, the government admits in 2026 that the country has "experienced a steady dependency on imported coal over the last decade". The net energy import dependency — an indicator that measures the extent to which a country relies on imports to meet its energy requirements — for coal is more than 23 per cent. This dependence on imports is alarmingly high and rising when it comes to crude oil (almost 90 per cent, up from 85 per cent a decade ago) and natural gas (50 per cent, up from 40 per cent a decade ago).

When it comes to a shift to renewables, India is fourth globally in renewable energy installed capacity, fourth in wind power, and third in solar power capacity. But more needs to be done, and soon. Finally, beyond finding new ways to produce and source energy with a view to reducing import dependence, India must also relook at how it uses its energy. Can it shift to electricity (produced from domestic sources) for cooking food instead of using imported gas? Or so radically improve public transport that it reduces the need for cars? Those are the questions.

Bengal order on madrasas is disturbing

THE BJP'S victory in West Bengal, a milestone in the party's journey, came after a bitter campaign. In the aftermath of the victory lies the victor's challenge: To not let the rhetoric of the campaign shrink the agenda and vision of governance, and to send a message that the government will address and respond to all the people of the state, those who voted for it, and also those who did not. In this context, the Suvendu Adhikari government's decision to make it mandatory for madrasa students to sing 'Vande Mataram' during morning Assembly prayers is a disturbing let-down. It sends out a disquieting signal — that the new government is more focussed on bulldozing a polarising agenda rather than addressing the many pressing economic, social and governance challenges it has inherited.

There is little doubt that West Bengal's madrasas and the state's education system as a whole require urgent reform. Over the decades, several attempts have been made in this regard, including aligning curricula in recognised madrasas with the state board. Yet, the issue of the poor quality of education in unaided *khariji* madrasas and narrower pipelines to higher education for madrasa students remains. Forcing students to sing 'Vande Mataram' distracts attention from the real problem, and in a diverse democracy, creates a new one. School education — whether in minority institutions, private bodies or state-run facilities — must not become a site for a forced performative nationalism. Students and their families must not be compelled to endorse, for the sake of accessing their right to education, symbols and signifiers that may go against their religious beliefs. In *Bijoe Emmanuel v. State of Kerala* (1986), the Supreme Court held that forcing students belonging to the minority community to sing even the national anthem is a violation of their right to freedom of speech, expression, and religion.

The 'Vande Mataram' order comes on the heels of the government scrapping state assistance schemes based on religious classification, including scholarships for minority students. These decisions may be part of the Adhikari government's attempt to counter what it calls the "appeasement" policies of its predecessor. There may be a case to be made that the Trinamool Congress government, like many others across the country, relied too often on tokenism over substantive reforms for minorities. But the forced recitation of a controversial song is the wrong answer. It does not strengthen Bengal's education system or prepare its young for a job market undergoing epochal transitions. The Adhikari government needs to take all the people along; it must step back from a path that will only lead to exclusion and alienation.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

The rupee problem this time is different. The solution must be, too

THREE MONTHS into the West Asia conflict, India has done well to avoid widespread energy shortages. Further, the burden-sharing of higher energy prices between the public and private sectors has begun. Retail prices are being raised, but will need to be increased further to elicit the necessary behavioural response from households and firms.

Instead, the key pressure point remains the balance of payments (BoP) and the rupee. But there are two unique elements this time.

First, pressures have long pre-dated the West Asia conflict. For the first time in decades, the BoP has been in deficit for two consecutive years, and we are on course for a third successive deficit. This suggests a more chronic underlying phenomenon that needs to be addressed.

Second, pressures are emanating from the capital account, not the current account. In past episodes, there was a prototypical evolution: The current account deficit (CAD) widened and became more dependent on fickle capital inflows to finance it, which ultimately dried up. This put pressure on the rupee and necessitated compressing the CAD. This episode is very different. The current account deficit has remained very benign — averaging less than 1 per cent of GDP over the last three years. Instead, pressures have been driven squarely by the capital account. Capital inflows — which used to average 2.5 per cent of GDP pre-pandemic — have consistently slowed since 2023, completely dried up in 2025 and have exerted pressure on the rupee.

Making the analytical distinction between the capital and current account as the source of pressures is crucial to formulating the right response.

In turn, a collapse in FDI is at the heart of the capital flow story, with net FDI, which used to average 1.5 per cent, completely drying up since 2024. What's driving this? Between 2010 and 2025, India's net FDI has been strongly correlated with US 10-year treasuries — a proxy for global financial conditions. When yields are low, India tends to get a gush of FDI; when yields have hardened — as in the last two years — net FDI has completely dried up. Recall, FDI is typically governed by both (global) "push" and (country-specific) "pull-factors." India's FDI has largely been governed by push factors since 2010. The last time it was driven by India-specific pull-factors was in 2005-10 when a strong corporate capex cycle catalysed FDI. In contrast, Vietnam has consistently been able to attract above 4 per cent of GDP in FDI irrespective of global financial conditions.

Why does this matter? Because global financial conditions are likely to remain tight. Sticky inflation and a precarious fiscal situation are likely to keep US yields elevated. Meanwhile, India's CAD is on course to more than double because of the West Asia conflict. Even if the Strait of Hormuz opens immediately, it is estimated crude prices will remain in triple digits all year as supply takes a while to normalise while demand remains strong to replenish inventories. If so, this would translate into India's CAD widening close to \$100 billion this fiscal. The combination of higher bond yields and higher crude prices risks a pincer-like effect on the BoP.

The genesis of the problem, however, is a sustained slowing of capital flows, amplified only recently by the terms-of-trade shock from higher energy prices. This must inform the policy response.

The first line of defence is to let



SAJJID Z CHINOI

The pressure point is the capital account. This will require both a weaker rupee and foreign capital augmentation measures. Squeezing the current account through demand compression can be counterproductive

the rupee depreciate — as policymakers have correctly done — to act as a shock absorber. A weaker rupee will disincentivise imports, improve export competitiveness and thereby simultaneously narrow the CAD and boost domestic activity ("expenditure switching"). Theoretically, too, a sharp slowdown in FDI compounded by a large negative terms-of-trade shock from crude prices would argue for a much more depreciated equilibrium exchange rate.

But while rupee depreciation is a necessary condition, will it be sufficient? In theory, a weaker rupee acts as an automatic stabiliser on the capital account, too, because if it is perceived to have overshoot, foreign capital should be attracted back. But what does overshooting mean in the current environment? To what extent will the rupee need to depreciate — if it is the only instrument deployed — to close a large BoP gap? That is the question foreign investors are grappling with, and it's not clear that any value of the rupee will be seen as being oversold, given the perceived size of the BoP gap.

In fact, if the rupee depreciates too rapidly, it increases the incentives for foreigners to hedge their existing stock of assets in India (FPI, ECBs, FDI), compounding BoP pressures. That hedging puts more pressure on the rupee, further increasing the desire to hedge, thereby creating a self-fulfilling spiral — signs of which have emerged. This risks pushing the rupee far away from its fundamentals and warrants a circuit breaker to restore order.

That circuit breaker should be foreign capital augmentation measures. The objective must be to attract a large enough quantum of near-term capital inflows across multiple avenues — even if it in-

● WORDLY WISE

The great men of a nation reach out to all mankind.

— Gustav Stresemann

An election far away, a crisis at home, lessons in aftermath



GARIMA AGARWAL

The app-based outside option may have positive spillover effects on traditional contracts and alter labour-market norms. It remains to be seen, however, whether and how much workers will benefit

THE DUST has only just begun to settle on the West Bengal election. This poll, which saw historic voter turnout and a new mandate, was being tracked by another unlikely stakeholder — the urban elite. The typical members of this group, like you or me, live in gated societies in metros like Delhi NCR or Bengaluru and are likely amongst the top 1 per cent earners in the country. These high-powered lives are held together by a steady supply of support services from migrant workers, many of whom are from West Bengal and, therefore, returned home to vote in a crucial election.

Domestic staff — maids, cooks, drivers, and nannies — cater to the hyper-personalised needs of employers who have rarely attempted such tasks themselves. Their absence triggered a "crisis" in urban homes. Who had the time to discuss the BJP vs Didi contest, given the more immediate problems of JPB (*ghaadu-pochha-bartaan*) without your *didid*? Instagram reels set to songs of labour struggles showed young couples buckling under the pressure of mundane chores. About a month ago, a popular reel showed a Bengali cook asking his (non-Bengali) employer for leave to go home and vote. The visibly distressed employer asked what the real need to travel was and generously suggested time off during Diwali instead.

This class divide is not new and reflects in the labour contract for domestic work — low pay, a seven-day week, unclear scope of work, and general lack of respect. Workers negotiate terms individually with multiple employers. An interesting development is the emergence of app-based gig platforms. For Rs 100-150 an hour, these apps allow customers to book well-trained professionals for a miscellany of household tasks. Professionals arrive at the designated time in uniforms, request an OTP to start a timer on their phones, wear aprons, and get to work. In return for standardised services and predictable supply, customers are now pushed to respect contractual boundaries. Extra time and tasks are now clearly priced. The entry of an organised third-party may give workers real bargaining power and dignity. When I first used this service in February,

I could book services instantly. I was matched with Safina (name changed), an excellent worker, incidentally also from Bengal. I would plan my housework around her availability and even offered her a regular job. She refused, saying she preferred the app for better pay and flexible hours. When my regular help left for the elections, I turned to the apps again. Safina was unavailable, as were many others. I had to constantly switch between platforms to find one elusive slot, even days later, only to have last-minute delays. The likely cause was the sharp decline in labour supply from Bengali migrants. As economic theory would predict, this negative shock to supply pushed up wages. Hourly app rates increased, and even traditional contracts became costlier. Is this wage revision permanent, or will the market snap back as labour supply stabilises? The scale of disruption caused by an entirely anticipated event has again exposed how precarious the urban informal labour market really is.

The app-based outside option may have positive spillover effects on traditional contracts and alter labour-market norms. It remains to be seen, however, whether and how much workers will benefit. During the election crunch, many app-based domestic workers likely clocked 10-11-hour days. Customers tend to extract the most value for booked hours, but who is tracking the toll on the worker? This worrying commodification of human labour is a product of the same mindset that has perpetuated such lopsided work arrangements in the first place.

Many of us first cleaned or cooked for ourselves during the Covid lockdown or during a stint abroad where labour costs might have been prohibitive. While we talked about our exhaustion for months, we don't seem to remember that as employers. Perhaps it is time to think afresh about dignity and respect for people who provide essential services, create fairer contracts that recognise human effort, and maybe also build these skills for ourselves. Something is not right if a state election thousands of kilometres away can bring our households to a halt.

The writer is assistant professor of Economics at Azim Premji University, Bengaluru

The burden and trap of being a 'good woman'



RINKU GHOSH

For women conditioned by marital roles played by their mothers and grandmothers, adjustment comes easier than self-assertion and autonomy

AMID ALL the haze around the death of Twisha Sharma, her last text, "I am trapped bro", is the headline that raises a larger question. Why can't an educated, capable, empowered, urban woman exit a marriage easily, even when she is unhappy or emotionally unsafe?

The one-line message articulates the insecurity that shrouds independent thinking in young women, especially in a case like Twisha's, where girl meets boy not in a meet-cute but on an app, where both have consciously ticked off boxes, where there is no social mismatch or conflict. That's because for all the spiel about modern marriage as one of companionship, equality and independence, the institution itself remains deeply conservative in its expectations of women. Even in nuclear double-income couples, women are unwittingly carrying the weight of role-playing. Call this a social dowry if you will — an uncoded playbook of what a young woman can bring to the table of family life.

A man-woman relationship is seldom allowed to evolve on its own dynamic once a marriage is finalised, even when a live-in is accepted. It becomes a social structure to be endured with patience. For women conditioned by marital roles played by their mothers and grandmothers, adjustment comes more easily than self-assertion and autonomy. There is also the game of emotional one-upmanship and "mother knows best" tussle between generations of women that complicates matters. This is more manipulative than well-meaning. Meant as a sweet advisory from one householder to the next, it hides an internecine war for attention and relevance for the son/husband. The fact that society continues to define a good mother or a good daughter by how they perpetuate a man's centrality in their lives is the biggest hurdle. If the man is not the prized trophy worthy of attention, then the woman is either a bad mother, a bad wife, a rebel, or a maverick. It's the worst when the woman does not want a child, simply because she feels she isn't cut out to be a mother and is not meant to exist solely for the continuity of the human race.

Young women feel further trapped by the lack of a supportive ecosystem, cornered by social pressure, emotional manipulation, fear of humiliating their parents, the stigma attached to divorce and sometimes by the sheer exhaustion of starting out again. Tolerating discomfort and the status quo suddenly seems the lesser evil. That's why, for all the semblance of independence, they reconcile themselves to societal surveillance.

This subtle tension between privacy and social legitimacy is the reason that the most carefree woman is actually withdrawing into herself and erasing her individuality. Sadly, this silence itself is culturally rewarded, not her ambition or talent. As author Alice Walker wrote, "The most common way people give up their power is by thinking they don't have any." Women may be visibly vocal but chained by institutions that have not evolved to listen to them.

The writer is senior associate editor, The Indian Express. rinku.ghosh@expressindia.com

40 YEARS AGO

May 25, 1986



Raid on Amritsar gurdwara

THE PUNJAB Police rounded up 12 suspected terrorists from a gurdwara in Amritsar and one extremist was arrested near Rajasansi Airport, about 15 km from the city. Following a tip-off, a police party rounded up the suspects hiding in Gurdwara Shaheedan. The district superintendent of police, S S Virk, said the police were still verifying the antecedents of those arrested.

Kerala impasse resolved

WHAT HAD come to be derisively described as the Pillai problem plaguing Kerala politics for close to a year has at long last been resolved with Chief Minister K

Karunakaran's decision to reinstate Kerala Congress leader R Balakrishna Pillai as a minister. Pillai, who has been out of power for over 11 months following a controversy over his alleged call for a Punjab-type agitation in Kerala, is being sworn in again as a minister on May 25.

Firing in Goa, CRPF moves in

A BATTALION of the Central Reserve Police is arriving in Panaji on May 25 to assist the Goa Police in the maintenance of law and order in the wake of renewed violence by Konkani supporters. The Goa collector and district magistrate, Shakti Sinha, told a press conference that the entire reserve police force and home guards

had also been asked to be ready to face any situation.

US, UK veto move on Pretoria

THE UNITED States and Britain have vetoed a Security Council resolution censoring South Africa for its raids on three Black-ruled neighbours because it included a call for sanctions. France abstained from voting while the other 12 members voted for the draft resolution prepared by Congo, Ghana, Madagascar, Trinidad and Tobago and the UAE. Discussions between the sponsors and the US and Britain failed to produce a text acceptable to all, despite some changes softening the original language.



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India faces a 1991 moment: It needs to reform, relook at subsidies



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI
AND RITIKA JUNEJA

THE INDIAN rupee continues to weaken against the US dollar. If the RBI does not intervene decisively, the exchange rate could well slide to Rs100 per US dollar. To stabilise the rupee, the RBI may need a war chest of at least \$50–60 billion, and even that would provide only temporary relief. The underlying causes of the crisis lie largely beyond the RBI's control.

The crisis in the Middle East is finally hitting India pretty hard. Energy and fertiliser costs have almost doubled. The recent increase in petrol prices by around Rs 3–4 per litre is only a partial pass-through of global prices. Similar underpricing exists in LPG, LNG, and fertilisers, especially urea. These pressures are likely to widen the fiscal deficit beyond 5 per cent of GDP.

Foreign portfolio investors are losing interest in India and withdrawing their investments. Domestic investors are equally worried and are not coming forward to invest big. The IMD has forecast a strong El Niño. As a result, the Indian economy is losing momentum. Our calculation, based on today's conditions, is that in the current financial year (FY27), India will be lucky to clock 6 per cent GDP growth and contain Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation below 6 per cent. If the Strait of Hormuz remains closed for another three months, GDP growth will fall below 6 per cent, and CPI inflation will shoot above 6 per cent — the upper band of the RBI for inflation control. The RBI will not have much choice but to raise the repo rates soon, triggering the northward movement of all interest rates. The economy seems to be on the brink of a major crisis. The only rational way



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

to avoid this is to carry out major reforms, similar to those in 1991.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has called for austerity measures, and some chief ministers have reportedly travelled on motorcycles, metros and electric cars. Such tokenism does not last long. After returning from his five-country visit, Modi held a meeting with his cabinet colleagues and asked them to carry out reforms that can save resources, especially energy, narrow down the twin deficits of trade and current account, and restore confidence in India's growth story. The technical blueprint of economic reforms is not difficult to prepare, but what is required is the political will to undertake such reforms. The culture of distributing freebies, at the central as well as the state level, is now deeply entrenched. That's the biggest hurdle in carrying out structural reforms. Let us demonstrate with the examples of fertiliser and food subsidies.

Take the case of fertilisers first. India imports anywhere from 20 to 25 per cent of its urea requirements. The last import tender showed that the minimum price of urea's landed cost on the west

The ultimate solution — the real 'brahmastra' — lies in reforming the entire chemical fertiliser subsidy regime by moving towards a direct benefit transfer system on a per-acre basis, integrated with the PM-Kisan scheme

coast would be \$935/tonne. But it is being sold at less than \$70/tonne to farmers. How prudent is this? Let the readers judge. But what we know is that such pricing creates a large arbitrage — a large amount that is being diverted away from agriculture to other industrial uses in India and also smuggled out to neighbouring countries. Bihar is an interesting example. Government data on fertiliser supply and usage reveal a mismatch. While official figures show large quantities of urea, DAP, and MOP being supplied, another set of government data — the Cost of Cultivation surveys used to determine the minimum support prices for major crops — suggests that actual on-farm usage is more than 50 per cent lower than the quantity supplied. The obvious question is: Where does the rest go?

Anyone familiar with Bihar's ground realities knows that the state has long been an easy route for fertiliser diversion into Nepal. Reports from border districts also indicate that subsidised fertilisers are routinely smuggled into Bangladesh. The root cause is the enormous subsidy on urea, which today

covers nearly 90 per cent of its cost.

The fertiliser subsidy bill, budgeted at Rs 1.71 lakh crore for FY27, is almost certain to exceed Rs 2.25 lakh crore and could even touch Rs 2.50 lakh crore. The ultimate solution — the real *brahmastra* lies in reforming the entire chemical fertiliser subsidy regime by moving towards a direct benefit transfer system on a per-acre basis, integrated with the PM-Kisan scheme. Concerns relating to tenant farmers can be addressed by triangulating different data sets, provided the government gives this reform the same priority it once accorded the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-mobile linkage initiative.

Once this transition is made, fertiliser prices should be left to market forces. That would curb leakages and the smuggling of urea, correct the imbalance in the use of nitrogen, phosphorus, and potassium, and improve nutrient use efficiency. Such reforms could save the government at least Rs 40,000–50,000 crore annually.

If comprehensive reform is politically difficult, the second-best option would be to impose quantitative restrictions on fertiliser sales based on landholding size and the crops being cultivated. If even that proves unfeasible, a third alternative would be to bring urea under the nutrient-based subsidy scheme, raise urea prices gradually, and potentially reduce the prices of phosphatic and potassic fertilisers, while keeping the overall subsidy bill around Rs 2 lakh crore.

A similar issue arises with food subsidies. The food subsidy bill for FY27 is budgeted at Rs 2.28 lakh crore. Yet, if the government claims that extreme poverty has fallen to 5.3 per cent, according to World Bank standards, or around 11 per cent according to NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index, why should free food grain continue to be distributed to more than 800 million people? Rationalising the coverage under the scheme or increasing issue prices for those above the poverty line could potentially save another Rs 50,000 crore annually.

Failing to undertake these reforms would reflect not caution, but policy timidity.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Juneja a senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Fuel price hikes

THE REPEATED hikes in petrol, diesel and CNG prices is becoming unbearable for ordinary citizens (3rd hike in 9 days: Petrol gets costlier by 87 paise, diesel by 91 paise, 15 May 24). While global crude prices and the Iran conflict may have contributed to the situation, the government and oil companies must find ways to protect consumers from frequent shocks. The strategy of gradual hikes may appear moderate, but the cumulative impact is severe. Public transport, milk and other essential commodities are already becoming costlier. Equally concerning is the role of private retailers allegedly keeping prices higher to divert customers toward public-sector outlets. Such market distortions require close monitoring.

Sanjay Chopra, Mohali

Cockroach power

THE EDITORIAL highlights an intriguing moment where an obiter dictum by the CJI risks delegitimising dissent ('Degree or no degree, let the cockroach be' 15 May 23). Such metaphors shrink democratic space, yet the Cockroach Janta Party shows how ridicule becomes a response. Limor Shifman in *Memes in Digital Culture* reminds us that memes are a shared cultural shorthand and a form of vernacular creativity. Blocking accounts under a national security legal framework reveals the fragility of free speech. The remedy lies in a democracy that thrives not by silencing cockroaches but by listening to them scurrying across the cracks of power.

Abhinav Shah, Lucknow

VIPS WHO hold exalted positions should show discernment in their choice of words and avoid dehumanising others and themselves in the process ('Degree or no degree, let the cockroach be' 15 May 23). The CJP is generally perceived to be a youth-led protest movement. Gen Z has reason to protest: It has no significant representation or participation in politics. It cannot be dismissed as a gimmick. Time alone will tell what the CJP's impact on Indian politics will be.

G David Milton, Maruthancode



ACHAL AGARWAL, SUBHASH LAKHOTIA, SUNIL MUKHI

RESEARCH INVOLVES original, creative, patient investigations and analyses to generate new knowledge. The findings are typically published in research journals following peer review by experts. Teaching and research at higher educational institutions (HEIs) are symbiotic, although hiring, promotions, awards, funding, etc. are significantly dependent upon research activity.

A higher "rank" encourages students to seek admission at an institution and thus generates greater revenue, and also facilitates enhanced public and private funds. HEIs' academic ranking on national and international platforms relies heavily on the number of research publications and their citation count, which together contribute 30 per cent of points in India's official National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) and 50 per cent in the QS World University rankings.

The current quantity-dependent ranking parameters utterly fail to assess the true academic merit of research and teaching. In fact, following Goodhart's law that any measure ceases to be effective once it becomes a target, the current rankings are damaging the country's academic ecosystem.

Careful analysis of India's apparent rise in the global research scenario reflects this damage. In recent years, India has ranked third, behind the US and China, in the number of research publications, but unfortunately stands second in

With enhanced publication and citation counts being targets, institutions push their faculty to publish more. This has promoted the emergence of 'predatory' and 'paper-mill' journals

published papers being retracted for unethical practices. While contributing 5 per cent of global research publications, India accounted for 20 per cent of retractions in 2025. Several institutions securing top ranks have higher retractions for research misconduct. Additionally, numerous "research papers" from India appear in huge numbers in journals of dubious quality. With enhanced publication and citation counts being targets, institutions push their faculty to publish more. This has led to the emergence of "predatory" and "paper-mill" journals, citation cartels and financial incentives for so-called adjunct/visiting faculty or collaborators.

The "Stanford/Elsevier" 2025 list of the world's "top 2 per cent scientists", widely "acclaimed" in India, also reveals serious flaws. It considers publication and citation numbers to be a proxy for research quality. Twelve per cent of Indian researchers in this list have suffered at least one retraction, with one having more than 40. While this list includes 6,000-plus Indian researchers, the "top 1 per cent researchers" list by Clarivate Analytics, which penalises retractions and other misconduct, has just five.

Emphasis on research metrics has staggering financial costs, too. In the misplaced hope of improving research quality, India's public universities spend nearly Rs 2,000 crore annually on research journal subscriptions, besides paying, often to poor-quality journals, huge publication charges. The inclusion of private universities will magnify this amount.

What should be done?

A fair, responsible, transparent and quality-based assessment of individual and institutional research must replace the current rankings on numerical parameters. Rather than total numbers, the quality and genuine impact of a select few papers should be critically assessed. Unethical self-citations (institutional and individual) and retractions for unethical practices must be severely penalised. The recent introduction of a "mild" penalty for retractions by NIRF is a welcome beginning, but more stringent action is essential. Unusually large numbers of publications should be examined for possible "paper-mill" activity.

Data for regular, contractual and visiting/adjunct faculty reported by HEIs need rigorous verification since these numbers are often unethically boosted. Student outcomes (for example, alumni performance) need greater emphasis while assessing teaching quality since HEIs are expected to prepare questioning minds.

India's size and diversity necessitate an autonomous Research Integrity Office to oversee and enforce ethical teaching and research practices. Promotion, identification and recognition of high-quality teaching and research across the academic ecosystem should receive the highest priority so that India's enormous talent effectively takes the country to a truly leading position.

The writers are board members of India Research Watch, which advocates for academic ethics in India. This article is endorsed by the full board

We need an autonomous Research Integrity Office

On media, a heavy-handed government, biased rankings



COOMI KAPOOR

THE NORWEGIAN journalist Helle Lyng opened a can of worms by sanctimoniously preaching press freedom and human rights to India. There were several takeaways from the ensuing brouhaha. The Ministry of External Affairs' long-winded discourse on India's history and civilisation in response to the question at hand as to why Norway should trust us simply digressed, unnecessarily making a mountain out of a molehill.

Lyng's query also drew attention to the fact that our articulate PM opts not to field questions from the media, either at home or abroad. Still, that is not exactly a major media freedom issue, as is being made out. Other world leaders also shy away from speaking extempore.

But what rankled many Indians was Lyng piously quoting Reporters Without Borders' 2026 Press Freedom Index, which ranked India a lowly 157th. It's true that standards of press freedom have plummeted of late. Even then, can a report card which places countries such as Burundi, Hong Kong, Singapore, Congo, Nigeria, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Kuwait and Jordan above India be taken seriously? Middle Eastern countries are ruled mostly by despotic monarchs, where a whisper against the government can lead to instant deportation or imprisonment. Indian residents are mortally afraid of even sending a WhatsApp message back home mentioning drone strikes in their neighbourhood. Countries once part of the former Soviet Union, such as Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan, inherited autocratic systems of secret police and detentions — these are not yet dismantled. Business-oriented Singapore views the press more as an arm to enhance nation-building than a medium to question the system.

A safe environment for journalists to work in is one of the key criteria in judging a country's standing. Yet Israel, which according to the Committee to Protect Journalists was responsible for the death of 84 journalists in the line of duty last year, is ranked much higher than India, where the committee lists just one journalist's unnatural death. The United States received a fairly respectable score of 64, though criticisms from some MAGA-



aligned and heartland media outlets of President Donald Trump's erratic and allegedly unconstitutional actions and perceived attempts to enrich his family have been limited. The most trenchant criticism in the US comes from the late-night show comedians. CBS recently ended popular comedian Stephen Colbert's show after 33 years, citing falling ad revenues. Trump publicly rejoiced at Colbert's ouster, reportedly the price for CBS's parent company, Paramount, being safeguarded from facing

trouble at the hands of the government.

Modi detractors who cite India's low rating as a consequence of his dictatorial policies will be disappointed to learn that even prior to the current dispensation, India consistently got low media freedom rankings. In February 2014, India was ranked 140. One assumes that a key indicator of a country's robust press is the plurality of opinions openly expressed on different media platforms. An illustrative example was last year's Operation Sindoor, where there were several voices on just how the four-day war with Pakistan was unfolding, from chest-thumping journalists to cynical publicly aired assessments that the Pakistan-China combine had downed five Rafale jets. Neither extreme position was accurate, but it reflected the wide range of discourse. In Pakistan's military dictatorship, where its most popular leader is still in jail, the media almost unanimously stuck to the government's story that Pakistan was victorious, even though satellite images of bombed military air bases released by India suggested otherwise.

This article is not an endorsement of the Indian government's ham-handed media policy, but simply questions Reporters Without Borders' own biases. Otherwise, why would it elevate military dictatorships and feudal overlords, from countries where popular political opponents and scribes are often jailed, above a functioning democracy, however imperfect? There is, perhaps, a prejudice against nations not in conformity with the outfit's foreign-policy goals, or inherent racism, as well as prejudice against countries with non-Abrahamic religious majorities. The recent narrative of the Cockroach Janta Party social media account going viral in a day illustrates both India's strength and weakness. The overwhelming support for the post criticising the Chief Justice's comments testifies to the openness of our society. The toxic trolling and the X account being withheld in India — on a government request citing security concerns — reflect the growing danger that India could slip to 157th place even in an unbiased ranking if such heavy-handed actions continue unchecked.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

Between Russia and EU, Delhi's defence rebalancing

world, particularly Delhi's long-standing ties with Russia. Reducing India's dependence on Russian defence supplies has also been a stated objective of both the US and Europe.

A major transformation is underway in European security, driven largely by the war in Ukraine, uncertainty over long-term American commitments, and the emergence of domains such as cyber, space, and drone warfare. Europe is returning to classical geopolitics, with a renewed focus on military deterrence. Under the ReArm Europe project (later recast as "Readiness 2030" following objections from Spain and Italy), EU member states are set to invest close to \$1 trillion in defence in the coming years.

The White Paper on European defence asserts that "the moment has come for Europe to rearm". The priority areas identified

by the document include air and missile defence, artillery systems, ammunition and missiles, drone and counter-drone capabilities, military mobility, AI, and the protection of critical infrastructure. Apart from expanding its domestic capabilities, the EU is also strengthening its security partnerships, with a particular focus on countries such as Canada and key Indo-Pacific partners, including Australia, India, Japan, and South Korea.

The India-EU SDP has to be understood in this context. As India has an ambitious

Unless Delhi succeeds in developing robust indigenous defence platforms, India's integration into European defence supply chains is unlikely to be easy

defence indigenisation programme, and its defence exports have now reached around \$4 billion annually, linking its defence industry to Europe seems attractive. However, a significant share of these exports is still driven by co-production and the integration of technologies based on Russian-origin platforms, including systems such as the BrahMos missile, Sukhoi components, and parts and ammunition for the T-90 and T-72 tanks.

In recent years, India has exported artillery shells to a few European countries, some of which were diverted to Ukraine. Russia has expressed concerns, but the issue has largely been managed so far, given the relatively modest scale of such exports. Unless Delhi succeeds in developing robust indigenous defence platforms, gradually reducing its dependence on Russia, India's

integration into European defence supply chains is unlikely to be easy. The White Paper on European defence identifies Russia as an enduring threat to European security.

Buying a few big-ticket items such as Rafale jets from France or submarines from Germany with limited technology transfer is very different from integrating India into European defence supply chains. India's strategy appears to be to skillfully leverage new opportunities with European partners while not abandoning its ties with the Russian defence industry. The task is far more complex than issuing measured statements on Ukraine. Deeper integration of defence industries inevitably requires alignment with wider geopolitical realities.

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U.S. PRESIDENT SAYS ‘BOTH SIDES MUST TAKE THEIR TIME AND GET IT RIGHT’; NUCLEAR ISSUE WOULD BE ADDRESSED LATER

Trump says no rush for Iran deal, US blockade to stay in ‘full force’

Tehran stresses differences need to be resolved

Reuters
Washington, , May 24

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Sunday he had told his representatives not to rush into any deal with Iran, appearing to dampen hopes of an imminent breakthrough in the three-month-old war that had been raised by both sides a day earlier. The US blockade on Iranian ships on the Strait of Hormuz would “remain in full force and effect until an agreement is reached, certified, and signed”, Trump wrote on Truth Social. Negotiations were progressing and the US relationship with Iran had become more professional and productive, he said. But he added: “Both sides must take their time and get it right. There can be no mistakes!” A day earlier, Trump said Washington and Iran had “largely negotiated” a memorandum of understanding on a peace deal that would reopen the Strait of Hormuz, which before the conflict carried one-fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas shipments. Trump has repeatedly played up the prospect of an agreement to end the war that



People wave Iranian flags and hold portraits of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei during a ceremony honouring armed forces personnel and those killed in the war, in Tehran on Sunday. AP

the US and Israel started on February 28. It was not clear whether the agreement he was referring to on Sunday was the interim memorandum of understanding that has been under discussion, or a much more challenging final peace settlement, likely to take much longer. The two sides remain at odds on several difficult issues, such as Iran’s nuclear ambitions, its demands for the lifting of sanctions and the release of tens of billions of dollars of Iranian oil revenues frozen in for-

eign banks, and Israel’s war in Lebanon with the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militia. Various media in the US and Iran had said the memorandum setting out a framework for ending months of fighting would, if concluded, initially lift a US blockade on Iranian vessels and reopen the waterway, which Iran has shut with threats to attack shipping. But Iran’s *Tasnim* news agency said differences remained over one or two clauses. *Tasnim* cited a source as saying there would be no

final understanding if the US continued to create obstacles. In another potential stumbling block, a military adviser to Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei said Tehran had the legal right to manage the Strait of Hormuz, though it was not clear if that meant continuing to decide which ships can go through. Any deal reinforcing the current fragile ceasefire would bring relief to markets but not immediately quell a global energy crisis, which has driven up costs of fuel, fertilizer and food.

Even if the war ends now, full flows through the strait will not return before the first or second quarter of 2027, the head of the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company said last week. Iran’s Revolutionary Guards said 33 vessels had passed through the strait over the past 24 hours after getting permission from Tehran. Trump, while offering various war aims during the conflict, has repeatedly said the US struck Iran to prevent it from obtaining nuclear weapons. Iran “must understand ... that they cannot develop or procure a Nuclear Weapon or Bomb, he reiterated in his post on Sunday. Iran has long denied it is pursuing such weapons and says it has a right to enrich uranium for civilian purposes, although the purity it has achieved far exceeds that needed for power generation. Sources have told *Reuters* the proposed framework, when it emerges, will unfold in three stages: formally ending the war, resolving the crisis in the Strait, and launching a 30-day window for negotiations on a broader agreement, which can be extended. Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Saturday that “the trend this week has been towards a reduction in disputes, but there are still issues that need to be discussed through mediators”.

Netanyahu tells Trump: Israel will remain free to act against threats

Reuters
Jerusalem, May 24

ISRAELI PRIME Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told US President Donald Trump Israel would remain free to act against threats in Lebanon during a phone call about an emerging agreement between Washington and Iran on Saturday, an Israeli source said. Trump said Washington and Iran had “largely negotiated” a memorandum of understanding on a peace deal that would reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping passage that has been effectively closed since the US and Israel launched their war on Iran in February. “In last night’s (Saturday) conversation with President Trump, the Prime Minister emphasized that Israel will maintain freedom of action against threats in all arenas, including Lebanon, and President Trump reiterated and supported this principle,” the Israeli source told *Reuters* on Sunday, asking not to be named. Expectations rose that a breakthrough might be imminent in the three-month-old war after Trump said an emerging agreement being brokered by Pakistan would reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Iran’s *Fars* news agency said the draft stipulates that the US and its allies will not attack Iran or its allies, and in return Iran pledges not to launch preemptive attacks on them.



Security officials remove damaged train coaches with the help of a crane at the site of bomb explosion, in Quetta, Pakistan, on Sunday. AP

Train blast kills 24 in Pak; separatists claim responsibility

Reuters
Karachi, May 24

A BOMB blast hit a shuttle train carrying Pakistani security personnel and their families in the southwestern province of Balochistan on Sunday, officials said, in the latest major attack claimed by separatist militants. The explosion killed at least 24 people and injured around 70, according to three provincial government and security officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity. The attack was the latest in a series of strikes on trains, security forces and infrastructure in the mineral-rich province that borders Iran and Afghanistan, where Pakistan has launched counterinsurgency operations after some of the deadliest violence in years. The separatist militant group Baloch Liberation Army, or BLA, said in a statement to media that it carried out the attack and described it as a suicide bombing. *Reuters* could not independently verify the claim. The shuttle train was carry-

ing passengers from Quetta’s cantonment area to connect with the Jaffar Express long-distance train when the blast struck near a railway track in the provincial capital, Pakistan’s railways ministry said in a statement. The explosion derailed the engine and three coaches, while two coaches overturned, the ministry said, adding that security forces had cordoned off the area and rescue operations were under way. A security official said an explosives-laden vehicle hit one of the train’s bogies in a residential area, and that some of those killed were residents of a nearby apartment building. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned what he called a “heinous bomb explosion” in a post on social media website X. He expressed condolences for the victims’ families and said the nation stood with the people of Balochistan. In March 2025, BLA militants hijacked the Jaffar Express train, taking hundreds hostage before a military operation ended the day-long standoff.

U.S.-IRAN PEACE DEAL: WHAT’S ON THE TABLE

A draft understanding appears close, but major gaps remain over Tehran’s nuclear programme and the terms of sanctions relief

U.S. SIDE				WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE ADDRESSED
● Trump says a preliminary peace understanding has been “largely negotiated”.	enriched uranium.	linked funding could keep Tehran engaged in talks.	● It seeks lifting of the US naval blockade and broader economic relief.	● Fate of Iran’s highly enriched uranium stockpile remains unresolved.
● Washington wants the Strait of Hormuz reopened.	● Detailed nuclear negotiations could be pushed to a later round.	IRAN SIDE	● Iran reportedly wants access to nearly \$25 billion in frozen assets.	● Timeline and limits on uranium enrichment are still disputed.
● Iran may be asked to give up or limit its stockpile of highly	● Release of frozen Iranian assets may be linked to progress on a final nuclear deal.	● Tehran reportedly backs a memorandum to halt fighting across regional fronts.	● Iranian officials say the draft does not settle the nuclear issue immediately.	● Terms and sequencing of
	● U.S. officials say reconstruction-	● Iran wants the Strait of Hormuz reopened without tolls.		sanctions relief remain unclear.
				● Israeli and US conservative opposition could complicate final approval. NYT & AP

Russia uses hypersonic Oreshnik missile in mass attack on Ukraine

Reuters
Kyiv, May 24

RUSSIA POUNDED Kyiv and surrounding areas with hundreds of drones and missiles on Sunday in one of the heaviest bombardments of the city since the start of the four-year war, firing an Oreshnik hypersonic missile near the capital. Russia’s hours-long overnight barrage killed four people and wounded nearly 100, according to Ukrainian officials, and authorities said dozens of residential buildings and several schools had been damaged, many in the centre of Kyiv. “It’s important that this does not remain without consequences for Russia,” President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on the Telegram messaging app, urging Ukraine’s allies to act. “Decisions are needed - from the United States, from Europe and others.” European leaders condemned the attack, with Britain and Germany describing the use of the Oreshnik - an intermediate range missile capable of carrying nuclear warheads - as



A resident sits at a site of a Russian missile and drone strike in Kyiv, Ukraine, on Sunday. REUTERS

an “escalation”. Kaja Kallas, the European Union’s top diplomat, accused Moscow of resorting to “apolitical scare-tactic and reckless nuclear-brinkmanship”. The attack caused minor damage to Ukraine’s cabinet building and to the Foreign Ministry. Kyiv’s national art museum and philharmonic hall, both in the heart of the city, were badly damaged, officials said, with many other historic buildings in the city centre also affected. “This is a war against our culture, memory, and identity,” Ze-

lenskyy’s top aide Kyrylo Budanov said. “For centuries, Moscow has tried to destroy everything that makes us Ukrainian.” It was only the third time that Russia has used the Oreshnik missile against Ukraine since the war began. The Oreshnik has a range of several thousand kilometres. The previous two strikes had hit major cities, but Zelenskyy said this one had struck Bila Tserkva, a city of 200,000 people that lies about 64 km from the outskirts of Kyiv.

Turkish riot police enter Opp party office to evict ousted leaders

Reuters
Ankara, May 24

TURKISH RIOT police fired tear gas and forced their way into the main opposition party’s headquarters to evict its ousted leadership on Sunday, fuelling a crisis at the heart of Turkey’s democracy. Clouds of tear gas billowed within the Republican People’s Party (CHP) building while those inside shouted and threw objects at the entrance as police forces broke through a makeshift barricade. There were no reports of injuries during the intervention. A Turkish court ousted CHP leader Ozgur Ozel on Thursday, annulling the results of the CHP congress where he was elected in 2023, citing irregularities. On Sunday, Ankara’s governor ordered the eviction of those inside the headquarters. The court reinstated in Ozel’s place former CHP chair Kemal Kilicdaroglu, who lost to President Tayyip Erdogan in a national election that year.

China sends astronaut on year-long space mission as it eyes 2030 moon landing

Reuters
Jiuquan, May 24

CHINA SENT three astronauts to its space station on Sunday, one of whom will stay for a year, a record length for the country, enabling the study of long-duration human physiology in space as Beijing works towards its ambition of a crewed moon landing by 2030. The Shenzhou-23 vessel launched at 11:08 pm using the Long March-2F Y23 carrier rocket from Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in northwest China, with three Chinese astronauts on board. Payload specialist Li Jiaying, a former Hong Kong police inspector, is the first astronaut from the city to take part in a Chinese space mission. The other crew members are commander Zhu Yangzhu and pilot Zhang Yuanzhi, both from the People’s Liberation Army’s astronaut division. One of the three is to stay on the Tiangong space station for a year, one of the longest space missions ever but short of the 14-

The Shenzhou-23 vessel launched using the Long March-2F Y23 carrier rocket from Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in northwest China

1/2-month record set by a Russian cosmonaut in 1995. That astronaut will be decided later, depending on the progress of the mission, the China Manned Space Agency said on Saturday. China has sent astronauts to its space station almost a dozen times, but this launch comes amid an accelerating race to the moon with the US, which has warned about what it alleges are Beijing’s plans to colonise and mine lunar territory and resources. NASA is seeking to achieve a crewed moon landing in 2028, two years ahead of China. The US aims to establish a long-term lunar presence as a stepping stone to eventual human exploration of Mars.

BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Suspect killed in gunfire exchange near White House



Police officers at the scene of the incident near the White House. AP

A MAN who opened fire Saturday near a White House security checkpoint is dead after being shot by officers who returned fire, the US Secret Service said. The enforcement agency said in a statement posted on X that the man was in the area of 17th Street and Pennsylvania Avenue when he “pulled a weapon from his bag” and began firing. Secret Service officers returned fire and hit the suspect, who died at a hospital, the agency said. The suspect was identified as an “emotionally disturbed” person, an official said. REUTERS

THE PHILIPPINES

21 missing after building collapse, search ops on

AT LEAST one person was confirmed dead after a building under construction collapsed in the Philippines on Sunday, officials said, as rescuers scoured the rubble for 21 people listed as missing. Rescuers at the scene could be seen clambering over a mound of concrete slabs and mangled steel as they searched for survivors. A probe has been launched into what caused collapse of the multi-storey building in the city of Angeles. AP

VENEZUELA

US holds first military drills over Caracas

THE US military conducted a drill over Caracas on Saturday, its first military exercise in Venezuela since US troops attacked the capital and captured President Nicolas Maduro and his wife Cilia Flores on January 3. The drill, which the Venezuelan government said it had authorized as an evacuation drill for possible medical emergencies or disasters, included two MV-22B Osprey aircraft that landed near the US embassy. REUTERS

IN A DEVASTATED SECTION OF THE CORAL TRIANGLE IN THE PACIFIC OCEAN, A CONSERVATION GROUP IS TRYING TO BUILD AN ARTIFICIAL REEF

On a damaged Malaysian seabed, ‘concrete’ reefs are bringing coral & fish back

Zunaira Saieed
Pom Pom Island (Malaysia)
May 24

THE SMALL boat set off from a tiny island in the western Pacific Ocean, its destination only a few hundred feet away. Its cargo was dozens of chunks of concrete that each weighed 60 pounds, had a textured surface and evoked a white lotus leaf. One by one, the crew tossed the pieces overboard. Then three divers descended 20 feet to the seabed with nuts, bolts and steel rods. As they began fastening the concrete pieces on top of one another, hundreds of curious damselfish gathered around them, and three green

turtles circled nearby. Within an hour, the structure was complete: an artificial reef standing 3 feet tall and 10 feet wide. This construction, on a recent Thursday morning near Pom Pom Island, Malaysia, was part of an effort to rejuvenate a small section of the Coral Triangle, which covers a wide section of Southeast Asia and is the most biodiverse marine region in the world. Pom Pom Island lies off the northeastern coast of Borneo, an area where fishermen have for decades used homemade dynamite to kill schools of fish. The practice, which has long been illegal in Malaysia, is common among local anglers, who

say they cannot earn enough money from the smaller catches they make using conventional methods. But miles of coral reef have become collateral damage. “The seabed here is like a desert, and this is one structure bringing life back,” said Robin Philippo, managing director of the Tropical Research and Conservation Center, the conservation group that installed the artificial reef. Over the past two years, the group has installed more than 60 of these structures around the island, each weighing about half a ton and costing about \$5,000. The corrugated surfaces allow corals to take hold,



The structures are made from concrete with 3-D printed molds. NYT

while the gaps between the individual pieces provide shelter from predators for marine life. “Before the structures were

placed, it was just rubble on the seabed and no fishes,” said Alvin Chelliah, chief programs officer at Reef Check Malaysia,

a nonprofit. “But now we can see damselfishes, juvenile groupers, butterfly fishes are making a comeback at the artificial reef structures.” Still, he warned, “the concrete reef is not a silver bullet.” Concrete reefs are less likely to support marine life that typically drills into natural reef surfaces, like boring giant clams, Chelliah said. In recent years, Malaysia has lost about 20% of its coral cover largely because of rising ocean temperatures that have accelerated coral bleaching, according to Reef Check Malaysia. This can have devastating consequences. For instance, the British government has warned

that a collapse of the reef system in Southeast Asia and the ensuing drop in caught fish could harm food security in Britain. Near Pom Pom Island, where the main enterprise is tourism, Philippo’s group, Tracc, is planning to install another 100 reef structures. Half of those are funded by a \$100,000 grant from the Coral Research and Development Accelerator Platform, a nonprofit based in Saudi Arabia. Tracc makes individual reef pieces using a mold made by Reef Design Lab, an Australian firm that also designs the units. Less than 18 months after the first structure was set up in the waters around Pom Pom Island,

which can be covered on foot in an hour or so, 500 young corals had settled on it, according to Tracc, where a team of five scientists is monitoring the results. “My observations show good recruitment of a wide range of organisms, like oysters, sponges and corals, attached to the structures,” said Scott Bryan, an earth scientist from Queensland University of Technology in Australia who is an adviser for the project. Tracc hopes to bring the structures to Tioman Island, a popular tourist destination off Peninsular Malaysia’s east coast. “Though it is a small area at a time,” Bryan said, “it is changing and improving.” NYT



#ExpressExplained

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• CULTURE

International Booker Prize at 10: Taking stories across borders

Paromita Chakrabarti
New Delhi, May 24

“...TRANSLATION ALLOWS writing to transcend the limits of time and space. I believe in literature’s power because, in the life of the mind, literature has never ceded ground nor given up on the dialogue between people,” Yang Shuang-zi, one half of the winner of this year’s International Booker Prize for her novel *Taiwan Travelogue* — translated into English from Mandarin Chinese by Lin King — said at the award ceremony on May 19. What the 41-year-old writer was articulating was not merely literature’s ability to forge connections, but also the fact that to be monolingual is to hear, at best, half the conversation the world is having with itself.

One of the world’s most influential awards for fiction in English translation, the International Booker Prize, that marks a decade in its current form, has worked to reward writers who write against the grain of the global literary market, of translators who carry stories across the distance of languages, and of readers who refuse to be circumscribed by familiarity.

Road to reinvention

Launched in 2005 as the Man Booker International Prize, it was a biennial honour awarded to a writer for their entire body of work. Its early recipients, Ismail Kadare, Chinua Achebe, Alice Munro, Philip Roth and László Krasznahorkai, were already literary behemoths and the Prize only served to confirm their stature.



Yang Shuang-zi and Lin King at the prize ceremony. BOOKER PRIZE FOUNDATION

• PICKING WINNERS

- In 2025, all six books on the shortlist were published by independent publishers
- Sheffield-based And Other Stories, which published *Taiwan Travelogue*, also published last year’s winner, *Heart Lamp*

transformation: the £50,000 prize would be shared equally between author and translator. It acknowledged, formally, that translation is not a mechanical service but a creative act. The translator, for long the invisible figure in world literature, was finally given a seat at the table. Before that, their names would often be missing from the book jacket.

The first winner under the new rules was Han Kang’s unsettling and luminous *The Vegetarian*, translated from Korean by Deborah Smith. In the decade since, the Prize has honoured works from Arabic, Dutch, Polish, Bulgarian, Kanada and more. Last year, Indian writer Banu Mushtaq and translator Deepa Bhashti won the award for a collection of short stories, *Heart Lamp*. In 2022, Geetanjali Shree and Daisy Rockwell won for the novel *Tomb of Sand*.

A decade of winners

The International Booker Prize has also worn politics on its sleeves, showing a preference for fiction that grapples with the weight of history — Olga Tokarczuk’s associative, nomadic *Flights* (2018); Jokha Alharthi’s *Celestial Bodies* (2019), a tapestry of Omani life across generations; David Diop’s *At Night All Blood Is Black* (2021), a harrowing meditation on colonial violence. It has championed formally daring, structurally restless books that reflect some of the world’s anxieties — war, displacement, memory, gender and the weight of the past.

The Nobel connection

No measure of the Prize’s impact is more striking than the fact that four authors recognised by the International Booker Prize have gone on to receive the Nobel Prize for Literature: Kang, Tokarczuk, Annie Ernaux and Jon Fosse.

Indie publishing boom

Since 2016, sales of translated fiction in the UK have doubled. Independent publishers, those risk-taking imprints guided by passion and a growing appetite for world literature, form the bulwark of the Prize, by drawing attention to fiction from literary cultures marginal to mainstream Anglophone publishing.

• GLOBAL

Amid tighter Green Card rules in the US, why Indians could be uniquely affected

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, May 24

THE US on Friday moved to significantly restrict those eligible for permanent residency in the country, rattling the lakhs of Indians on temporary visas who are awaiting a Green Card.

The US Department of Homeland Security, which oversees the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), announced that those applying for Green Cards must return to their home countries to do so — a sweeping reversal of a practice in place for over half a century.

People can apply for Green Cards in two ways — going to a US consulate abroad, or applying while already in the US, which is called an “adjustment of status”. The new

USCIS policy memo targets the second, more popular route, used by Indian workers on H-1B visas, students transitioning from F-1 visas, and spouses on H4 dependent visas. Indians also dominate the decades-long backlog in employment-based Green Card categories such as Employment-Based Second Preference (EB-2) and EB-3.

What has changed?

Immigration lawyers say the USCIS memorandum makes adjustment of status significantly more discretionary. Until now, eligible professionals could file Form I-485 and continue living and working in the US while the application was processed. But the memo now instructs officers to treat “adjustment of status” as “an extraordinary act of administrative grace”.

“Applicants must now demonstrate what the memo calls ‘unusual or even outstanding equities,’” Rajiv Khanna, an immigration attorney based in Washington DC, told *The Indian Express*. “A clean record and full eligibility are no longer sufficient on their own. You must affirmatively show why you deserve this ‘grace.’”

What happens to Indians?

Indians are uniquely trapped in America’s employment-based immigration backlog. They overwhelmingly dominate the EB-2 and EB-3 employment backlog categories for securing permanent residency. “The wait for many of them exceeds 20 years,” said Khanna. During those years, many would have built entire lives in America — buying homes, paying taxes

and building careers — with the expectation that if they followed the rules, a Green Card would follow.

Now, lawyers say, the very fact that they stayed in the US for years while waiting could become something immigration officers scrutinise negatively.

According to Asel Williams, founding immigration attorney at the New York-based firm Williams Law firm, any push to have Indians return home to apply for the cards could create “enormous” appointment backlogs. “USCIS is currently adjudicating millions of ‘adjustment of status’ applications for foreign nationals physically present in the US. Redirecting even a fraction of those, potentially hundreds of thousands of Indian cases, to consular posts would overwhelm a State Department that

simply does not have the resources to absorb that volume,” Williams said.

Khanna said, “Consular officers in India have, over the past several years, placed a significant number of employment-based immigrant visa applicants into administrative processing... There is no transparency about what triggers it or when it will end.”

These delays are likely by design, in line with the Donald Trump administration’s push to restrict immigration. Khanna added that an applicant who leaves the US for a visa interview could suddenly find themselves stranded in India indefinitely, “sometimes without the ability to continue their employment at all.”

Williams also warned that delays in consular processing could cause employers to pull back on job offers.

What are lawyers advising?

“My recommendation is to hold off on filing an adjustment of status application and wait for clarity on how USCIS will implement this policy,” Williams said. “Indian clients cannot afford even a single immigration violation.” She warned Indians who already filed adjustment of status applications not to travel without legal consultation.

Khanna said eligible Indians should file if their priority dates are current. “The memo does not prohibit approvals,” he said. But he emphasised that applicants now need to proactively tell their story: “Your application may now need to state your length of residence, your tax compliance, your community ties, your employer’s reliance on your work, your family circumstances, and your clean record.”

• ENVIRONMENT

4-letter word everyone in Delhi needs to know: dust



SOPHIYA MATHEW

IT IS persistent, it lingers in the air. It is inhaled deep into the lungs, it even enters the bloodstream. And it carries toxic metals that can trigger disease, damage lungs, and raise cancer risk, especially among children.

Meet road dust — the main villain in Delhi’s pollution story that is quietly putting your life at risk, every day.

A January 2026 report by a panel of top experts constituted by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) identified road dust as a major pollution source in Delhi because it acts as “both a primary emission and a persistent source”. The panel defined road dust broadly to include airborne dust from roads and shoulders, vehicle movement, dry soil, and road wear. It said poor road surfaces, potholes, broken edges, unpaved stretches, road-tyre-brake wear, and debris falling from the transport of construction and demolition (C&D) material all contribute to the dust load.

The report also underlined the mechanism that makes road dust difficult to control: dust deposited on road surfaces is resuspended by vehicular movement, particularly during dry conditions. This keeps pollution levels elevated even in the absence of active dust-generating activities.

Mohammed Rafiuddin, Programme Lead for Clean Air at the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), said, “Scientifically, road dust is a very different kind of source compared to C&D dust. It is a line source (spread along a corridor), but at a construction site, the dust generated is from a point source.” In other words, road dust requires corridor-wide, routine removal and surface management, while construction dust depends on site-level containment and enforcement.

Why it persists

A road-dust committee set up by the CAQM last year said resuspension is driven by continuous dust deposits along road edges and medians, unsuitable road infrastructure design, poor maintenance, and inadequate dust-management practices.

The committee noted that dust from unpaved medians frequently blows onto carriageways. Irrigation practices can further worsen the problem, as thick hose pipes used for watering median and foot-path plantations often spill soil onto roads, which later dries and adds to dust levels. Encroachments and unauthorised parking were also flagged as operational barriers that obstruct cleaning and allow dust to accumulate.

Local roads and secondary streets, the report said, are often excluded from regular maintenance schedules. “Maintenance is

• DELHI’S ROADS CARRY A HIDDEN LOAD

145 KG Approx. amount of loose dust a 1-km road stretch in Delhi can hold

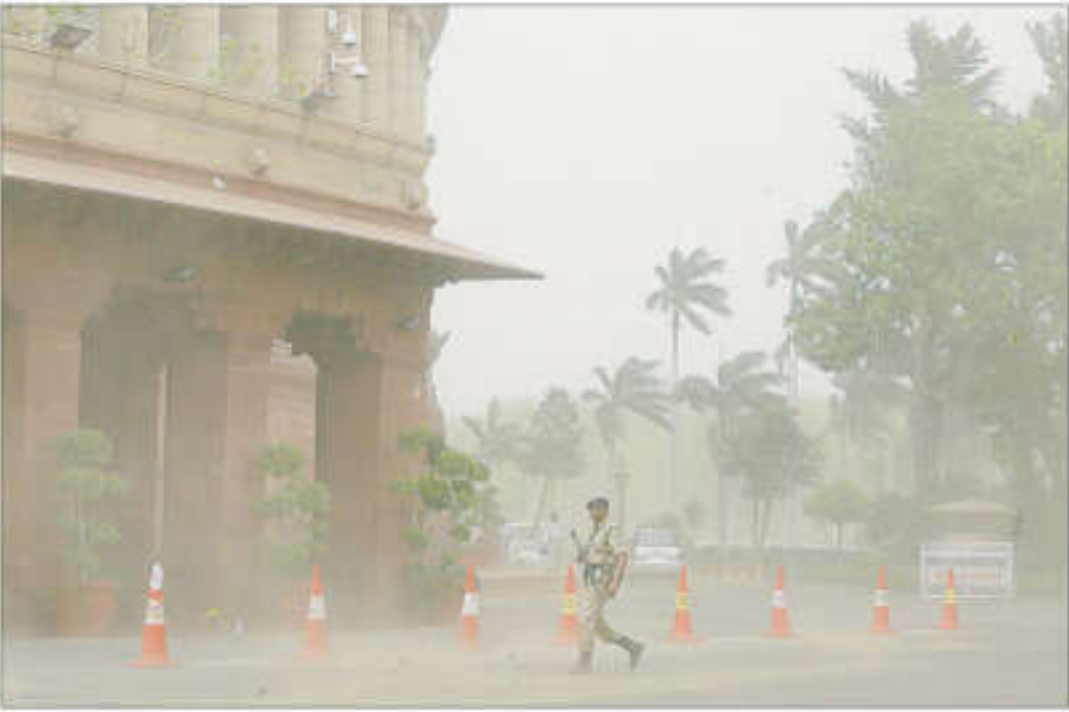
KEY POINTS FROM VARIOUS STUDIES

2016 IIT KANPUR:

- Road dust PM10 emissions in Delhi estimated at 79,626 kg/day
- Road dust PM2.5 emissions estimated at 22,165 kg/day
- North, north-east, and parts of north-west Delhi strong hotspots for road-dust resuspension-induced PM10
- These same areas overlap with low mechanical sweeping zones such as Narela, Shahdara North and Civil Lines
- Areas with relatively higher sweeping coverage, Shahdara South, Rohini and Keshavpuram, had much lower levels of road dust, as per the spatial mapping

2023 IIT KANPUR, IIT DELHI, TERI REPORT:

- Road silt load in Delhi ranged from 2



Aravalli degradation has weakened a natural dust barrier around Delhi.

to 12.5 g/m². Reducing it below 2 g/m² recommended, with regular vacuum sweeping

2023 IIT DELHI:

- Average Delhi road silt load was around 14.47 g/m²

- This means a 1-km × 10-metre road stretch can hold ~144.7 kg road dust

2020 IIT MADRAS:

- Delhi road silt load near construction sites reaching about 40 g/m², considered high for urban roads in India

Health risks

Several studies suggest a link between long-term exposure to PM10 and respiratory diseases

• Last year, a study by researchers from JNU and Australia’s University of New South Wales found toxic elements in Delhi’s roadside soil and dust with the potential to cause cancer and other serious illnesses

and May. Across 32 cities, silt loads ranged from 0.2 g/m² to 111.2 g/m², with Delhi averaging 14.47 g/m².

Researchers also pointed out that the degradation of the Aravalli range has weakened a natural dust barrier around Delhi, allowing more wind-blown dust to enter the city. Nationwide, the study said, exposure to road dust is linked to more than 10,207 premature deaths annually.

What Delhi is doing

Along with the clearing of dust by Mechanical Road Sweeping Machines (MRSMs), the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) deploys a total of 57,000 sanitation workers, sweeping areas where the machines can’t enter.

But the NEERI-CRRI report flags that mechanised sweeping needs to become more scientific, not just more frequent. “There is a need to prepare a standard operating procedure (SOP) for the operation of mechanical road sweepers on a particular type of road based on scientific study,” it said. The frequency and efficiency of application, and particle-size analysis of lifted dust during and after use, should be studied, it said.

Other measures include water sprinklers, mobile anti-smog guns (ASGs), and repair of roads and potholes. The MCD, for instance, has a total of 167 water sprinklers and 63 ASGs installed at roads. There are also processing facilities for construction and demolition waste, Sanitary Landfill Facilities for residual ash and Waste-To-Energy plants to treat non-recyclable waste.

• DEFENCE

DRDO’s new missile offers precision strikes, anti-drone combat

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, May 24

THE DEFENCE Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) last week carried out final development trials of the UAV-Launched Precision Guided Missile (ULPGM)-V3. This will be followed by user trials by the armed forces.

Significant upgrade

A DRDO scientist said that compared with the V1 and V2 variants, the ULPGM-V3 represents a significant advancement in India’s indigenous drone-launched missile capability.

The V1 was a basic free-fall precision missile and the V2 introduced propulsion, longer range, and mid-course target updates. The V3 adds the ability to engage both ground and aerial targets, including drones and helicopters. It also features



Development trials of ULPGM-V3 at DRDO’s test range in Kurnool. **PB**

more advanced target-seeking systems, improved day-and-night combat capability, and multiple warhead options for different battlefield roles, making it a far more versatile weapon for modern drone warfare.

The ULPGM-V3 is fitted with an ad-

The new battlefield

- Development of drone-launched weapons will be one of the DRDO’s focus areas

- Drones are important for both conventional conflicts and asymmetric warfare involving smaller, highly mobile threats

vanced guidance system using multiple sensors to accurately track targets, allowing it to strike a wide range of threats. It can be deployed in both plains and high-altitude regions in the day or night. It is equipped with a two-way data link, enabling operators to change or update the target even after the missile has been launched.

Depending on the mission, the missile can be fitted with three types of warheads. These include an anti-armour warhead designed to destroy heavily protected tanks and armoured vehicles, even those fitted with special layers of protection used in modern battle tanks. It also has a penetration-cum-blast warhead meant to pierce and destroy bunkers and fortified structures, and a pre-fragmentation warhead that disperses high-speed metal fragments over a large area to maximise damage. The missile can engage both stationary and moving targets in all weather conditions.

Network-centric warfare

DRDO has partnered with Bharat Dynamics Limited and Adani Defence Systems and Technologies Limited for development and production. The Ministry of Defence said that the missile has been produced entirely through the Indian defence ecosystem, involving DRDO laboratories and several Indian companies.

Officials said that the ULPGM-V3 has been developed primarily for the Army, with the air-to-ground mode for anti-tank roles and air-to-air modes for drone, helicopters, and other airborne targets.

A senior Army officer said systems like ULPGM-V3 are key, as drones are increasingly becoming central to modern warfare worldwide. It also reflects the growing shift towards network-centric warfare, where drones, sensors, and command systems work together in real time to detect and strike targets with precision.

THE CENTRAL BANK CUT ITS RISK BUFFER TO 6.5% FOR FY26 CITING MACRO FACTORS

Cut in RBI’s risk buffer raised dividend to Centre by Rs 92K cr

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, May 24

THE CENTRAL board of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday approved the transfer of a record Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the Centre as surplus — or dividend — for 2025-26. But it would have been much lower had the board not reduced a key risk buffer to 6.5% from 7.5%.

The RBI said its board decided to keep the Contingent Risk Buffer (CRB) at 6.5% of the central bank’s balance sheet — which expanded 20.6% in 2025-26 to Rs 91.97 lakh crore — “taking into consideration the current macroeconomic factors, financial performance of the Bank and maintenance of appropriate risk buffers”. According to calculations by *The Indian Express*, had the CRB been maintained at the 2024-25 level of 7.5%, the dividend to the Centre would have been around Rs 92,000 crore lower at Rs 1.95 lakh crore.

When the CRB is lowered, the amount the RBI must transfer to its Contingency Fund — a rainy-day fund meant to meet unexpected and unforeseen contingencies, includ-

ing depreciation in the value of securities the central bank holds, risks arising out of monetary and exchange rate policy operations, and systemic risks — decreases. This raises the dividend payable to the Centre.

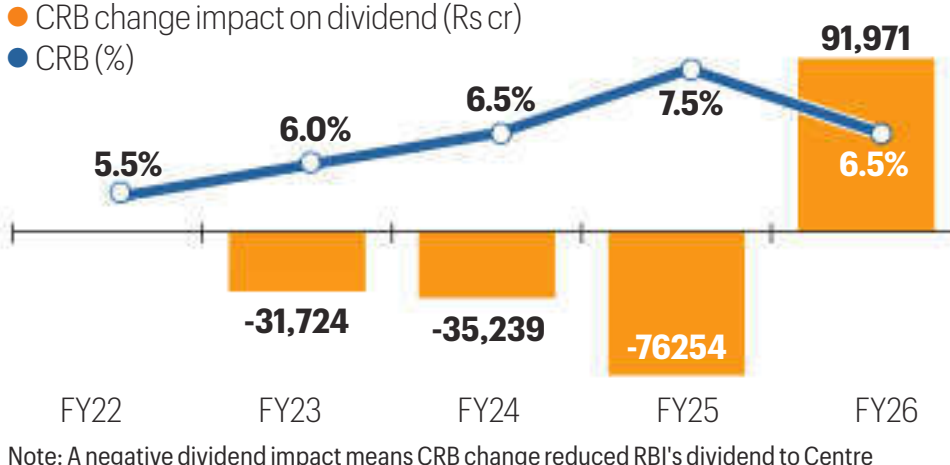
Last year, the RBI had internally reviewed its Economic Capital Framework and the board approved widening the CRB range to 4.5-7.5% of the balance sheet from the 5.5-6.5% recommended in 2019 by an expert committee led by former governor Bimal Jalan.

The Economic Capital Framework provides a rule-based system for the provisions the RBI must make against the risks it faces. These provisions are to be made from the revenue it generates in the normal course of its operations and after it has met its expenses. The Contingent Risk Buffer, or CRB, comprises the RBI’s provisions to cover any potential risks — be it credit, operational, financial, or related to monetary stability — and is the proportion of the balance sheet that must be set aside as a buffer.

Strains of war

Over the years, the RBI’s

• Changes to the CRB can raise, or lower, RBI's dividend to the Centre



Note: A negative dividend impact means CRB change reduced RBI's dividend to Centre
Source: RBI, *The Indian Express* calculations

dividend has become an increasingly important source of income for the government and now makes up around 8% of its revenue receipts, up from around 5% a decade ago. And the increase in the dividend due to the lowering of the CRB to 6.5% will be an enormous source of relief to the government whose finances have been stretched by the West Asia war: a rise in the fertiliser subsidy bill, a hit to tax collections because of cuts to the reduction in excise duty on petrol and diesel, and likely lower dividends

from public sector oil marketing companies who are incurring heavy losses.

According to Gaura Sengupta, IDFC First Bank’s Chief Economist, the West Asia war poses a fiscal slippage risk to the Centre of around Rs 1.6 lakh crore — or 0.4% of GDP — assuming the Rs 10 per litre cut in petrol and diesel excise duty is only for six months. The Centre is targeting a fiscal deficit of 4.3% of GDP for the current fiscal.

CRB and the dividend

This is the first time the

RBI’s board has ever reduced the CRB and comes after it was raised three years in a row.

When the CRB is raised — as it was in 2022-23, 2023-24, and 2024-25 — the amount the RBI must transfer to the Contingency Fund increases. This reduces the dividend the Centre gets.

In 2024-25, the RBI’s balance sheet grew to Rs 76.25 lakh crore; 7.5% of this is equal to Rs 5.72 lakh crore, which was maintained across the various funds of the central bank: the Contingency Fund, Asset Development Fund, capital, and Reserve Fund. These four together make up the RBI’s Available Realised Equity (ARE). The ARE divided by the size of the balance sheet is equal to the CRB. Had the RBI retained the CRB for 2024-25 at 6.5% instead of raising it to 7.5%, the dividend to the government would have been higher by Rs 76,000 crore or so at Rs 3.45 lakh crore, calculations show. But with the Centre’s finances in a good position last year, there was no need for an outsized dividend. As it is, even after the CRB hike, the dividend was a then record Rs 2.69 lakh crore.

FULL REPORT ON

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508-KM MUMBAI-AHMEDABAD BULLET TRAIN PROJECT

High speed rail project: India’s Shinkansen track takes shape in Surat factory

Dheeraj Mishra
Kim (Surat), May 24

AROUND 56 kilometers far from Surat in Gujarat, at a 14-acre factory, over 200 workers are manufacturing a part of a track system being used for the first time in the country.

Arjun Yadav, a site worker from Uttar Pradesh, slides out his digital depth caliper and fixes it to one side of a 4.5 tonnes track slab — which looks roughly like a double-edged razor blade. The machine reads 191 mm. Relieved, he marks “OK” on its surface. This is the 36,112th number of the track slab manufactured at the Kim, one of the two facilities in Gujarat for the 508-km Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail project.

What Yadav measured was the thickness of the track slab, which was prepared after more than 12 hours of the rigorous work. Even a minor error could have marked it redundant.

This is what will eventually hold the rail.

The country’s high-speed dreams are now being expedited with faster laying of track slabs, which is among the last works before bullet trains will run, as the 48-km Surat-Bilimora stretch of the 508-km project is scheduled to be completed by August 2027. The entire corridor from Ahmedabad to Mumbai is targeted to be made operational by 2029.

As per the National High Speed Rail Corporation Ltd, the government agency behind the implementation of bullet train projects, a total of 2.05 lakh track slabs is required for the entire project. Out of this, 75,473 track slabs have been casted in two units, another one is in Anand, and 35,327 slabs have been laid over track bed on the viaduct.

The track slab is one of the most unique features of the Japanese high speed system, so much so that even the word Shinkansen is derived from it.

This is different from the ballasted track system that Indian Railways use for its projects. “In Japanese, Shin means new, Kansen means track. It is, quite literally, a new track,” said an official of NHSRCL.

The Kim facility is the largest one, which will provide track slabs for Vapi to Vadodara section of the project. It was started in September 2023. Out of the 96,000 slabs, 36,000 have been supplied. Its peak capac-



Started in September 2023, Kim is the largest track slab manufacturing facility.

SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

ity is to cast 120 slabs in a day.

Inside the cavernous factory, the Italian bar cutting machine of schnell group runs at a full flow. It cuts 11 types of bars in different dimensions (shape and size) with the smallest one of 4.84 meters and the longest of 106 meters. In one minute, it cuts 30 bars, and in a day it cuts over 10,000 bars.

The steel cage for this has arrived from Japan, there cannot be even a millimeter of error. The cage is created with 11 types of bars and then it is put in the Japanese moulds. One cage weighs 300 kg.

The spreader bucket moves vertically and horizontally with the concrete aggregate-cement admixture. The four vibrators are deployed in the mould for concrete compaction.

The steam pipe from a boiler outside runs down the mould which heats up the concrete for 12 hours at 40-45 degree Celsius. Then it is submerged in treated water for three days for curing. A total of 4.5 tonnes of concrete is poured into one slab. After this process, there are a total of nine gauges which are used to check the properties. There are two pages of a checklist to check 16 items and over 50 points.

Manu Maheshwani, lab in-charge and Deputy Manager of IRCON, works at the compressor testing machine. He said the sample for each track slab is collected during the moulding. To check its strength, it should achieve a minimum 50 mpa (megapascal). It is checked two times, first after three days, second after 28 days. Along with this, a cement cube is tested for quality, aggregate test, water test of its PH and TDS. In total more than 30 tests are done to verify that a particular track slab can be used for the Bullet train.

He said a particular electri-

cal resistance test is conducted to check that the signals are not passed from the track to the slab. “A 6 volt current is passed through the rail for checking the rail fracture. The current should only pass through the rail, not the slab,” said the man. This is a unique system for high speed rail. Indian Railways does not have it, but the metro performs the same function. Railways only have it in the yard area.

Sanchit Garg, overall in-charge and Joint General Manager of IRCON, said 16 engineers came from Japan to give the training. “The factory area, the shed part, is 200 meters. For the lab test, the machines used are Indian made only,” he said. Ravindra Singhal, Senior Track Expert, says three types of machinery have been deployed at the site — Japanese, Italian and Indian.

“In Japan, this kind of factory is for 20-30 slab casting in a day. This is a much larger factory than theirs. They have a factory every 20-30 kilometers. Around 1,000 people have been trained for it. They were taught under the 15 courses conducted with JARTS (Japan Railway Technical Service),” said Singhal.

Outside the 200 meters main workshop, trucks are lined up to load precast slabs and take it to one of the 13 track construction bases. One of the trucks goes to the Vaktana base, part of Surat-Bilimora section, where slabs are lifted to 23 meters above the ground to be placed on the viaduct. Then comes the role of four key machines — Flash Butt Welding Machine, Rail Feeder Car, Track slab laying Car and Cement Asphalt Mortar injection car; all lined up on the viaduct. They came together to lay a track slab, before the rails could be laid over it.

• BRIEFLY

War negotiations, oil to drive mkt sentiment

New Delhi: Developments related to negotiations between the US and Iran to resolve the conflict, oil prices and foreign investors’ trading activity will largely influence markets in a holiday-shortened week, analysts said. Equity markets will be closed Thursday for Bakri Id. The rupee-dollar trend and global market sentiment will also be

tracked by investors, said analysts. PTI

Govt in advanced talks on cotton import duty cut

New Delhi: The government is in an “advanced stage of consultation” regarding the 11% customs duty on imports of raw cotton, and examining if the levy can be removed, with a decision expected soon, according to a senior official said. PTI

How NHAI plans to decongest Delhi with 10 upcoming projects

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, May 24

THE MINISTRY of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), along with the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), will begin work on key projects by the end of the year to decongest the national capital, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said last week.

After inspecting the six-lane access-controlled DND-Faridabad-Ballabhgarh corridor with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Gadkari outlined the status of 10 upcoming projects covering 186 km at a cost of Rs 34,800 crore. These projects have been specifically planned to decongest Delhi by diverting freight traffic and providing connectivity to key centres in the region such as the Noida International Airport. The 59-km, 6-lane DND-Ballabhgarh corridor is nearing completion and will connect to Delhi-Mumbai Expressway and Western Peripheral Expressway.

Why congestion is a challenge in Delhi?

Despite the continuous development of metro network and increase in buses, the traffic congestion has remained a challenge for Delhi.

It is due to multiple factors like diverse socio-economic issues, population growth, increasing number of private vehicles, cargo vehicles etc.

A Delhi traffic police survey in March 2024 identified congestion at 134 locations or stretches, mainly due to ongoing construction works by various civic agencies, encroachment and heavy traffic volume. The agency also found 128 bad conditioned/potholed roads and 97 damaged/en-

• NEW CORRIDORS

● The projects will cover 186 km at a cost of Rs 34,800 cr, and have been planned to decongest the city by diverting freight traffic

● They will provide connectivity to key centres in the region such as the Noida International Airport

● 59-km, 6-lane DND-Ballabhgarh corridor is nearly complete, and will connect to Delhi-Mumbai Expressway and Western Peripheral Expressway

croached footpaths.

While the problem requires a multi-layered solution involving civic and state authorities, one of them is to divert the cargo vehicles not destined for Delhi, away from the city’s roads.

MoRTH and NHAI are primarily responsible for the development and maintenance of the National Highways. However, it has an integral role to play in decongesting Delhi by diverting cargo vehicles.

These highways projects for decongestion are a transit route for the cargo and other vehicles to other states without entering the city.

What are these projects?

The highway ministry prepared a Delhi Decongestion Plan in 2015. It involved the construction of expressways, ring roads, tunnels, elevated corridor for a modern transport network, which not only provide hassle-free movement, but also saved fuel.

One of these upcoming key projects are connecting Urban Extension Road-II (UER II) to Delhi-Dehradun Expressway.

The 17-km and six lane project will connect the newly opened expressway near Tronica city in Ghaziabad. Gadkari said the alignment of the project is in the final stage and its work will tentatively begin by December.

“This will help in reducing the traffic congestion on stretches IGI Airport, Barapullah Nala, Mukarba Chowk, Singhu border, Ashram-Badarpur. Also, areas like Dwarka, Rohini, Punjabi Bagh, Gurugram will get direct connectivity with Dehradun expressway,” he said. Another similar project is 65-km highway from Delhi-Dehradun expressway to Noida-Faridabad, also scheduled to begin by December. The project will act as an integration corridor connecting Delhi-Dehradun, Delhi-Meerut, DND, Faridabad and Yamuna Expressway.

The other proposed project, as part of Delhi Decongestion, is Delhi-Amritsar-Katra connectivity to UER-II, where the work will tentatively begin by March 2027. “With this project, the traffic coming through Delhi-Katra expressway will be diverted to UER-II and Dwarka Expressway. It will help in heavy traffic diversion and make freight movement more efficient,” the minister said.

The Centre has also proposed building a 8-km, 6-lane tunnel from Shiv Murti (near airport) to Nelson mandela marg at a cost of Rs 7000 crore to provide signal-free connectivity to Vasant Kunj via Dwarka Expressway. Gadkari said Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) approval for the project has been received and the work will begin after the final cabinet approval. **FULL REPORT ON**

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• Rupee at 100/\$, RBI rate hikes on the horizon?

● The rupee’s baseline exchange rate level is now 96-per-dollar, according to Japan’s MUFG Bank, which is predicting the 100-mark could be breached in a ‘severe’ case scenario of the West Asia war lasting longer and leading to global crude oil prices averaging \$120 per barrel.



● It is in the backdrop that MUFG Bank is forecasting the Reserve Bank of India may increase the repo rate by at least 50 basis points in 2026-27. “In risk scenarios we think RBI may bring terminal rates up to between 6.25% to 6.75%,” Michael Wan, Senior Currency Analyst at MUFG Bank, said. The repo rate is currently at 5.25%.

WE CONTINUE TO SEE THE INDIAN RUPEE AS VULNERABLE WITH USD/INR LIKELY BREACHING

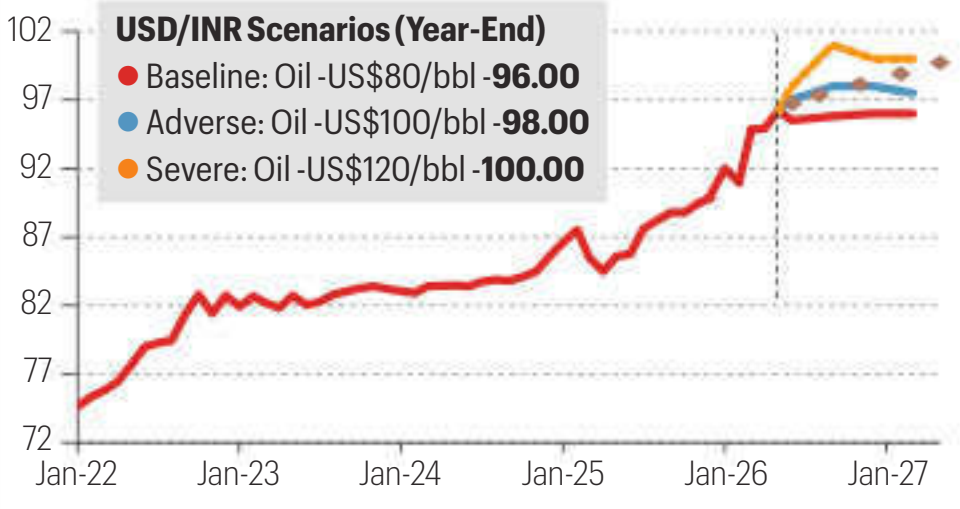
USD/INR Oil and Strait of Hormuz Cases

● USD/INR - Baseline forecasts: Oil: US\$80/bbl

● Adverse Scenario: Oil - US\$100/bbl

● Severe Scenario: Oil - US\$120/bbl

● Onshore USD/INR Forwards



Note: Scenarios based on 2026 average oil prices

Source: MUFG Bank

Align education, skills with evolving economic needs: NITI Aayog CEO

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 24

NITI AAYOG Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Nidhi Chibber has underlined the importance of continued efforts towards aligning education, skilling, and employment ecosystems with the evolving requirements of the economy, according to an official statement.

On 22 May, NITI Aayog convened the first meeting of the High Powered ‘Education to Employment and Enterprise

Standing Committee’ under the chairpersonship of Chibber.

Speaking at the meeting, Chibber observed that India’s demographic dividend presents opportunities to accelerate growth through appropriate policy measures to create productive employment and entrepreneurial opportunities for the youth.

According to the statement, the Committee noted that the services sector continues to play a pivotal role in the economic development,

and highlighted its growing contribution to economic resilience, export competitiveness, employment quality, global value chains, and potential to contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

The Committee decided to meet at regular intervals and focus on identifying actionable recommendations to enhance employability, foster entrepreneurship, strengthen industry-relevant skilling, and accelerate growth in the services sector.

• WEST ASIA ENERGY SHOCK HAS PRECIPITATED A CRISIS IN INDIA, WITH FOREIGN INVESTORS EXITING FINANCIAL MARKETS AND RUPEE TUMBLING TO FRESH LOWS ALMOST EVERY WEEK

Trump rating sinks: Why Indian mkts are pinning hopes on US midterm elections

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, May 24

LAST WEEK, the *New York Times/Siena* poll of registered US voters showed that Donald Trump’s approval rating had slumped to 37%, the lowest in his second term as President, with nearly two-thirds of voters saying his decision to go to war with Iran was wrong.

More importantly, 69% of voters disapproved of how the Republican is handling the cost of living. And the Indian market’s hopes are pinned on Trump being sufficiently concerned with his ratings to focus on home.

“We are positioned for the war to end,” Seshadri Sen, Head of Research & Strategist at

Emkay Global Financial Services, said on May 19. Sen, who has a target of 29,000 for the Nifty by the end of 2026-27 — 22% higher than Friday’s close of 23,719.30 — assumes the Strait of Hormuz will reopen and the energy markets will normalise in a month or two.

“As we approach the midterms, it will be unsustainable for the Republicans and the US government to have pump prices ruling where they are and political pressure will start to get very intense on the US administration to reach a conclusion to the war,” Sen said, admitting that Emkay’s views “may sound a little bit out of sync with today’s reality, but we are looking ahead”. Of course, there is a negative



US President Donald Trump’s approval rating had slumped to 37%, according to the *New York Times/Siena* poll.

REUTERS

scenario which exists, albeit with a low probability. Should the war go on for three more months, then “all bets are off”: interest rates will rise, consumption will slow, input costs

will rise, company margins will get affected, and Nifty could fall to 21,000.

Pain in the USA

Sen’s views echo those of

some policymakers, with Ram Singh, one of the six members on the RBI’s MPC, telling *The Indian Express* earlier this month that a prolonged West Asia war is not in the interest of any country, including the US, where retail petrol prices, airfares, and government bond yields have surged.

Early November, the entire House of Representatives and a third of the Senate will head for elections. While Democrats need to gain three seats in the 435-seat House on a net basis to control it, they need four net wins in the 100-member Senate. And higher energy prices are burning a rather big hole in the pockets of US consumers — as per a new study by Brown University, each household has

on average spent over \$300 on petrol and diesel since February 28. This amounts to more than \$40 billion for the country as a whole. After surging 21.2% sequentially in March, gasoline prices in the US were up 5.4% month-on-month in April, helping propel consumer price inflation to a three-year high of 3.8%, which is seen crossing 4% in May. But it is not just prices that will be on voters’ minds.

“Real wage growth is at best flat, hiring is slow, the labour force is shrinking and the University of Michigan consumer sentiment survey has recently reported the lowest consumer confidence on record in the survey’s 74-year history,”

ANZ economists Brian Martin and Bansi Madhavani said on May 18. “Firms also reported slowing sales growth while plans to increase compensation in coming months are declining. For many consumers and businesses, the conflict in West Asia is offsetting the benefits of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act.”

Foreign outflows

The West Asia energy shock has precipitated a crisis in India: with foreign investors exiting Indian financial markets in droves, the rupee has tumbled to a fresh record low almost every week. On May 20, the rupee nearly breached the 97-per-dollar mark and is down

5% since the war began. The Nifty has fallen 5.8% since February 27. Over the same period, Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have pulled out \$23.8 billion on a net basis from Indian financial markets. Government bond yields have also jumped, with the war straining the Centre’s finances.

“India’s bond market has begun pricing in possible RBI rate hikes later this year, and foreign inflows into Indian bonds have slowed sharply — the 5-day moving average of net buying fell to just \$2.1 million against a 20-day average of \$47.2 million,” Michael Wan, Senior Currency Analyst at Japan’s MUFG Bank, said on May 19.

FULL REPORT ON
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NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY MITHUN MANHAS

Mithun Manhas is one of the key individuals responsible for the development of Jammu & Kashmir cricket, a team that became Ranji champions. Now at the helm of BCCI, he has a lot on his plate like the cricketing ties with Pakistan, the sport's return to the Olympic and the growing influence of Indian cricket globally

‘I don't see India-Pakistan players shaking hands, as of now ... our tradition is *namaste*’

In his first major interaction since taking charge, BCCI president Mithun Manhas speaks about Jammu and Kashmir's historic Ranji Trophy triumph, the board's stance on bilateral cricket with Pakistan, and why protecting the domestic system remains non-negotiable. The conversation was moderated by Sandeep Dwivedi, National Sports Editor, *The Indian Express*

Given those factors, we are confident the value of the rights will continue to grow.

Shankar Narayan: Almost every year, Test matches in north India are scheduled in October or November despite an obvious pollution issue. Have any measures been taken to ensure avoiding this in the future?

There are a lot of factors that go into allocating matches. The BCCI broadly follows a rotation policy to ensure fair distribution across venues. We are also very careful about external factors — weather conditions, logistical requirements and pollution in northern regions during certain times of the year. We take these very seriously. We try to plan the schedule in a way that avoids hosting matches in such conditions, and we have done that in the past. If you look at the Ranji Trophy season, breaks have been deliberately created so that we play fewer matches in the north when conditions are bad — fog, smog, pollution — which would cause health issues.

Shankar Narayan: Grounds like Ahmedabad and Guwahati are getting Border-Gavaskar Trophy games but traditional venues like Wankhede and Eden Gardens haven't hosted Australia for a very long time...

It is the rotation policy. It is also about generating revenue. If you look at Ahmedabad, that's our biggest stadium and the BCCI benefits from that. If we generate a lot of revenue from one stadium and can accommodate more fans, why not? That has been done in consultation with our respective state associations.

ON THE CHANGE IN J&K TEAM

'Back in the day, there used to be an 8-8 quota for Jammu cricketers and those from the Kashmir valley. I never believed in it. For me, it doesn't matter which religion you follow. My religion is cricket'

Nihal Koshie: What is the BCCI's policy on India playing Pakistan? And if India plays Pakistan, will we see players shake hands?

The BCCI has always consistently maintained that any decision regarding bilateral series with Pakistan is subject to Government of India's policy. We fully respect and abide by that position. Any future engagements will entirely depend on the prevailing situation.

Nihal Koshie: What about handshakes?

I don't see it happening as of now. Though it's the prerogative of players — if they don't feel like doing it, they won't. As Indians, our tradition is to do namaste. We were never a hand-shaking nation.

Venkata Krishna B: How important is it to send a strong team to the 2028 Olympics?

I can talk about it from an organisational standpoint, because I don't get into selections as such. But I can assure you that we will leave no stone unturned in ensuring that India sends its strongest possible team to the 2028 Olympics. Proper planning and preparation will be put in place well in advance. It's about winning gold, not just participation. So we assure you that we aim to have the best team representing the country at that stage. And it's very important for us.

Venkata Krishna B: With the international calendar packed, is player fatigue becoming a concern?

Not really. Test cricket is something we are very mindful of. Though it is the selectors' job, we keep a watch on the load. There is a lot of cricket happening and that's why we don't allow our players to play foreign leagues. We also follow a rotation policy. So the team management is constantly in touch with the selection committee and that's how they operate. Players' fitness and mental health is of paramount importance to us.

Venkata Krishna B: Given recent Test setbacks against New Zealand and South Africa at home, what is being done to improve performance?

We always get back to the drawing board. We want more senior players to play domestic cricket — not just the one-day format but the days format too. We need preparatory camps before Test series like we used to have in the past — a 10-15 day camp before a series. Before the next series, you will get to see that.

Nitin Sharma: You played with Virat Kohli and Gautam Gambhir in Delhi. Any memories?

Well, I not just played with Virat, but with Gautam too — the Indian team coach. I had also coached them (laughs). So to comment on just them and not others won't make any sense. They are all equal to me.

ON WHY AHMEDABAD GETS BIG GAMES

'It is the rotation policy... also about generating revenue. Ahmedabad is our biggest stadium and BCCI benefits from that. If we generate a lot of revenue from one stadium and can accommodate more fans, why not?'

Sriram Veera: What made you choose Ajay Sharma as the J&K coach?

Ajay Sharma has been around since I started my cricket. I believe in him and have worked very closely with him. I understand how he operates. He's a demanding coach who knows the fine nuances of batting. We have been struggling with our batting — bowling has always been our strength. He's also very disciplined and firm. I'm very happy for him. He's got his due.

Nihal Koshie: Ajay Sharma is a Delhi cricketer and comes from a different culture. Did he take time to adjust?

Everything takes time. If you want to do something good, it takes time — *kharab karne ke liye do minute hi lagte hain*. (to spoil something it takes two minutes) It is all about understanding their point of view and where they were coming from. Coach and players need to gel. If they don't trust each other, players wouldn't talk about their faults. It's like going to a doctor. Unless you tell him what the problem is, he can't help. Or he will continue doing the tests and nothing will happen. It takes time. It was not about me or Ajay *bhai* or anyone — it was all about maximising their potential.

Sandeep Dwivedi: What has been the impact of the Ranji Trophy win beyond the sporting field in J&K? What does this win mean to the people of the region?

When we were playing the final, bazaars were empty as everyone was glued to their television sets. There was not a home where the final was not being watched. This win will help us not just in cricket but will be very beneficial for the youth as well. There is a lot of struggle here. Every boy and girl has a story. I think this win means something very special to us.

Now they've started believing that boys and girls from JK can move ahead in life because of cricket. Parents from remote areas are sending their children to cricket centres. Imagine, today we have a girl from Gurez who wants to be a trainer. Players from Ladakh, Kargil, Gurez, Chenab Valley, Poonch, Rajouri and border areas want to play cricket. It is a wave that has swept the whole of JK. Special credit goes to Jay *bhai* because he was the one man who believed that we could do it. Whatever we asked of him, he provided. And here we are, Ranji Trophy champions in 2026, only the 11th association to do so.

Sandeep Dwivedi: Has cricket been able to drop the hyphen that connected Jammu and Kashmir?

Back in the day, there used to be an 8-8 quota for Jammu cricketers and those from the Kashmir valley. I never believed in it. For me, it doesn't matter which religion you follow. My religion is cricket and that should come to the fore. Whenever I speak, I call it JK, never J&K.

Sandeep Dwivedi: India's presence in world cricket keeps spreading. Indian or Indian-origin cricket entrepreneurs own teams in most leagues around the world. Do you think Indian players also need to be allowed to play in these leagues?

It is a very pertinent question but there are a lot of factors. The international

cricketing calendar is extremely demanding, followed by a long domestic season and the high-intensity IPL. In addition, many states have their own T20 leagues, which means players are engaged in cricket almost throughout the year. Our focus is that the domestic system remains strong. This can be achieved only if our established players are playing with young talent in domestic leagues — they transfer their experience and that's how the system grows. So at this time it will be challenging to permit our players to participate in overseas T20 leagues. It is also about their mental and physical health and keeping them fresh whenever they play for India.

Mihir Vasavda: How can the BCCI improve the fan experience? There are complaints about ticket

availability, poor stadium conditions, unhygienic toilets and overpriced water at nearly every venue.

Enhancing the fan experience is a key priority. It is extremely important and we are actively working on it. Whenever incidents are reported, we look into them seriously and make amends. We are in constant dialogue with our member associations to identify gaps and implement improvements across stadiums. We are also in the process of appointing a professional agency to assess some of our major venues and provide detailed recommendations on areas that require attention.

Mihir Vasavda: Given what is happening with FIFA World Cup

ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

{ W E E K L Y C A P S U L E }

This diet cuts diabetes risk by 31%

A large Spanish study by the Universidad de Navarra revealed that a lower-calorie Mediterranean diet paired with exercise and lifestyle coaching dramatically reduced the risk of Type 2 diabetes. Participants who made lifestyle changes were 31 per cent less likely to develop the disease over six years. They also lost more weight and trimmed their waistlines compared to those following a standard Mediterranean diet. They lost more weight and reduced abdominal fat more effectively. The intervention group lost 3.3 kg and reduced waist circumference by 3.6 cm. The control group lost only 0.6 kg and trimmed waist size by 0.3 cm.



Kimchi can flush microplastics

Scientists at the National Research Council of Science and Technology in South Korea have discovered that a probiotic bacterium found in kimchi may help the body flush out tiny plastic particles before they can build up in organs. In lab tests, the kimchi-derived microbe clung tightly to nanoplastics even under conditions designed to mimic the human intestine, where other bacteria quickly lost their grip. The study adds to growing evidence that microbes in fermented foods may do more than support food production and digestion. They can interact with environmental pollutants inside the body.



How exercise trains your brain

Exercise may be training your brain just as much as your body. Researchers at the University of Pennsylvania discovered that certain brain cells stay highly active even after a workout ends, and those lingering signals appear to help the body build endurance over time. In experiments with mice, blocking these brain cells prevented improvements in stamina, even when the animals still exercised normally. Researchers hope the findings could eventually lead to new ways to help older adults remain active and assist people recovering from stroke or injury. The work may also benefit athletes looking to improve performance.



Study finds anti-ageing protein

Scientists have identified a protein that appears to put the brakes on the chronic inflammation linked to ageing. Older mice with boosted levels of the protein were stronger, more energetic, and had healthier bones than untreated mice. The study centered on tristetraprolin (TTP), an RNA binding protein that helps control inflammation by breaking down inflammatory signals before they can build up. As people age, TTP levels naturally decrease, especially in immune cells. That drop may allow inflammation to become more widespread throughout the body.



Watermelon for heart health

Studies suggest watermelon could be a hidden powerhouse for better heart health. Researchers found that people who eat watermelon tend to have higher-quality diets packed with more vitamins, fibre and antioxidants — while consuming less added sugar and saturated fat. Another study showed watermelon juice may help protect blood vessel function and support heart health. Researchers from Louisiana State University focussed on two naturally occurring watermelon compounds, L-citrulline and L-arginine, which are involved in nitric oxide production. It helps blood vessels relax and expand.



GETTYIMAGES

Warm nights disrupt the body's reset mechanism

Delhi's hot nights are becoming a health risk

Night temperatures are disrupting sleep and stressing the heart

Ankita Upadhyay

AT 2.30 AM, 42-year-old Neeraj Sharma woke up drenched in sweat in his East Delhi apartment. The fan was running at full speed and the AC was set at 24°C, but the room still felt suffocating. He drank water, splashed his face and tried going back to sleep. By morning, he had a pounding headache, fatigue and dizziness severe enough to force him to skip work. “My body never gets a chance to recover anymore,” he says.

Neeraj's experience is becoming increasingly common across Delhi this summer, where residents are not just battling punishing daytime temperatures but unusually warm nights — a phenomenon during which minimum temperatures remain significantly above normal, trapping heat in densely built urban areas long after sunset. Human beings are biologically designed to cool down at night. “During prolonged heat waves, survival is not only about avoiding the afternoon sun, it is also about ensuring the body can cool and recover overnight. During sleep, the body's core temperature drops, helping trigger deep, restorative sleep and allowing organs to recover from daytime stress. But when temperatures remain excessively high after dark, that natural cooling mechanism gets disrupted. Heat illness is not caused by temperature alone; it occurs when the body's natural cooling system can no longer keep pace with environmental stress,” says Dr Neeraj Nischal, professor of medicine, All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi. “We often focus on daytime temperatures but persistently warm nights may be equally important predictors of heat-related complications. People continue to experience heat stress even while resting,” he adds.

One of the earliest consequences is disturbed sleep. People often struggle to fall asleep, wake up repeatedly through the night or experience shallow sleep accompanied by sweating and discomfort. “Sleep deprivation caused by hot nights affects concentration, mood, productivity and the body's ability to tolerate heat the following day,” Dr Nischal says.

Researchers have increasingly linked elevated night-time temperatures to fatigue, irritability, impaired cognition and worsening mental stress. Repeated sleep disruption can also weaken immunity and reduce the body's resilience during prolonged heat waves.

Even while asleep, the body continues sweating in an attempt to cool itself. This leads to continuous loss of fluids and essential electrolytes such as sodium and potassium. “The human body depends on cooler nights to restore thermal balance. When night temperatures remain elevated, the body continues to sweat and lose fluids even during sleep, increasing the risk of dehydration by morning,” Dr Nischal explains.

The cardiovascular system comes under strain. To release excess heat, the body pushes more blood toward the skin surface, forcing the heart to work harder even during sleep. This additional stress can become dangerous for people with hypertension, heart disease, diabetes or kidney disorders. Your resting heart rate could go up by roughly 10 beats per minute for every 1°C rise in internal body temperature. As blood vessels widen to radiate heat, your BP could drop low. For those with pre-existing heart conditions, the combined stress of elevated temperatures, high humidity and poor sleep can trigger irregular heartbeats, heart failure or heart attacks.

Dr Nischal warns that some commonly prescribed medicines may further increase vulnerability. “People taking medications such as diuretics for hypertension may face a greater risk because these worsen dehydration. Such individuals may lose fluids overnight and begin the next day with an already reduced water balance.”

Children and the elderly remain among the most vulnerable groups. They may not recognise or communicate symptoms of heat stress early enough, while older adults often have a diminished ability to regulate body temperature through sweating. “By the time confusion, dizziness or reduced sweating appear, the condition may already be serious,” Dr Nischal says. His advisory: Maintain hydration through the evening, ensure ventilation indoors, wear loose cotton clothing, avoid heavy meals late at night, pre-cool rooms with blackout curtains and use cooling methods such as fans, cool showers or damp towels before sleep.

Rinku Ghosh

REMEMBER every patient I have lost and I have always put myself in their position, swapped their families with mine and visualised how they would react in similar conditions. And I have seen the good fight from ordinary patients, seen how their minds never give up till the end. Each of them has taught me more than just science — humanism,” says Dr Cyriac Abby Philips, the Kerala-based hepatologist, better known online as “The Liver Doc.” Few doctors in India inspire as much admiration and irritation in equal measure as him.

On social media, he has built a formidable reputation as a crusader of scientific medicine, dismantling wellness fads, calling out dubious supplements, questioning Ayurveda's unchecked claims and taking on an industry far larger than himself with the solidity of a data analyst and the aggression of a street fighter. Often considered a maverick, Dr Philips says, “On social media, you need to be loud to be heard so that real science has an audience. It's sad that what I say is what any doctor and man of science would say.” But in the real world, as a student of the classical history of medicine, he goes back to the original meaning of the word doctor — an instructor. And that's what he does by the patient's bedside, helping them and their families beat death, understand it, endure it and sometimes, even find dignity within it, stories of which have made up his new book, *The Liver Doctor: Stories of Love, Loss and Regeneration*.

That's why, despite being trained at the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences in Delhi, he chose to return to Kochi where he works at the Rajagiri Hospital so that he can save ordinary lives from what is becoming the top 10 causes of death nationwide — liver disease. Yet it is silent and very few understand it. “There is a huge challenge in medicine and healthcare today, both for doctors and patients. I call it the loss of the true heart of medicine, which is humanism. The heart of medicine is empathy, and that is what medical training is actually supposed to offer. Now medicine is mostly business. I want to teach people how to live life,” he says.

What modern medicine should be

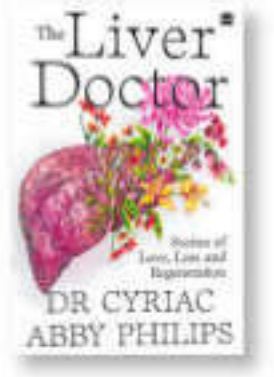
With the burden of healthcare being shouldered by the private sector rather than the public one and patients feeling like commodities, Dr Philips says he wants to reclaim that space where medicine feels the way it is supposed to feel — deeply caring, empathetic and compassionate. “There are very few diseases that doctors can truly cure. Infections are one example because we have antimicrobials. But beyond that, what can we cure completely? Most diseases we can only reverse, slow down, halt, manage, or improve life expectancy for. That is where the true practice of medicine shines. Treating a patient is not just diagnosing and prescribing medicines. It is about going on a journey with them. In my field, chronic liver disease patients stay with you for years — sometimes for life, until they die or undergo liver transplantation,” he says.

The second reason for writing was personal. “The book became a way of decompressing emotionally. As a doctor, one of the hardest things is understanding limits. Patients come with expectations, but there are limits to what medicine can do. Sometimes you know the patient is not going to survive. First, you have to accept that yourself, and then you have to help the patient and family accept it too. That is how clinical medicine works for many diseases. For me, this book became a way to depersonalize all those

emotions I had internalised over the years,” says Dr Philips.

Why does the liver seem fickle?

Is sudden deterioration something unique to the liver? Someone can seem perfectly healthy and yet collapse suddenly. “This is what we call acute liver failure — where a perfectly healthy person suddenly develops severe liver failure and may even require ventilation support. Because the liver is the most resilient organ, has huge functional reserves or backup tissue and masks early distress, a person seems healthy until vital functions — detoxification and blood clotting — collapse, triggering sudden, life-threatening complications. This is triggered by sudden damage rather than long-term wear and tear and can be a result of drug toxicity, viral infections and autoimmune disorders,” says Dr Philips.



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EVERYONE SHOULD test for Hepatitis B and C at least once in their lifetime. North India has a high burden of chronic Hepatitis B. While Hepatitis B is preventable

‘Will question certain things’: Pollard on captaincy issue

Express News Service
Mumbai, May 24

THE MUMBAI Indians (MI) ended a forgettable IPL 2026 campaign with a 30-run loss to Rajasthan Royals - their 10th of the season - and finished ninth on the points table, with eight points in 14 matches. One of the major talking points was Hardik Pandya's captaincy and his impact on the field.

Batting coach Kieron Pollard backed the 32-year-old's captaincy skills, despite a hard season, adding that he tried what he could with the resources he had.

"From a leadership perspective on Hardik, yes, it has not gone maybe as well as he would have wanted as an individual. It might not have gone as we would have wanted as a management staff. But one thing you know is that we have tried each and everything to give the best opportunity to lead the franchise, to do well," Pollard said at the post-match presser.

Collective perspective

"Again, no one is going to sit here and put blame or point fingers. I think when you lose, especially, you have to look at it from a collective perspective. So you win some, you lose some. But at the end of the day, I will question certain things. He was trying. We all were trying. And it just didn't workout for us. So just as previously answered, again, you sit, you talk, and see what's best. Never know what's going to happen. For us, let's just lick our wounds in the meantime and hopefully come back stronger in 12 months' time," he added.

The 39-year-old admitted that IPL 2026 had been a campaign of "what-ifs" for MI, and the lack of consistent wins pegged them back this season.

"To be honest, it has been a season of what-ifs and overall disappointing for all of us. Everyone would have felt the same way. We weren't able to string together wins and use the momentum when we got it. At the end of it, when you look at it rationally, I think we got the position that we deserved in terms of the type of cricket that we played throughout the tournament," Pollard said.

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE

Archer on target with bat and ball, Royals take last playoff spot

England pacer's cameo late in the RR innings takes them to 200-plus score, before he sets MI back with the ball

SYNOPSIS: Jofra Archer's all-round exploits help Royals beat MI by 30 runs and qualify for IPL Playoffs.

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, May 24

THE MUMBAI Indians-Rajasthan Royals clash on Sunday had not just the attention of a packed Wankhede Stadium, but also the Punjab Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders camps. In the end, RR, helped by a collective batting effort and Jofra Archer's brilliance, prevailed to knock the other two contenders out of the playoff race.

All-round impact

After many seasons of failing to hit his straps, Archer has bowled with renewed venom in IPL 2026, and came into the final league match in excellent rhythm.

The strong crowd of schoolkids raised their voices to the highest decibel level when Rohit Sharma made his way to the centre, and his duel with Archer was the one to watch out for. The pacer got out-swing on his first two balls and then, off the fourth, got one to move away sharply.

Rohit played down the wrong line, the ball took the edge, and Dhruv Jurel held a fine catch.

In a must-win game, it was the start RR needed after putting up 205 batting first, and one MI didn't. After his Power-play impact, Archer returned in the 16th over to dismiss a rampaging Hardik Pandya and dent MI's chances in the chase.

The bowling exploits were preceded by a pivotal batting effort. RR had the option of

using their impact sub when Jurel fell in the 13th over. Yet, they sent Archer in at number seven, and his 32 off 15 balls was the cameo that gave them the impetus and eventually carried them to a 200+ score.

Surya comes good

After the highs of 2025, Suryakumar Yadav endured a disappointing IPL 2026 campaign, but had a last chance to make a significant contribution on Sunday. The right-hander walked in with MI in early strife at 18/2, and the first signs that he could make a difference came in the fourth over, when he swatted Nandre Burger for six over backward square leg.

The youthful crowd would have wanted to see more of such shots, except that with wickets falling at the other end, Surya had no option but to mix caution with aggression efficiently. With Will Jacks and later Hardik Pandya for company, he went about his business, taking singles and twos with the odd boundary in between.

Surya struck Ravindra Jadeja for sixes in the ninth and 10th overs before taking on Yash Raj Punja to keep MI in the chase. But Jacks' dismissal in the 12th over increased the pressure on him to stay till the end.

His 50 came in the 14th over off 32 balls, and he had ensured that the asking rate and the current rate were at par. Pandya's explosion at the other end helped Surya's cause, and with 59 needed in five overs, MI held the upper hand.

Yet, Archer's final over in which he claimed the MI skipper pegged back the chase, and when Surya fell for 60 in the 18th over, the game was almost done. But at the



Jofra Archer picked up Rohit Sharma and Hardik Pandya's wickets in the crucial win for Royals. CREIMAS/BCCI

●IPL table

Teams	M	W	L	P	NRR
RCB (Q)	14	9	5	18	0.783
GT (Q)	14	9	5	18	0.695
SRH (Q)	14	9	5	18	0.524
RR (Q)	14	8	6	16	0.189
PBKS	14	7	6	15	0.309
DC	14	7	7	14	-0.651
KKR	14	6	7	13	-0.147
CSK	14	6	8	12	-0.345
MI	14	4	10	8	-0.584
LSG	14	4	10	8	-0.740

end of a tough season, he had offered a glimpse of what he could still do right at the end.

Sooryavanshi trap

For the majority of the IPL, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi had shown a high proficiency in scoring runs on the legside, with the arc between long-on and square leg his favoured

After many seasons of failing to hit his straps, Archer has bowled with renewed venom in IPL 2026, and came into the final league match in excellent rhythm.

zone. On Sunday, he found himself in unfamiliar territory.

MI turned up in the afternoon heat at the Wankhede Stadium and set a trap. Six fielders were placed on the off-side and three on the inside. The plan was clear: Nothing on the middle or leg, which would allow him to swing into his arc.

Deepak Chahar floated one on off stump on the first ball the teenager faced. Soorya-

vanshi went for it, almost instinctively. Jacks, at the cover boundary, pulled off a near-spectacular catch. That delivery was the sign of things to come. Neither the pacers nor the spinners offered anything on middle or leg for the teenager, who was itching to get going.

Eventually, the temptation got the better of him. Chahar, bowling his third straight over, delivered a full ball, and got Sooryavanshi to go for the big hit. The mistimed shot landed in Naman Dhir's hands. The left-hander had fallen for four, and the trap offered others a cue on how to contain him in the playoffs.

BRIEF SCORES: Rajasthan Royals 205/8 in 20 overs (Dhruv Jurel 38, Jofra Archer 32; Shardul Thakur 2/41) beat Mumbai Indians 175/9 in 20 overs (Suryakumar Yadav 60; Archer 3/17) by 30 runs.

Rahul's 60 helps DC overcome KKR in final IPL league game

Sayak Dutta
Kolkata, May 24

AS SOON as the Rajasthan Royals defeated Mumbai Indians at Wankhede, the lustre of Kolkata Knight Riders' match vs Delhi Capitals was mostly lost as the Indian Premier League group stage ended in a rather anticlimactic manner with the hosts at Eden Gardens ending their campaign on a whimper, losing to the Capitals by 40 runs.

Contrasting fortunes

Kuldeep Yadav outdid Kolkata's spin twins Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine as the Delhi twerker took 3 wickets at critical junctures, breaking the back of Kolkata's chase and ending with figures of 3/29. Com-

pared to him, Narine finished with 1/38 while Varun could only muster 1/35 in a match of contrasts.

Kolkata were off to a decent start with Finn Allen dazzling the crowd, scything through the decorated Mitchell Starc with a 4 off his first over and then a straight 80m six over the bowler's head followed by a four in the Aussie's second over. Auqib Nabi was also met with the same disdain as Allen placed him for a four through wide mid-on even as skipper Ajinkya Rahane slammed him over the ropes for back-to-back sixes with the KKR openers cutting the Delhi bowling lineup to shreds.

But the party did not last long as Allen completely missed a hoick, leading to Lungi Ngidi rat-

ting his stumps for 20 runs. New man Manish Pandey got a six of his own in the 6th over as the Knights managed 55/1 in the powerplay. The KKR batters refused to let up with both Pandey and Rahane finding sixes off DC skipper Axar Patel in the 8th over. The hell for leather approach ultimately cost the Knights as Pandey was caught in the deep by Starc off Ngidi for 25.

Kuldeep would then account for Cameron Green who perfectly found David Miller in the deep for 2. Rahane, meanwhile, continued chipping away at the target, completing his half century in the 11th over. The Kolkata captain departed a couple of overs later as Kuldeep snapped him up for 63 runs. Rinku Singh lasted just one ball, holing out to



KL Rahul. CREIMAS/BCCI

Tristan Stubbs in the deep for 0 as Kuldeep notched up his third. Axar then put KKR 6 down cleaning up Tejasvi Dahiya for 1 while a bullet throw from Ashu-

tosh Sharma from the deep found Rovman Powell well out of his crease. With their last ray of hopes snuffed out, Kolkata finished with 163 with Ngidi also finishing with 3 wickets.

Rahul stars with 60

Skipper Rahane sent the Delhi contingent to bat first with the aim of chasing down the target in a quick manner. However, their bowlers were initially left wanting with Abishek Porel and KL Rahul getting off to a fast start. After Anukul Roy was taken for 10 in the first over, Green was slammed for 14 runs in the third. It went from bad to worse for the Knights after Porel was dropped at 23 by wicket-keeper Dahiya.

It didn't do much damage in

the long run though as the economical Saurabh Dubey forced Porel to nick behind to the keeper for 22 runs.

Rahul, however, continued undeterred, taking Narine apart with a straight six and a four before going after Kartik Tyagi in the 11th over. The Karnataka batter continued to up the ante but a dragged shot failed to get the required distance as he holed out to Powell in the deep off Anukul for 60 runs. Delhi ended up finishing their innings on a high with Miller (28) and Ashutosh (18*) pulling off some lusty blows at the death as they posted a target of 203/5.

BRIEF SCORES: DC (KL Rahul 60; Saurabh Dubey 2/28) defeated KKR (Ajinkya Rahane 63; Kuldeep Yadav 3/29)

How Punjab went from favourites to team in freefall

Sandip G
New Delhi, May 24

SIX GAMES of feast; six games of famine. A last-ditch resurrection bid; prayers mumbled, chewed nails, split hairs and an agonising wait; few teams have suffered emotional extremities as Punjab Kings this season. From the golden favourites to shocking losers, they are both a cautionary tale as well as an example of the league's vicissitudes.

Much of their fate was self-inflicted. Dropped catches would haunt them; they spilled 16 off 56 opportunities, which is a dramatic rate in a format with threadbare margins. Add missed stumpings, and Punjab would curse their leaden hands and betraying eyes. Some of them proved costly (like those of Ishan Kishan and Heinrich Klaasen in Hyderabad), but even the non-expensive ones generated a negative fatalistic vibe, killed momentum and sowed doubts in fielders. Coach Ricky Ponting, one of the finest all-round fielders of all time, likened it to a virus that spread throughout their camp. Skipper Shreyas Iyer termed it the "biggest setback of the season."

The culprit was not just one fielder, though Shashank Singh would feel the guiltiest. He let five rather straightforward catches slip through his palms. So did Cooper Connolly and Lockie Ferguson, among others. It was not always technical flaws, which at this level coaches would easily identify and address. It was not always the lighting patterns in a particular stadium, for they dropped catches in different matches. It was not always the wind and the elements. It remained a mystery, or a spooking. Ponting struggled for an answer. "I don't know why, the boys have worked exceptionally hard."

He empathised with Shashank. "You know, poor old Shashank there. It just looks like the ball is following him around everywhere he goes."

But catching was not the only factor either. Punjab Kings had the deeper fundamental flaw of an imbalanced bowling group. Pinning the hopes on a lone spinner, Yuzvendra Chahal - even if he is the highest wicket-taker in IPL history - was myopic. Chahal was a diminished force, losing his once-immaculate control of drop, a yard or two of pace that made him unpredictable, and the precision that induced mistakes from batsmen.

Lack of quality

Spinners, especially the leg-spinners, prosper when pampered. The management was cynical towards both Chahal as well as spinners in general. Chahal included, Punjab's spinners bowled only 59 overs in the entire season, the fewest among all teams. On slow, dry surfaces, they missed a tweaker who could stifle and frustrate batsmen.

The overwhelming trust on



Ricky Ponting's Punjab was let down by a poor battery of bowling options in this season of the IPL. CREIMAS/BCCI

seamers turned counter-intuitive. Nor did they possess a high-class pack like Gujarat Titans either. Arshdeep Singh's form tailed off towards the end; Marco Jansen and Vijayakumar Vyshak were erratic. Lockie Ferguson lost trust after early drubbings. The wickets chart made for despicable reading. No bowler took more than 14 wickets; only two reached double figures; nine of the 12 bowlers they employed bled more than 10 runs an over. The most economical, left-arm spinner Harpreet Brar (7.50), was limited to merely two games. Three times they failed to defend 200-plus totals. The scales of T20s might tilt towards the batsmen, but a team can't invest all their capital on them. Serving up batting paradises benefited rival sides too.

Last-over troubles

Their batsmen touched or crossed 200 10 times, but there were days their most destructive game deserted them. The batting bubble burst at times, especially during their win-less phase. Like when chasing RCB's 222 in Dharamshala, or folding up for 163/9 against GT. The latter game would haunt them, as Marcus Stoinis failed to defend eight runs in the last over. Similarly against Rajasthan Royals, they couldn't guard 35 runs in three overs. They lost three games in the last over, reflecting their inability to close out matches, a glitch stemming from their measly options of death-over experts.

Sometimes, the margins were negligible yet significant. Ponting would summarise, "We've just been a little bit off and they're small things. They're one or two balls or they're an over here and there. Quite conceivably, we could have won another three or four games, but we've only got ourselves to blame for that."

Rest assured that Ponting and the coaching crew would scan for quality bowlers before the next season. Shifting the home base to Dharamshala for the crucial business end impeded their revival hopes.

But their capitation also captures the transient nature of the format, the reality that all it would sometimes take is one bad day to change the season around, or one fundamental flaw to sully a season

Underdog Zverev starts strong at Roland Garros

Reuters
Paris, May 24

FRENCH OPEN dark horse Alexander Zverev started his Roland Garros campaign with a meticulous 6-3 6-4 6-2 first-round demolition of France's Benjamin Bonzi in searing heat on Sunday. The 2024 runner-up and three-times semi-finalist, who is chasing his maiden Grand Slam title, never allowed the world number 95 into the contest on court Philippe Charrier as he set up a second-round meeting with Tomas Machac of the Czech Republic.

"Very good start to the tournament, it's always good to start with a win in straight sets especially against Benjamin who can be a tricky opponent," the German second seed said. The tournament started under blazing sun as fans in Panama hats streamed into Roland Garros, which felt more like the Riviera

than claycourt grind as alleys echoed with a violin rendition of soft-rock staples.

Russian Karen Khachanov, seeded 13, dispatched French hope Arthur Gea on Court Suzanne Lenglen before 11th seed Swiss Belinda Bencic downed Sinja Kraus of Austria. Hours after a Russian missile landed near her family home in Kyiv in Ukraine, Marta Kostyuk took to the court to dispatch Oksana Selekhmeteva 6-2 6-3. The 23-year-old, who advanced to the second round, said she was overwhelmed with anxiety.

Key results

MEN'S: Karen Khachanov beat Arthur Gea 6-3, 7-6(3), 6-0; (2) Alexander Zverev beat Benjamin Bonzi 6-3, 6-4, 6-2 **WOMEN'S:** Hailey Baptiste beat Barbora Krejickova 6-7(7), 7-6(6), 6-2; Solana Sierra beat Emma Radacanu 6-0 7-6(4).

●NORWAY CHESS

Amit Kamath
Oslo, May 24

A YEAR after Magnus Carlsen made global headlines by smashing his fist on the table after losing to Gukesh Dommaraju at Norway Chess, both players will square off again... in a library. The Deichman Bjørvika, Oslo's main public library that is said to house about half a million books in a sprawling six-storey facility, will play host to this year's edition.

The playing hall for this year's event has been set up on the third floor with tall rows of books from the music section flanking the tables and about a hundred seats set up for ticket-buying fans. All through the day on Sunday, locals trickled in in small batches to click pictures of the unique playing arena where the nation's favourite chess-playing son will take on some of the world's best players in classical chess.

Norway Chess is one of the rare occasions when Carlsen plays the longest format of the game. With the 35-year-old now gravitating towards faster time controls such as rapid and blitz, besides newer variants like Free-style Chess and the upcoming Total Chess World Championship, there is intrigue over when one of the greatest players in the world decides to stop playing classical chess altogether.

Norway has been in such a thrall of Carlsen's exploits that a couple of years ago, there were reports that around 20 percent of the country's five million population tuned in to watch him play at the year-ending World Rapid and Blitz Championship. Besides Carlsen and Gukesh, this year's tournament will feature R Praggnanandhaa, Vincent Keymer (who's in hot form having just won the Super Chess Classic Romania tournament two days ago), Wesley So and Alireza Firouzja.



The Deichman Bjørvika, Oslo's main public library, will host the 2026 edition of Norway Chess. AMIT KAMATH

But most of the focus at this year's edition will be on the two Carlsen-Gukesh encounters, a battle between the reigning world champion and the World No.1, who could have still been on the throne had he not lost interest in classical chess.

Course-correction

In the 18 months since Gukesh became the youngest world champion in chess history, the conversation has been dominated by his lack of form. The 19-year-old has not won any tournament since his greatest moment on the chessboard in

December 2024. Recognising that he was in need of urgent course correction, Gukesh reduced his tournament load earlier this year by skipping a few Grand Chess Tour events that he was originally scheduled to play.

"My performance in the last few events has been quite disappointing," Gukesh wrote on social media while announcing his decision two months back. "In order to find my best form, my team and I have decided that I should compete with slightly less intensity over the next few months. Consequently, we feel it is in my best interest to skip long events away from home to allow for more dedicated training time."

Carlsen has been among the former world champions who have been unsparing in their criticism of the incumbent.

Only last month, when asked to weigh in on the upcoming world championship between Gukesh and Javokhir Sindarov,

Carlsen had quipped: "Gukesh has very obvious weaknesses when it comes to his understanding." This could provide Gukesh added motivation when he faces Carlsen in classical chess, that too at his home.

Last year's victory over Carlsen - which had led to the infamous fist smash - too had come in similar circumstances. As the Indian prodigy's long-time coach Grzegorz Gajewski had told *The Indian Express* right after the famous win: "As a world champion, Gukesh keeps facing these comments, 'ok, you're the world champion only because Magnus didn't play.' You try not to hear those comments. But then you lose to him, and then you lose to him again, and that's not even a bit pleasant. Now that Gukesh has beaten him, I hope this is going to give him some credit. And a lot of confidence."

(THE WRITER IS IN NORWAY AT THE INVITATION OF NORWAY CHESS)

FEDERATION CUP ATHLETICS

How Tejaswin engineered a 8,000-point decathlon

Speed gains, tactical reinvention, moving back to US and high jump peak of 2.25m power landmark show

Prithish Raj
Ranchi, May 24

ON A night of historic results, Tejaswin Shankar ran his heart out in 1500m, the last event of Decathlon and became the first Indian to cross the coveted 8000 points mark.

Tejaswin, who transitioned from high jump to combined events, is in the fourth year of doing Decathlon but the climb to this mountain of 8000 points started back in 2019 when he made a bet with his University buddy, Aaron Booth.

“Yes, you can say that my path for 8000 points started way back before I transitioned to Decathlon. Me and Booth would compete with each other in different events as part of fall tests during the school. I would always think what is special about Decathlon, I can also do it. But when I started doing it, I realized it is much more grueling and requires every bit of human ability to do combined events,” Tejaswin told *The Indian Express*.

Tejaswin, who competed in his first Decathlon in 2022 and scored 7592 points, is the 10th Asian ever to score over 8,000 points and ranks seventh on the continent’s all-time decathlon list.

Conquering Mt 8,000

After making his own plans and working on improving the national record in 2025, Tejaswin decided to move back to the US as a teaching assistant and started training under Kip Janvrin, an American coach with 26 Decathlons over 8000 points. “I was over analysing by sitting here and just doing sports. During my NCAA days, I used to do college and then do sports that would keep me fresh. I needed distraction and studying was that for me. So on advice of my wife Siddhi, I decided to move back to the US as a teaching assistant and started my masters in Kinesiology,” said Tejaswin.

After moving to the US, Tejaswin started training under Kip and the first thing they worked on was speed improvement.

In Ranchi, Tejaswin recorded four personal bests (100m, Long Jump, 400m and 1500m) but had sub par performances in Javelin Throw and Shot Put.

“100m is the event that sets the tone for a Decathlete. It’s the first event and if you do well, you carry that confidence and momentum to Long Jump, which is again about speed. When I did 10.59s at San Angelo earlier this year, it made me believe that I can improve in the 100m,” said Tejaswin.

When he started training under Kip, the coach told him to improve his speed so a lot of things could improve automatically.

“Kip told me that you’re an explosive guy but not crazy fast. If you improve your speed, it can improve a lot of your events as speed is the fundamental of events like Long Jump and Javelin,” said Tejaswin.

Tejaswin recorded a personal best of 10.77s in 100m and then went on to record another personal best of 7.67m in Long Jump.

“All the acceleration training done in the US came into play as I got the 100m PB and it set the tone. Long jump is also about speed as I don’t have a technique. I just run and jump. I carried the confidence from 100m to Long Jump and Siddhi (a 100m sprinter herself) told me that you need to move two-three steps back from the board as you are running really fast on the runway, that’s when I realised that I am in really good shape today,” said Tejaswin.

Tejaswin, who transitioned from High Jump to Decathlon, always uses his strength in the event to score more points. In the last event of the first day, Tejaswin jumped 2.25m and became only the sixth Decathlete



Tejaswin Shankar moved to a training base in US and the first thing he worked on was his speed. EXPRESS

in history to touch the mark in high jump. “It felt pretty special that I’m only the sixth Decathlete to touch the 2.25m mark in high jump. It is my strong event which always helps me,” said Tejaswin.

In the other events of the day, Shot Put (13.31m) and 400m (48.29s), Tejaswin did decently to score a mammoth 4511 points on Day one and set himself on course of 8000 points.

Unpredictable Day 2

While his 4511 points were historic, the focus was on the second day where usually the Decathletes falter.

Tejaswin started with a good hurdles race clocking 14.23s but had a below par show in Discus Throw with 37.90m. “I wanted to throw 40m in Discus Throw as I believe there is an improvement round the corner in this event. I was doing good in practice but it just didn’t come out at that time,” he said.

The third event of the day was Pole Vault, an event which can be a nightmare for any Decathlete given the technicalities involved in the event and the delay in the event due to technical issues added more agony to it. Also, at the end of it, Tejaswin suffered a nasty fall that resulted in him getting a bandage on the knee.

“I’m extremely happy with the 4.20m in the Pole Vault.

This is not the first time I fell in PV. Earlier in one of the competitions, I fell off the mat and almost suffered a concussion,” said Tejaswin. “Another issue was the poles were too small to carry my weight. I usually vault with bigger poles but I didn’t have them here and the poles here were small to support my frame as I am a big guy,” he chuckled.

While his performance in PV was below his personal best, it didn’t really affect him. It was the poor throw in Javelin that slightly cast doubts on the 8000 points target. “I had the mindset of 70m in Javelin and did well on the runway also but the throw didn’t come only. I had two options after that- either sulk on the result or focus on 1500m,” said Tejaswin.

All the calculators came out as he was placed at 7306 points after nine events.

“After the calculations I realised that I need to execute my 1500m plan and keep the body running. In 1500m, the fatigue can hit at the third lap and your body can shut down. It has happened to me in the past also,” said Tejaswin.

As the calculators got clicking and the pressure mounted, Tejaswin knew the final 1500m would decide everything. He dug deep, kept his rhythm, and didn’t let fatigue hit him crossing the finish line knowing that he had made history.

Spurs survive, Man City lose coach’s finale

• EPL Top 5

CLUB	P	W	D	L	GD	PTS
Arsenal	38	26	7	5	44	85
M City	38	23	9	6	42	78
M Utd	38	20	11	7	19	71
A Villa	38	19	8	11	7	65
L’pool	38	17	9	12	10	60

Reuters

London, May 24

TOTTENHAM HOTSPUR salvaged their Premier League status in the nick of time as Joao Palhinha’s first-half goal earned a 1-0 home victory against Everton on Sunday.

Only an 11th home league defeat of a miserable season could have sent Tottenham down for the first time since 1977, but Palhinha’s 43rd-minute effort erased that nightmare scenario.

It meant West Ham United’s 3-0 win over Leeds United was in vain as Tottenham finished 17th on 41 points, two points ahead of their London rivals who were relegated.

Tottenham’s victory completed an escape mission led by Roberto de Zerbi who has rejuvenated the team since taking charge little more than a month ago with Spurs deep in trouble. Meanwhile, Manchester City lost 2-1 to Aston Villa but their fans were less focused on the scoreboard then in an emotional farewell to Pep Guardiola after a decade in charge.

There was little riding on the outcome of their final game of the Premier League season, with City already assured of second, seven points behind champions Arsenal, who beat Crystal Palace 2-1.

Manchester United beat Brighton 3-0.

‘Slept whole day, got up, came to stadium, broke national record’: Gurindervir

Prithish Raj
Ranchi, May 24

GURINDERVIR SINGH, India’s fastest man, has captured the imagination of the nation with a blazing run of 10.09s at the Federation Cup on Saturday.

In an exclusive interview with *The Indian Express*, he opened up about his struggles last year, the significance of his run, and what comes next for him. Excerpts:

Do you hope to inspire more youth to take up athletics given that Punjab is one of the states with a major drug problem?

It might have an impact on the next generation but not on the ones who are already involved in it (drugs). The ones who are involved don’t even know who Gurindervir Singh is, where Ranchi is or what Athletics is. But I think this race can tell the next generation which path to choose.

Punjab is known for producing throwers in recent years and quarter-milers back in history. What does it mean to be a sprinter from Punjab?

Earlier, there were throwers. There were 400m runners.



Gurindervir Singh became the first Indian to break the 10.1-second barrier in the 100m, PTI

They used to choose throw events more. Now, I have chosen to run 100m, 200m and I think people will look at me and say that if he will do it, I’ll also do it.

How many reels have you seen since last night since you were not allowed to touch the phone day before?

I have been seeing my reels only. Every second or third reel is about me. It feels good that the whole nation is talking about me. It will feel good for five days and then back to the same grind of training.

You broke the national record the day before also but Animesh quickly reclaimed it. How did you feel about that?

I was happy for Animesh

• Pole vault NR broken

DEV KUMAR Meena and Kuldeep Kumar both lowered the national record with identical efforts of 5.45m. However, Meena won the gold on countback. The previous record, 5.41m, was set recently by Kuldeep. Long jumper Murali Sreeshankar won the gold with a jump of 8.08m. PTI

and didn’t stress myself. I was in my full flow. I did my stretching and slept for four hours at night and then again slept the whole day. Got up, came to the stadium and broke the national record.

During my under-16 days, there were many over-age boys competing and I used to fear them. My mamaji said, “*Sher eko hi hunda jungle vich, baki-riyan bahut firdi, hun tu sher banke khel.*” (There is only one lion in the jungle while there are a lot of goats, you are the lion).

This is not the first time that you broke the national record. You did it last year but after that you struggled, what happened?

Someone said something about my appearance and that too, to my face. I was disturbed

The Guardiola decade: How Pep rewired English football

Sandip G
New Delhi, May 24

TEN YEARS is too short to be called an era, but Pep Guardiola’s decade with English football is an era unto its own. Ten years of stacking trophies, of varied sizes, shapes and values; ten years of building an identity and heritage for a club that had languished in the shadows of the more historic institution in the neighbourhood, and ten years of refashioning the ideals and values, methods and style of the English game.

He would be immortalised as the greatest Manchester City manager, as one of the greatest of the league, but his biggest legacy is that he changed the footballing mentality of a stubborn nation that claims to have discovered the game. He found the league in English and left it Guardiola-esque.

To call him a supreme tactician would be to limit his aura to the numerous innovations and inventions he produced with various iterations of City; to belittle the supreme man-manager he was, in how he coaxed his men to buy his unusual theorems; to disregard the revolutionary he was, in how he burst the physicality myth in England with his short, small and twinkle-toed footballers. Guardiola is an unrepeatable footballing life, a blend of all the greatest managers that had strived and succeeded on English shores and made it arguably the most competitive in the world.

If Alex Ferguson was the colossus team-builder, Arsene Wenger the aesthete, Jurgen Klopp the radical, Jose Mourinho the shape-shifter; Guardiola was all and more, perhaps outdoing them all. He was everything that English foot-



Pep Guardiola reacts during his final match in charge of Manchester City. AP

ball had been in the last ten years; and he would be everything that English football would be in the next decade, from style and tactics to the very length of grass they play on these days.

To pinpoint a singular narrative thread that captures Guardiolsmo is difficult. Arguably, it is how he tore up the prevailing concepts of English football and rewrote them. After City finished 15 points adrift of champions Leicester City in the first season under him; the lack of physicality in the midfield was debated and perceived as the biggest stumbling block between him and glory. Next year, he added even shorter players who became champions touching the century mark.

He defended the crown next year, and in the next eight years built a dynasty that was as indomitable as Ferguson’s. Every team now plays from the back, everyone wants ball-playing defenders, craves for pass-metronomes, demands inverted full-backs, and once-upon-a-time false nines.

But when every other manager was busy learning from Guardiola, Guardiola was busy unlearning himself, challenging his core ideas, tweaking and tinkering his methods to suit the ever evolving game, driven by a quest to think ahead of the pack. The man that sculpted the greatest false nines of all time in Barcelona, Lionel Messi, chiselled the most destructive conventional nines of this milieu. Erling Haaland. The man that installed midfielders at the heart of the team once, then thrust the creativity keys to the men on the wings. He who made goalkeepers with ball control fashionable purchased a classic shot stopper in his end days. Where once he fixated over control and possession, he began to invest in individual quality. He adapted to the English game too, especially in realising the importance of the second ball after the first season.

At the heart of Guardiola is perhaps not a tactician or a romantic, but a student of the game, aware of the game’s infinite possibilities, football as a game of chess in hurry.

Perhaps, his departure is just a physical one. He will lurk invisibly in boardrooms and on the playing field through his ideas and methods, from the Premier League to Sunday Leagues. If Guardiola were to watch a game, any game in any tier of the country, he would be surprised at how he can see shades of himself in other managers, in their fundamentals and sensibilities, in how they conduct the play, in how they think about the game.

English football would miss Guardiola, but what he embodied would live through a generation of managers he had influenced and groomed.



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